

2 B O O K S I N 1

CHESS FOR BEGINNERS

*Chess for beginners
+
Chess openings for beginners*



BLAKE WHITE

2 books in 1

chess for beginners

The Definitive Step by Step Guide
To Understand The Essential Rules
And Discover the Best Tactics and Strategies.
Start Playing Today!

+

chess openings for beginners

The Ultimate And Definitive Guide To Learn Chess Board
Rules And Start Playing With The Best Tactics and
Efficient Strategies.

Blake White

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PART 1

chess for beginners

The Definitive Step by Step Guide
To Understand The Essential Rules
And Discover the Best Tactics and Strategies.
Start Playing Today!

Introduction

Chess is the perfect game to exercise your mind. It helps increase concentration and develop crucial cognitive abilities, such as strategic planning, pattern recognition, and critical thinking.

Also, learning the art of playing chess enhances your focus and ability to analyze situations more effectively and rationally and learn how to eliminate distractions.

It is a very self-motivating exercise, and for the last 20 years, it has been my favorite board game. I've been reading, exercising until late at night, playing against all kinds of opponents, and I still find so much happiness and satisfaction in every single win.

This is why I've decided to share the most important information about this beautiful game with you, hoping to help you start a journey as meaningful as mine.

The great acceptance of my first book, "Chess Openings for Beginners" made me realize that so many people worldwide are willing to learn and understand how to play chess. With this second publication, I want to disclose the essential strategies, tactics, and techniques to play all the different game stages effectively.

And, once again, I will do it in a very easy way... because all of us can become great (well, at least good) chess players and enjoy this timeless game. And if you feel anxious about getting started, thinking chess is a game for exceptionally smart people only, please trust me when I say that this is not true. Reading different kinds of publications and (even more important!) practicing, you can become an expert too.

So, find some time to dedicate to yourself and, with this book in your hands, get ready to discover the most important secrets of the chessboard.

Playing chess is a life-changing experience, and I am honored you have decided to share it with me.

So, shall we begin?

The history of Chess

First of all, let's briefly talk about the history of the game.

Because you might have just discovered it (maybe watching a Netflix show?), but chess dates back more than 1500 years. It is believed to have originated in India in the 6th century AD, even though some historians consider its origins more likely to go back to China.

To this day, most of the evidence points to the fact that chess started in India, where it was called "Chaturanga," a word that translates from the four military divisions: cavalry, chariotry, infantry, and elephantry.

These same forms have evolved into the well-known pieces knight, rook, pawn, and bishop in modern chess.

The Chaturanga game later spread to Persia, the Muslim world, and finally reached Southern European countries.

In the 15th century, modern chess started evolving in Europe: this period was generally referred to as the "Romantic Chess Era."

In the 1800s, winning the game wasn't the most crucial thing: the style was what really mattered. This is why in this century the game was characterized by clever combinations of moves, a daredevil attitude, and bold sacrifices. Long-term strategies weren't that important compared to creativity.

At the beginning of the 19th century, the "Dynamism Era" started, and chess became a part of tournaments and championships, celebrating the very first World Chess Championship in 1886.

In the 20th century, a chess federation was finally established, setting standard chess rules. FIDE (The International Chess Federation or World Chess Federation) is an international organization based in Switzerland that connects the different national chess federations and acts as the governing body of international chess competitions. It was officially founded in Paris on July 20, 1924.

In 1999, The International Chess Federation or World Chess Federation was recognized by the International Olympic Committee (IOC).

Beginning from the following century, the popularity of chess skyrocketed all over the globe.

And as they say... the rest is history.

Glossary of Chess Terms

As a beginner, the "language" of chess is one of the first thing you will need to learn to understand moves and strategies appropriately. So let me introduce you to the words you will always have to keep in mind. And don't forget to come back to these pages every time you find, in this book or in other publications, a term that you don't seem to remember.

My personal suggestion at the moment? Read the following terms once, but don't go crazy trying to memorize them immediately. Go on with the rest of the book, where you will find most of these expressions, and then reread them at the end, when everything will sound "familiar" and will make much more sense to you.

Activity: it defines the mobility of chess pieces or the freedom of movement. The active pieces have a better option of positively influencing the game's result than the inactive ones (blocked pieces, for example).

Advantage: It is typically based on piece positions on the chessboard and determines the potential of a certain color to win the game. When it looks like one color (or side) is ahead, then that side is said to have an advantage. A *clear advantage* should be enough to win if correctly played, while a *slight advantage* simply provides improved practical chances. When judging an advantage, complex criteria are taken into account: for example, the king's safety (one side's king is safer compared to the other one), activity (the enhanced influence of pieces), space (more room for maneuvering), material (more pawns or pieces), or other significant weaknesses.

Attack: An attempt to aggressively gain an advantage, with the primary aim to checkmate the opponent's king. A successful attack should force the other player to sacrifice pieces as a defense or accept weaknesses that lead to an advantage for the opponent's attack.

Blockade: This word defines a scenario in which the pawn advance is prevented by placing a piece directly in front of it.

Backward Pawn: a pawn that can no longer be protected by the rest of the pawns on its flanks, because they have already moved pretty far. It is a primary weakness since this pawn has more chances of getting attacked, and its defense requires pieces that are being used for other plans.

Bad Bishop: a bishop whose movement has been decreased, because of a friendly pawn positioned on the squares of the same colour.

Center: d4, d5, e4 and e5, the squares in the middle of the board.

Checkmate: the final goal of every chess game. A position in which the king cannot avoid capture.

Closed: the opposite of an open position (see below). The term defines a position in which the pawns block the movement of pieces around an area or the board.

Combination: a position's tactical exploitation (forced moves) that lead to the advantage of a player.

Cramped: A cramped position implies a lack of space. It prevents the pieces positioned behind pawns of the same color from moving freely. A cramped player isn't able to move from one side to another of the board as fast as the other one. This is one of the significant elements in assessing a chess position.

Development: the act of moving pieces from their original places to positions in which they can better help the player and positively affect the game.

Doubled Pawns: two pawns that sit on the same file and have the same color. It is generally considered a disadvantage because the pawns cannot defend one another.

Exchange: a series of closely related moves, usually sequential, in which the two opponents capture each other. All pieces except the king can be exchanged; the king instead can capture its opponent's pieces. Usually, this term is used when the pieces being exchanged have equal or similar value, in this case, we would be talking about an "even exchange." This is the case, for example, with a bishop and a knight, which generally have the same value. When two pieces of different value are exchanged, the player who captures the higher value piece is "up" or wins the exchange, while his or her opponent loses it or is "down."

Fianchetto: a strong chess position that implies developing the bishop on a long diagonal, g2, and/or b2 squares. In this position, the bishop can exert maximum pressure along its longest diagonal. In Italian, the word "fianco" means "flank".

File: the vertical (down and up) row of squares.

Fish: in chess, the word "Fish" refers to... a bad player!

Forced: a move or a set of moves needed to prevent a bad result.

Gambit: a material sacrifice that a player makes to gain some kind of compensation, like an advantage. It generally implies sacrificing a pawn or a minor piece in a complex and essential game phase. Just watch out: a very obvious material sacrifice for an apparent advantage is known as a combination; it is not a gambit.

Grandmaster: a highly rated and well-recognized chess player.

Horse: informal term, usually used by young players, that refers to a knight.

Howler: a bad move, also referred to as a blunder. A howler is a mistake that overlooked a very clear tactical response.

Line: the succession of squares, horizontally, vertically, or diagonally on the chessboard.

Mate: short version of checkmate (see above).

Material: the chess pieces. The player with better-valued pieces left to play has a material advantage.

Middle Game: the second phase of a chess game, the one that comes right after the opening and just before the end game. In this phase, pieces have finished developing or are almost complete, and many of them have been traded or captured as players start developing specific plans and strategies.

Open: a position in which pawns aren't blocking pieces, and they are free to move in certain parts or all of the board. This is the opposite of a closed position (see above).

Opening: the initial phase of a chess game, the one that comes before the middle and end game. In the opening, players try to develop their pieces as soon as possible, to gain space for their pieces to move around, and start bringing their king to safety.

Passed Pawn: an advantage in which the pawn's progress isn't blocked or guarded by the opponent's pawns.

Position: the arrangement of chess pieces. The player with a better placement of pieces counts on a positional advantage.

Promotion: When a pawn reaches the last rank, the player can "reward it" and replace it by choosing among a higher valued piece: a knight, a bishop, a rook, or a queen.

Queening a Pawn: promoting a pawn to a queen.

Rank: the horizontal (right to left) row of squares on the chessboard. All pawns start the game from the second rank.

Rating: the ability of a player, usually a numeric score.

Sacrifice: to lose pieces on purpose to gain a potential advantage.

Sealed Move: in the case of an adjourned game this is the way to secretly record the next move until the game is resumed.

Space: a chess position that enables better freedom of movement or more mobility for pieces positioned behind the pawns. When a player's position has more space, then the player has more freedom to move than his or her enemy and can quickly switch the game from one side of the board to another.

Smothered Mate: a checkmate with no escape because the player's own pieces are blocking its escape routes.

Stalemate: a game that ends in a draw because there are no legal moves left.

Study: a composed endgame position in which much thought and artful play is required. A position is generally referred to as a study when it is unusually artistic and complicated.

Sudden Death: the time duration in a game in which all left moves should be completed. The play rate in most tournaments is: 40 moves within 2 hours, 20 moves in 1 hour, and 30 minutes for the remainder of the game. And these last 30 minutes is what we refer to as sudden death.

Tempo: the turn at move, meaning chess time as opposed to clock time.

Time Control: the time limit that every player has to finish a specific number of moves.

Time Trouble: a complicated situation for a chess player who must finish a huge number of moves before time control.

Under Promotion: a pawn that is promoted to a piece other than the queen, generally in order to avoid a stalemate or gain a better advantage.

Weakness: a flaw in a position that increases the possibilities of losing the game (for example, shortage of space, a blocked pawn, etc.)

Win: a player wins the game when he or she checkmates or decides to accept the opponent's resignation before a checkmate.

Woodpusher: another word to describe a lousy chess player.

Algebraic Notations

I am sure you have heard about algebraic notations in chess... and you are probably already worried about them. Please don't! It is all easier than you can imagine.

The Algebraic Notation (AN) is a standard method to describe and record moves in chess games.

Although algebraic notations are available in different languages and forms, they are mainly based on the standards set by Philipp Stamma, a pioneer chess master internationally well-known for the chess books he published in France in 1737. His rules are used in the most important competitions and by FIDE.

Names of the Squares

	a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h	
8	a8	b8	c8	d8	e8	f8	g8	h8	8
7	a7	b7	c7	d7	e7	f7	g7	h7	7
6	a6	b6	c6	d6	e6	f6	g6	h6	6
5	a5	b5	c5	d5	e5	f5	g5	h5	5
4	a4	b4	c4	d4	e4	f4	g4	h4	4
3	a3	b3	c3	d3	e3	f3	g3	h3	3
2	a2	b2	c2	d2	e2	f2	g2	h2	2
1	a1	b1	c1	d1	e1	f1	g1	h1	1
	a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h	

As you can see above, on your chessboard the squares are identified by a unique coordinate (a letter and a number).

The vertical square columns known as *files* are labeled a-to-h.

The horizontal square rows known as *ranks* are numbered from 1 to 8, starting to count from the white side of the chessboard.

All the squares have a specific number and letter to identify their position.

Naming the Chess Pieces

The pawns are lettered with a lowercase "p," while the other pieces are identified with an uppercase letter. The first letter is usually taken from the name of the piece, and it applies in different languages. In the English language, "K" represents the King; "Q" represents the Queen; "R" represents the Rook; "B" represents the Bishop; and "N" stands for the Knight (because K has already been "taken" for the King).

Even though in other languages different letters are used to represent chess pieces (in French, for example, the Bishop is referred to as "F," for the French word "Fou"), the universal symbols and shapes of the pieces are identical all over the world. Pawns are always represented with lowercase letters mainly because, since this piece only moves one square at a time, distinguishing between them isn't necessary.

Move Notations

To indicate the movement of a chess piece, we use the first uppercase letter and then the square to which it moved. Let's make a few examples: Be5 means your bishop moves to the e5 square, Nf3 means your knight moves to the f3 square, c5 means your pawn moves to the c5 square (as we just said, for pawns, you do not need to use a lowercase p).

Easy, isn't it?

Capture Notations

If you make a capture, you have to denote that on the score sheet with an "X," before describing the piece's destination. So, let's now say you make a capture Bxe5. What does it mean? That the bishop captured a piece on the e5 square. If a pawn caught a piece, the file from which it left is what allows identifying the pawn's location. If a piece on d5 is captured by the pawn on e-file, this is noted as exd5. Sometimes, players use the ":" sign instead of "X" to describe the capture and they can either put the ":" sign in the same place where the "X" would go or at the end of the notation. So, both "B:e5" or "Be5:" is accurate.

The captures made by *en passant* rules (we will talk about this in a short while) are referred to by indicating with X the pawn capture file and then the square of destination. Please, just remember that this square is not the one of the captured pawns. After it, you add the "e.p." suffix, which means "en passant". An example would be exd6e.p.

More Notations

When identical chess pieces are moved to the same square, the piece that actually makes the move is identified by specifying the piece's letter, and the notations follow in ascending or descending order. So, the notation depends on the file and the difference; the departing piece's rank; when we have the same files but with differing ranks; or both the file and the rank. This happens in sporadic cases where two or more pawns get to be promoted.

Let's make a practical example. When the knights are placed on the squares g1 and d2 (in both cases can move to f3), the move is noted as Ngf3 or, alternatively, also as Ndf3.

The knights placed on g5 and g1 can make moves, like N1f3 or N5f3. As previously indicated, "X" can also be included to describe a capture.

Notations for Pawn Promotion

Once a pawn gets to the eighth rank, it is promoted to either a queen or another high-valued piece. When this happens, it is indicated at the end of the move. So, you use e8Q to indicate a pawn promoted to a queen. Sometimes, you might also find the addition of an 'equal to', but it represents the same promotion. A pawn promotion could therefore be recorded as e8(Q) or e8=Q.

Please just remember that these are not FIDE standards.

Offer to Draw a Game

Even though this is not considered an algebraic notation, FIDE indicates that the "=" sign denotes a draw on the score sheet next to the piece move.

Castling Notations

Special notations are also used to represent *castling* (we will talk about this in a short while). For kingside castling, 0-0 is used, while 0-0-0 is notated for queenside castling.

Checkmate

To show a checkmate state, we use the "+" symbol. Sometimes, the sign might appear as a dagger or also as a "ch" abbreviation. If the king is in a double check situation, we will find a double "++" or "dbl ch."

How to Record Your Chess Moves

By now, you know that you “read” the chessboard using pairs of numbers and letters. For the vertical files you use letters from "a" to "h", and for the horizontal ranks you use numbers from "1" to "8".

With this lettering and numbering, it is effortless to identify squares and ranks. So, for example, we know that the white king starts from the e1 square, that the black knight sits on b8, and that it can be moved to either a6 or c6.

In an official tournament or competition, the players can record the moves they make in chess notation in order to avoid any possible dispute or legal opposition. For example, if they violate a time delay method or control, they can claim by showing the moves they have made. Nowadays, Algebraic Chess Notations are the most preferred way to record a chess game.

In a match, the current rule indicates that every single move must correspond to the chess notations before writing it on paper or using an electronic device. Before the match starts, the player must first indicate an "=" sign on the scoreboard, and time notations must be accurately recorded on the scoreboard or the recording sheet. In case a player has less than the prescribed five minutes left to complete his or her moves, he or she will not be asked to record, and an extra thirty-minute delay will be added.

Game Completion

When a game ends, if the white player wins, it will be denoted 1-0. On the other end, if Black is the winner, it will be indicated with 0-1. What about a draw? In this case, the scoreboard will show $\frac{1}{2}$ - $\frac{1}{2}$.

Now that we have mentioned the main rules behind algebraic notations, don't you agree with me that this isn't that complicated after all? It is perfectly normal if you don't seem to remember many of the options we have just talked about right now. Still, I am sure you have already noticed that in the end, this is all about logic.

So, take your time to read this chapter a few more times, possibly looking at your chessboard and moving a few pieces, then go on with the rest of this manual, and in no time, you will see how naturally this will all come to you.

And talking about your chessboard, it is now time to have a look at the most important pieces of equipment you are going to need to start playing the game of chess.

The equipment

The first good piece of news is that chess is a game for any kind of budget. The price of a chess set goes from just a few dollars to hundreds of dollars for well-carved, high-range sets.

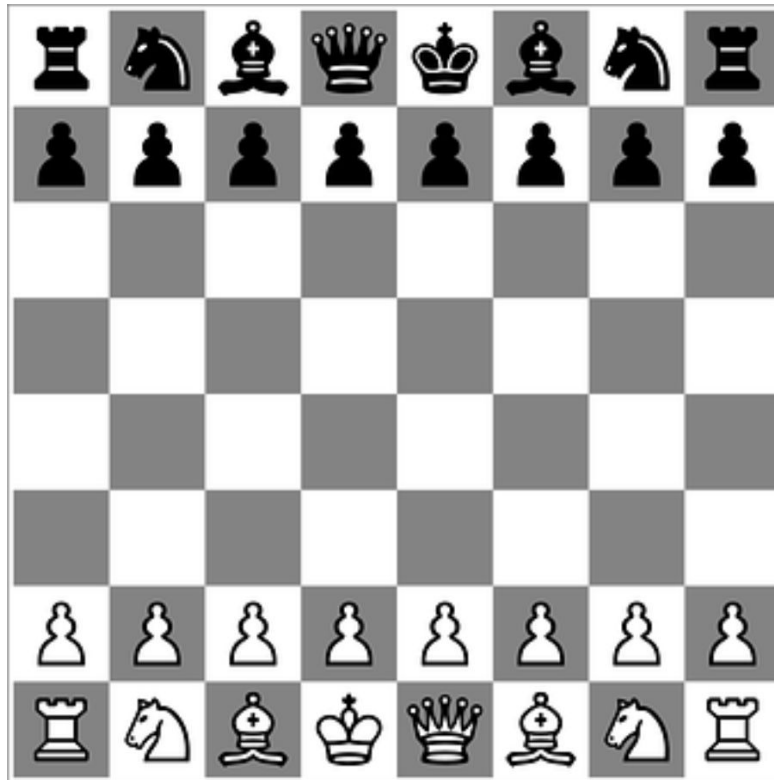
A chess set includes the board and all the pieces (pawns, bishops, rooks, knights, the king, the queen). The color and sizes of pieces always match and contrast with the board's squares.

Chess sets can also come in unique travel versions and generally have pegged or magnetic pieces and a separate section to store the remaining ones. Needless to say, these kinds of sets are very practical and perfect for any kind of trips.

And guess what? You can even find themed sets with special motifs and designed armies of all kinds (cats and dogs, Indians and Cowboys, etc.) that can fight against each other. These pieces are obviously custom-made, and they can make the game even more fun!

Just take into account that these kinds of sets are, for obvious reasons, not suitable for official games or tournaments.

The Chessboard



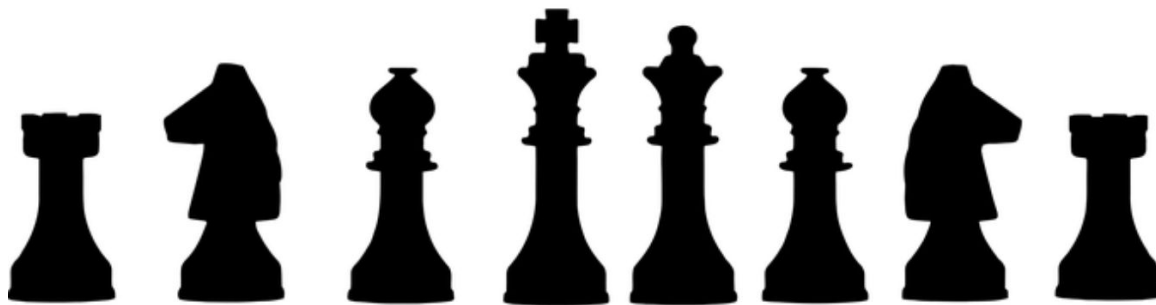
And now, the moment has come to talk about the place where the magic happens: the chessboard. Its squares are 1.25, and the size of the king's base is 1.3 (approx. 65mm).

The actual color of the darker squares on the chessboard can be black, dark green, or dark brown, while the lighter colored ones can either be white or off-white.

In tournaments, you will see special chessboards built right into gaming tables.

Boards usually have coordinates printed on the sides, showing the algebraic notations for the squares. These are very useful for both amateur and professional players because they give an idea of which square each piece moves on to.

The Chess Pieces



Chess pieces are generally made out of plastic or wooden materials, and they are usually white or black. Even pieces of other colors, like dark wood or red, are still referred to as "black" or "white." On a standard chessboard, the king must be 85 to 105 millimeters tall (3.35 to 4.13 inches), and its diameter has to be approximately 50% of its actual height. All the other pieces need to be proportional to the king, balanced in height, width, and shape.

If you are a beginner, be aware of the fact that you can find special introductory pieces that have legal moves printed on them. They generally get replaced pretty quickly with normal ones. Still, they are also a great asset for beginners looking for some help to get started.

Also, do not forget that you will have to store your pieces in an appropriate container or pouch: this will help you increase the lifespan of your chess set, and you won't risk losing any of them.

Chess Clocks



During chess games, you will generally use adjacent game clocks, which might be digital or analog, consisting of two buttons. One button stops the clock; at the same time, the other one starts the timer and prevents the two clocks from running at the same time.

In the analog clock, a flag is sandwiched between 11:00 and 12:00 on both the two clocks. When the minute hand comes closer to noon, the tip touches the flag, and the clock continues to move on.

So the flag goes from a vertical position to a horizontal one. When the hand reaches noon again, the flag drops; if the player hasn't made her or his move within that time, then this will be recorded as a time loss.

Nowadays, digital clocks allow better control of time and represent the most popular option. Every time a player makes a move, they punch the clock, and it saves additional time.

Chess clocks have to be sturdy (players might punch them a bit too hard or make them fall from the table) and audible but not too noisy.

Score sheet

Apart from the equipment mentioned above, in order to record your chess moves, you should always keep a score sheet. In tournaments and matches, these are distributed to players at the start of every round.

The Rules

And now, let's talk about the rules of this fascinating game: they originated back in the Middle Ages and have been continuously modified over the years.

The world chess organization has determined universal standardized rules, and no matter if you play chess with your best friend or in a tournament or important competition: initial rules remain the same, and you will always have to go after your opponent's king.

On the other hand, fast chess, chess variants, online chess, and correspondence chess have their own slight rule variations.

As I am sure you already know, rule number one is that chess is a game played between two people.

Each player counts with an "army" of sixteen pieces of six different types that he or she will have to move on the chessboard. Players can use only one hand to move their pieces, and they must take it off as soon as they have made their move. Bear in mind: once you have moved a piece, it is illegal to reverse that move.

The ultimate goal of every player is to “checkmate” his or her opponent by putting the enemy’s king in a position in which capture cannot be avoided. But this is not always how a game ends. Sometimes players, who know they are going to lose, voluntarily resign. Also, a game can end in a draw, a situation called a “stalemate.”

But the match also ends in a draw when neither player can checkmate the opponent’s king, nor can they make further legal moves. In this situation, the game reaches a “dead position.”

This ends the match and neither player can claim victory.

But other situations too may cause the game to end in a draw: when a player has moved a piece to the very same position on the chessboard at least three times. Or when both players have made fifty moves consecutively without moving any pawns and without capturing any pieces (we will talk about this in a short while).

From the moment the game begins, the players take alternating turns. You are entitled to move one piece each move, and when your piece ends on a box occupied by a piece of your opponent, this means you have captured it, and this piece gets permanently removed from the game.

As we briefly explained before, if you make a move that leads to the capture of the enemy’s king, you win the game. In this situation, we would be talking of a “checkmate stage” because the other player has no move left to save his or her king.

Watch out! It is illegal to make any move that exposes your king to immediate capture, and you cannot move into “check.” It is also considered illegal to try to force a draw or avoid defeat simply by repeating the same moves and, in particular, making repeated checks.

Now let’s see with more details two important chess rules: the Fifty-Move Rule (the one that we have briefly mentioned above) and the Touch-Move-Rule.

The Fifty-Move Rule

This rule was introduced to avoid a player who had no chance of winning from continuously making moves until an indefinite end comes about.

This was actually a strategy used by players who tried to win by exhausting their enemy and forcing them to quit the game.

So, the Fifty-Move Rule states that if no capture has been made in the game, and if no pawn has been displaced during the former fifty moves, then the players can claim a draw.

Are 50 moves enough? Well, obviously, a master player can easily make the necessary moves to earn a checkmate in way less than 50 moves. However, in the 20th century, it was observed that specific strategies and moves didn't lead to a victory, and the rule was then changed, allowing an additional 50 moves for players who were unable to end the game within the first 50 ones. In any case, this new rule was only applicable if the player hadn't eliminated any pawns.

Over the years, however, more winning moves were discovered, making it way easier for players to win the match in 50 moves. This is why in 1992, FIDE abolished all other exceptions and set the fifty-move rule as the standard one.

So now you must win the game within this number of moves, claim a draw, or simply accept that you have lost to your opponent and quit the game.

The Touch-Move-Rule

During a match, if you touch a piece with your hand in a way that might indicate that you want to make a move, then no matter what happens or what your real intention was, you have to move that piece.

Anyhow, this is only permissible if the move is legal. As long as you don't move the piece onto a new square, the piece can be moved to any other accessible square.

And if you accidentally brush against a piece, then it doesn't count as an intentional move.

If you touch an opponent's piece and the move is legal, then you must capture it with your piece. If the move isn't legal, then you will have to capture one of your opponent's first pieces on the board, always as long as the move is legal. When the players can't decide if they touched their piece or the enemy's one, it will be assumed that they touched their own, and the capture of the other piece will be declared void.

If you touch more than one piece, then you must capture each of them in legal moves. In the case of an illegal castling move (we will talk about this in more details in a short while), we have an exception: the king has to move if it can do it, or the rook will not be able to move.

When you are castling, you must touch the king first. If you touch the rook first or both pieces at the same time, then you must use the rook first and then go on with castling. Of course, this is possible only if the moves are legal. If you can complete a two-square move with the king without touching the rook, then you must move the rook using the correct moves that will make that move legal. Otherwise, the whole castling will be considered illegal, and you will have to withdraw it.

When you successfully move your pawn to the eighth rank, you have to be very careful: if you take your hand off the pawn, then this can no longer be promoted to a different piece. In any case, this move will be considered invalid if you promote your piece before moving it to the next square.

In general, when you decide to make a move, the Touch-Move rule establishes that the player must legally move the piece before touching any other chess pieces. This can be a bit of a challenge, and you will always have to stay vigilant while playing your moves.

Also remember: if you want to adjust a piece on the board, first you will have to announce *j'adoube*, (yes, it is French, and it means "I adjust"). It is strictly prohibited for a player to touch other pieces on the board if it's not his or her turn; this means you will always have to wait for your own turn to make a legal move.

The rules of the game also have to do with time control, player conduct, recording moves with the appropriate chess notation, resolving any irregularities that may occur, and using the correct equipment: we will talk a bit more about these topics in the next pages.

Irregularities

We have briefly mentioned illegal moves. Now we will see with more details the irregularities of chess and the exceptions that players need to know and take into account.

As we will see below, these can basically be divided into two categories: illegal moves and illegal positions. Let's have a look!

Illegal Moves

If a player makes an illegal move, they must retract it and make another one that is considered legal, possibly using that very same piece that was initially moved.

Why? Because the Touch-Move Rule will apply here. If the player makes an illegal castling move, then the touch move rule applies to the king and not to the rook.

When this happens, the time on the clock has to be readjusted (in tournaments, it is the judge or arbiter that takes care of it). Suppose the players don't notice the mistake until later in the game. In that case, the game should be restarted from the point of the illegal position.

If the opponents are playing a blitz match (don't worry, we will talk about this in just a few lines), they have a very limited time to make their moves, and in this case, the rule varies: the player is only allowed to correct an illegal move if he or she isn't under any time pressure. When the player is under pressure, his or her opponent can ultimately claim victory if they make the next move.

Suppose the opponent makes a move that is illegal too. In that case, it will be considered accepted, and none of the players will have to face any penalties.

Standard FIDE chess laws establish that an opponent is awarded an extra two clock minutes for an illegal move penalty. If the same player makes a second illegal move, then the game will end for him or her. If the opponent can make legal moves to win, it is then possible for them to win the game.

Illegal Positions

Suppose a game goes on for a while, and later it is discovered that something in the starting position was incorrect. In that case, the players have to restart the game from the beginning.

On the other hand, if in a game that has been going on for a while, the board was not appropriately set up, the opponents can continue to play, just making sure to correct the board and put the pieces where they are supposed to be.

Suppose the match starts with the opponents playing the pieces of the wrong colour. In that case, the game can still go on (unless, in tournaments or official matches, the judge says otherwise proposing a new rule for that particular game).

If the players realize that an illegal move has been made, or pieces have been displaced, the game must be restored to a regular or legal state; in case none of the players can determine the exact position of legal moves, then the game has to go back to a position that was recorded as legal.

Player Conduct

As a chess player, you also have a conduct to follow and responsibilities to take into account. Chess players cannot undertake illegal actions that might result in the abrupt end of the game. For example, they are not allowed to pick up a captured piece and replace it on the board: this could result in the player being dismissed from the match.

Also, when playing a chess game you are not allowed to bring any technological device (such as mobile phones, tablets, laptops, and so on) to the match. Remember: you can only use your pieces and score sheet when you are playing, and you are not allowed to receive any phone calls during the game. If something like this happened in a tournament, the game would end immediately.

In general, players are not allowed to distract or disturb their opponents in any way, and those who do not follow these rules will have to abandon the game or accept the penalty established by the judge. In case both players weren't able to follow the rules, they would both lose the game.

Blitz Game

So, just a few lines above, I mentioned the term *Blitz Chess*. And what is it? Blitz chess, also called *fast chess* or *speed chess*, is the time control of choice for most chess players.

It refers to a game that is generally extremely amusing to watch and is played faster than with classical time controls, which are most commonly used for over-the-board tournaments and that, according to FIDE, have at least 120 minutes per player (one game only in the world championship chess match could last more than six hours!)

So, this kind of speed chess is divided into rapid, blitz, and bullet time controls. And then we have the variation known as *Armageddon*, where different rules apply for each player.

In short:

Rapid chess: FIDE states that time controls for each player are more than 10 minutes, but less than 60.

Blitz chess: according to FIDE, time controls are 10 minutes or less for each player.

Bullet chess: time controls are less than 3 minutes per player, based on a 40-move game.

Armageddon: this is a variation where Black wins drawn games. To compensate for giving Black draw odds, the white player has more time on the clock. Generally, times are 6 minutes for White and 5 for Black or 5 minutes for White and 4 for Black.

How to Play Chess

We are about to see how to play chess practically, so let's make a short recap of the basics of this game.

So far, we have learned that you will need a chessboard in order to start playing. This is a unique board divided into 64 small squares arranged in an eight-by-eight manner and with alternating colors generally referred to as "black" or "dark" and "white" or "light" boxes.

One player competes using the white pieces, while the other one controls the black ones. From this moment on, they might be referred to as "Black" and "White".

So, White always makes the first move. And a move has to be made at every turn. It goes against the rules to skip one, so even if moving one of your pieces might negatively affect your game, you will have to do it anyway, or the match will stop.

As previously indicated, the game goes on until one of the players makes a "checkmate" (captures the king of his or her opponent), or until one of them decides to withdraw or until the game is drawn.

Another thing to keep in mind is that chess can be played under "timed conditions." As we mentioned before, the entire match is played within a limited time, and the player that exceeds it loses the game. But if you manage to capture the enemy's king before time is over, you will be declared the winner of the match.

This kind of game counts with different types of time control. For example, players can either have a fixed time and play the game during that entire period or make a certain number of moves within that time frame.

Another option for the players is to decide to extend the time and increase the number of moves they will most likely make.

It's up to the players to decide who plays Black and who plays White, which also happens in tournaments and official matches. Generally, colors are randomly assigned, and the players pick their colors by grabbing a random piece from the pieces' bag.

Then, the game starts: each player's goal is to capture as many pieces of his or her opponent as possible. As the game goes on, you get to a point where either you put the other player into "check" or ultimately "checkmate," or your opponent defeats you.

In case of finding yourself in a "check" situation, you can:

- 1) Blocking your enemy's path to your king by moving one of your pieces in front of this one.
- 2) Taking your king away from the impending danger, moving it in a safe square.
- 3) Capturing the piece that is threatening your king using one of your pieces or your king itself.

If you cannot do any of these things, then you will need to admit that you are in "checkmate" and accept you lost. Also, note that you can never put yourself in "check." What does it mean? You are not allowed to make any move that will permit your enemy to capture your king.

The following may also occur:

Resign

If one of the players believes that they will ultimately lose the match, then he or she has the permission to withdraw at any time and accept defeat. The other player will be declared the winner of the game.

Stalemate

This is a particular situation in which a player is left with no legal moves to make, even though he or she isn't in check.

So, a stalemate is a draw, and, as explained before, it depends on the *Fifty-Move rule* (when both players have made fifty moves without any capture by pawns).

Chess Pieces And Their Major Abilities

As we have already said, each chess player gets sixteen pieces. These pieces are one king, one queen, two rooks, two bishops, two knights, and eight pawns.

So, let's get to know the main characteristics of these pieces and talk about how you should move each one of them:

King (Value: inestimable)



The king has a small crown or cross on and is the most important piece in the game. At the same time, it is also the weakest one. Why? The king can be moved only one square in any direction (forward, backward, or sideways). It also has a special and unique move, known as the *castling move*. You can never move your king in a position of danger (please do not forget this!): if you lose your king, you lose the game.

As we briefly mentioned before, castling is a special move that applies to the king and the rook and allows you to get your king to safety and move your rook to the center of the game.

You should move your king two squares to one side and then shift your rook next to your king on the contrary one.

But watch out, to be able to castle, the following conditions must be met:

- It must be the first move for both the king and the rook
- There can be no pieces blocking the path between the king and rook.

- The king cannot be under "check"

When you castle in one direction, the king gets closer to that side of the chessboard. And this is called a "kingside castling." When you castle to the other side, where the queen is placed, then this is called a "queenside castling." Just remember that no matter what side it takes, the king can move only two squares when castling.

Also, when you castle, you must first move the king with one hand and then move the rook with the same one.

Queen (Value: 9)



The queen is generally smaller than the king and has a ridged edge at the top of her head. She is the most powerful piece on the chessboard and can move any number of squares along the rank, file, or diagonal.

The queen can attack in any manner she moves; however she is not allowed to leap over any other piece. Like the other pieces on the chessboard, if the queen is captured, she is out of the game.

Rook (Value: 5)



The rook, also known as the castle, is considered a very powerful piece, especially when it comes to protecting and working with other rooks to attack the enemy.

The rook can move as far as it can, but it can only do it backward, forwards, or sideways. Like the queen, it cannot leap over the other pieces.

However, captures in a chess game are optional. This means that the rook does not necessarily have to make a capture: it can do it only if it wants to.

Bishop (Value: 3)



The bishop is an excellent piece to cover and/or protect the other pieces on the chessboard.

You have two bishops for the color of your choice: the one that sits on white can move diagonally on the white squares, while the black one moves only on the black squares, also diagonally.

The bishop is allowed to move any number of squares, provided they are all diagonal, but it cannot jump over the other pieces.

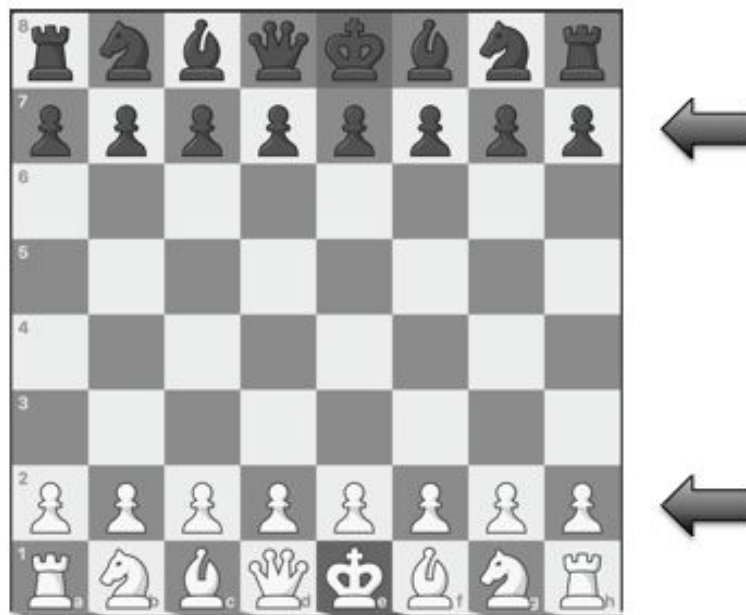
Knight (Value: 3)



The knight's head looks like a horse, and, compared to all the other pieces, the knight moves in the most different ways: three squares in total, like in an “L” shape (two squares in one direction, and another one at a right angle).

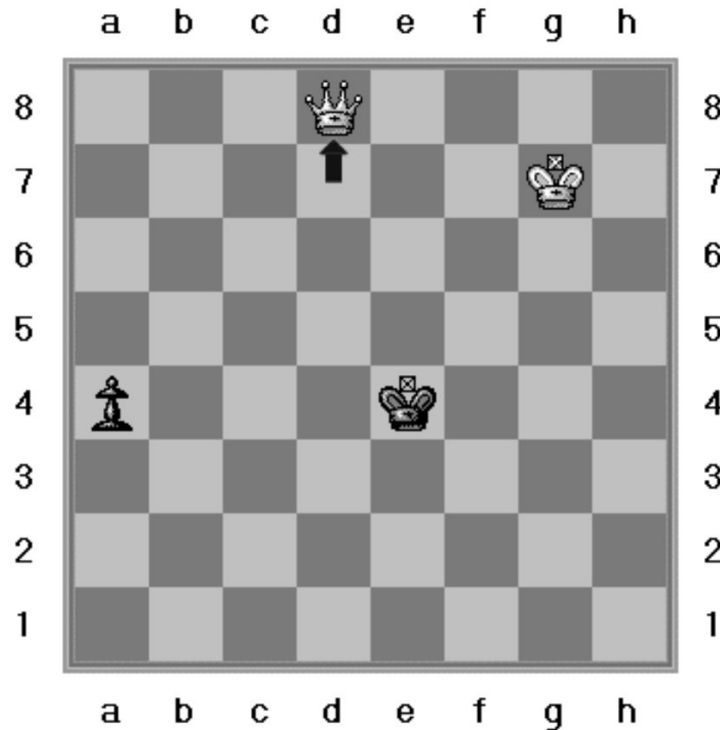
The knight is also the one piece that can move over other chess pieces. Also, the knight can move two squares vertically or horizontally, and then one perpendicularly. It can easily jump over the different pieces and capture the opponent's pieces. Also, the other pieces of the chessboard cannot block the knight. But watch out: when placed in a corner, the knight is even more vulnerable than the queen or the bishop, and it is even easier for its opponent to capture it.

Pawn



Pawns are considered the most complex pieces on the board: they can capture other pieces and move in different ways. You can move them one square at a time, except for the first moves when you are allowed to move them two squares forward. They can capture pieces diagonally in front of them, but they cannot capture another piece going backward. If there is one piece blocking a pawn, this cannot move until the piece moves.

Pawn Promotion



Suppose a pawn successfully reaches the other side of the board. In that case, it can be promoted, meaning it can become a piece with a higher value, including the queen. Some people say that pawns can only be exchanged for previously captured chess pieces, but this is not accurate. They can be promoted to any piece.

Once a pawn is promoted and all the pieces have been moved consequently, those pieces cannot be touched anymore to reverse the moves. But if the promotion is not final, then a new piece can make any valid move.

En Passant

As we briefly mentioned in the first pages of this book, "en passant" (French expression that means "in passing") is another rule that applies to pawns.

How does it work? During the game, if the pawn moves two squares on its first move, and by doing so, ends up next to an enemy's pawn, then that pawn may capture the first one it moves past. You can only make this move if you notice it at the start and act immediately. Otherwise, the opportunity of capturing the pawn expires.

Now you know the names of the pieces, their main qualities, and how they move, so the next thing we need to talk about is how to set up your chessboard properly.

Let's begin.

How to set the pieces on the chessboard

The first thing you will need to do in order to arrange the board and your pieces correctly is to set it up so that the bottom white square faces the right side. This way, both players will have the white squares in the right corner of the board. Your pieces will be set up on the two horizontal rows closest to you, on the bottom side.

Then, you will have to place a rook on the two corners of the board. Once you have placed them on the edges, then place the knights beside them. As we said before, remember that knights can move a total of three squares, but they can only move in an "L" shape, and they can also jump over other pieces.

After the knights, you will have to place the bishops immediately next to them. While setting the pieces, keep moving towards the center of the board, and always keep in mind that bishops can only move diagonally.

While placing them, check to ensure that one is on a black square and the other is sitting on a white one.

At this point, if you are playing White, place your queen on the remaining white square and if you are playing Black, just do the opposite. And, on the last remaining square of the first row, place the king, the tallest piece of the entire chessboard. Once the king is sitting in its place, then your whole first row, also known as the rank, is ready.

Remember that the king can move in any direction, but only once square at a time. And this means that you will always have to make sure that other pieces are surrounding and protecting it.

Last but not least, you will have to place all the pawns on the second row, letting them stand arrayed in front of the other chess pieces.

And once you have placed all the pawns, your board is set and complete.

The game can finally begin!

Castling



Kingside Castling



Queenside Castling

If you have paid attention to the last few pages, by now, you should know that castling involves exchanging the places of the king and one of the rooks and that this move is only possible if neither the king nor the rook has been previously moved.

Also, the squares between the rook and the king must be unoccupied, and the king must not be in a "checkmate" situation. Generally, casting protects the king behind a wall of pawns.

Now, let's have a closer look at the so-called "castling strategy."

In the opening phase of a game, this is a very important move because it serves two valuable purposes:

It moves the king into a safer position, away from the center of the board, and, at the same time, it also moves the rook to "an active" position in the middle of the board. With this move, it is possible to put the opponent's king in a "checkmate" situation too.

My advice is to opt for kingside castling because it keeps the king at a safer distance. The king will stay closer to the board's edge, and all the other pawns will stand in a file right close to the king, protecting it from possible attacks.

On the other hand, in queenside castling, the king is placed closer to the board's center while pawns in the first row will stand undefended. With this move, the king is generally taken to the "b file" in order to defend the "a-pawn." By doing so, the king will move away from the center of the board, and the risk of attacks will increase. Furthermore, queenside castling will require moving away the queen as well.

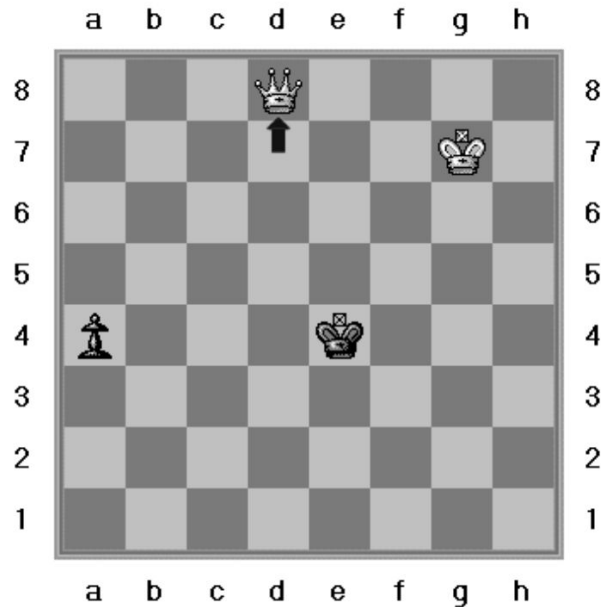
But let's be fair, queenside castling has advantages too because it efficiently places the rook in the board's central "d-file."

Generally, in a chess game, both players opt for kingside castling. In rare cases, one player chooses kingside castling, while the other opts for queenside castling: this situation is known as "opposite castling," or the "opposite side castling."

This castling strategy usually ends in a fierce fight between the two players, as their pawns are free to move forward and try to attack the enemy's king. Examples of such moves are the openings Dragon Variation, Sicilian Defense, and the Yugoslav Attack.

If the king ends up moving before it gets the chance to castle, the player will still have the choice to take the king to the edge of the board and the rook to the middle of the board. When the player chooses this way to reach a castling stage by taking two to four moves, this is called "artificial castling," or "castling by hand strategy."

Promotion



As we also mentioned before, once a pawn reaches the eighth rank, it can immediately be promoted to any piece, and it's up to the player to decide which one. The threat of a pawn promotion is often decisive for the match and leads to the “chess endgame move.”

The pawn can become a queen, bishop, rook, or knight. This means that after promotion, a player may have two queens!

Actually, being the queen, the most powerful piece on the chessboard and a piece able to move diagonally, most pawns end up being promoted to this piece, and this situation is usually referred to as the “queening promotion.”

On the other hand, if you decide to promote your pawn to another piece, we would be talking of an “under promotion.”

Promotion Strategy

Pawn promotion is frequently considered a primary aim of a chess game. Pawns are not able to move backward, and this is why promoting them is so important. Most often, when a match gets to this stage, the chessboard is already half empty, which gives pieces more liberty to move.

But, what happens if you exchange a pawn for a knight? Let's imagine for a moment that the black queen is under threat from the white one. Within the next move, she is able to move back to the king on the c7 row. During his or her third move, the white player might put the king into "checkmate" with the knight to e8 or the queen to h7. After this move, the white pawn will be promoted to a knight, and the black king will find itself in some trouble.

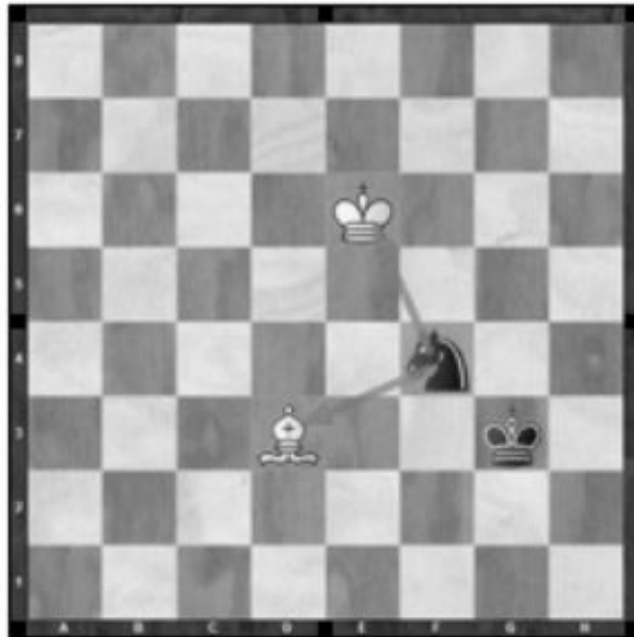
If the pawn had been promoted to a queen in this scenario, it would have been easier to checkmate the enemy's king with just one diagonal move. But the promotion of the pawn to a bishop may help too to attack the enemy's king from a distance.

Another possible scenario could be the rook attacking the enemy's king along a line from a distance. The pawn can lead the player to victory after being promoted to a rook and having attacked the opponent's king in a single file.

But with a queen promotion, with almost no effort, the pawn can put the enemy's king under checkmate pressure with just a single diagonal move. Generally, to most players, this looks like the best option, the one that can make you win the game.

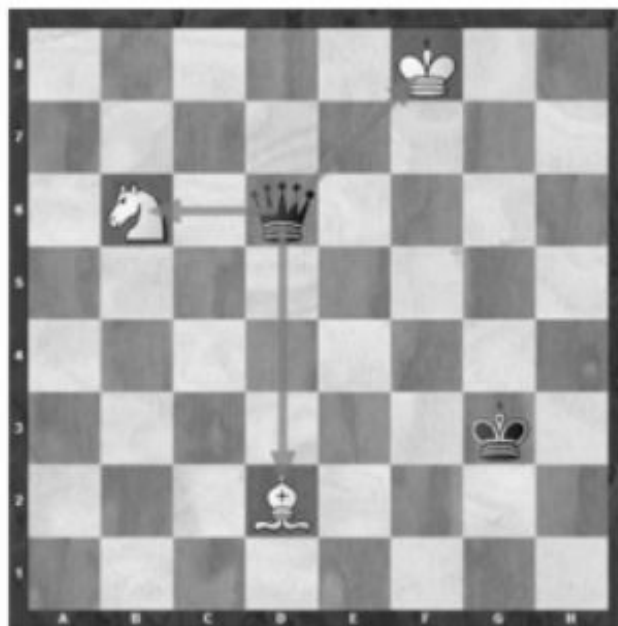
Let's now look at a few more chess tactics: read carefully because they might help you change the fate of your game!

Knight Fork



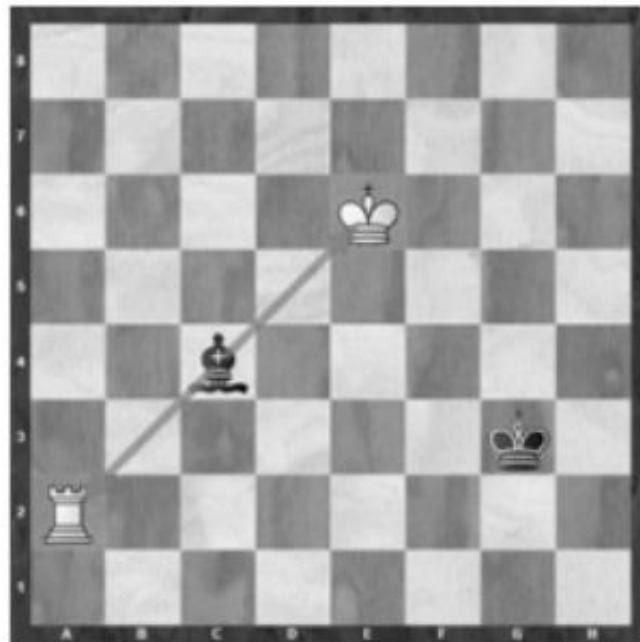
A knight fork is a powerful tactic that implies threatening two different pieces of the enemy's army with your knight. One of the advantages of using this tactic is that you can get a more valuable piece, for example, a rook or a queen, by utilizing the knight. But watch out! Be sure that one of the two targets of this move is not your enemy's knight, or you will end up losing yours!

Queen Fork



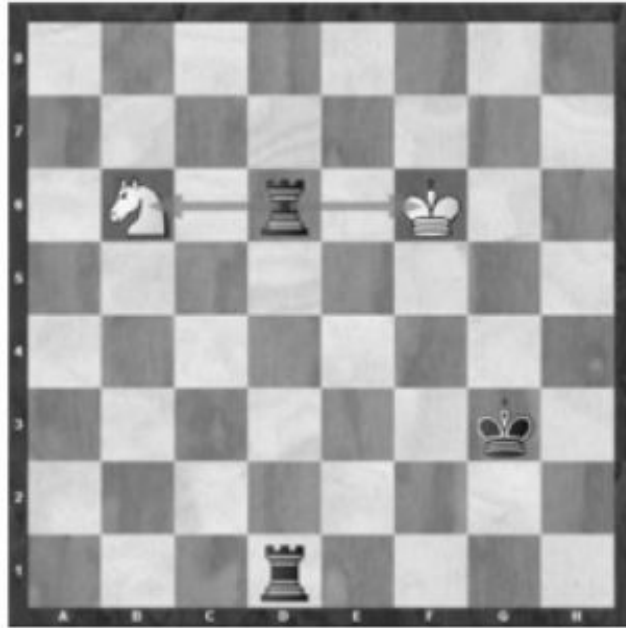
A queen fork is a tactic that implies threatening two different pieces of your opponent using your queen. In this case, you will need to be very careful: you should know by now that the queen is a very valuable piece of your army, and it would not be clever at all to lose such an essential asset over a piece with less value like the bishop or the knight. This is why you should target either two unprotected pieces or a king and an unprotected piece. Why? Because if you target a protected piece, you will end up losing your queen. Sounds too risky? Well, think that if you play this tactic well, you might quickly achieve a checkmate.

Bishop Fork



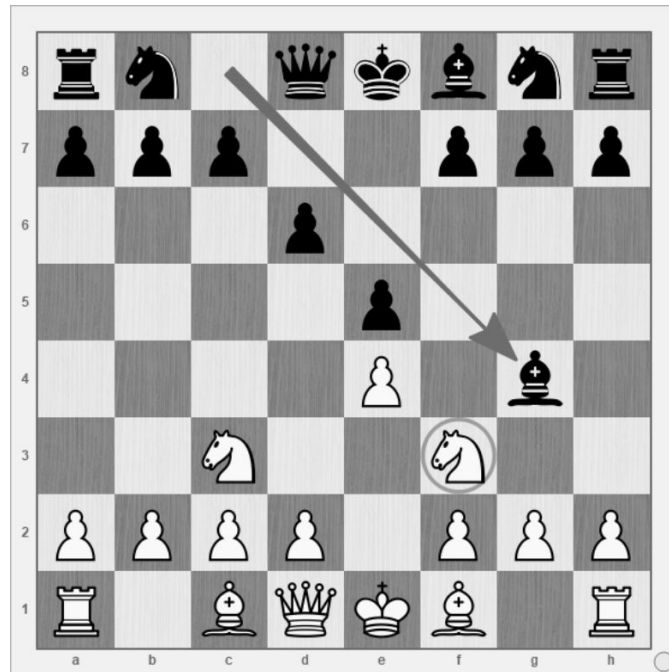
A bishop fork is a tactic that implies threatening two different pieces of your enemy using your own bishop. We are talking again about another powerful move that may help you gain an enemy's piece fast and easy. But remember: none of your targets can be your opponent's bishop or queen, or you might end up losing your own bishop.

Rook Fork



A rook fork is a tactic that implies threatening two different pieces of your enemy using your rook. It is a pretty powerful one because the rook is exposed to the entire line. Also, in this case, you should use the rook fork to target either two unprotected pieces or the king and an unprotected piece. Once again, make sure that one of the targets of this tactic is not your opponent's rook or queen, or things might get really nasty for your own rook.

Pinning



When an enemy's piece is threatened, he or she has two possibilities: 1) to move that piece 2) to put another piece in between the threatened one and your own. This second option is known as *pinning*. Now, you have to be aware of the fact that even though the pinning can neutralize the threat, it also implies a considerable disadvantage. Which one? The player won't be able to move the pinned threat as long as the menace remains. In other words, it's like the player is "giving up" one of his or her pieces.

We can find two kinds of pins, called the *Absolute Pin* and the *Relative Pin*.

Let's talk a bit more about both of them.

An absolute pin occurs when the following happens: you threaten your enemy's king with one of your pieces, and your opponent places a certain piece between your piece and his or her king. By doing so, your enemy will have to keep the pinned piece in place, as it will result in an open check. And when the threatened piece is your enemy's king, we will be talking about an absolute pin.

A relative pin looks like an absolute pin in terms of function. The difference is that in this case, the piece under threat is not the enemy's king. So we have a relative pin when the following happens: you threaten one of your enemy's pieces of higher value (for example, the queen or the rook) with one of your pieces. Your enemy places a certain piece between yours and his or her valuable piece. The consequences of a relative pin look quite similar to those of an absolute one: your enemy will not be able to move his or her pinned piece. But the general consequences of a relative pin are way less serious than those of an absolute one, as your opponent might just decide to sacrifice his or her piece under threat and move the pinned piece aside.

Not that bad compared to the previous scenario, right?

The Most Important Chess Strategies

Chess strategies, in my opinion, are the thing that makes this game so beautiful and what really marks the difference between winning and losing a match. After you have made the first initial moves, the real game begins, and the "world" of chess openings awaits you and your opponent.

As you probably already know, I am a massive fan of this part of the game, and this is why I dedicated my very first book to chess openings.

There is no doubt that you can pave your way to victory by learning opening moves and strategies. However, the middle game and the end game are also two extremely important moments of the match, and many chess players give up before they reach the end.

In general, no matter if we are talking about openings, middle or end game: strategy is fundamental for playing chess. If you don't control the basic strategies, you will never be able to win a game.

So, step by step, let's look at the most important of them all to provide you with the right tools to start winning in this game.

Opening Moves

Even though any beginning of a chess game is called “opening,” the formal use of this term generally refers to the set of moves you make in a certain sequence when the match starts. That is also called openings by White or defenses by Black.

In the following few pages, we will discuss several important opening chess strategies, perfect for beginners like you. However, if you want to know more about this part of the game, do not forget to order a copy of my book “Chess Openings for Beginners.” In there, I unlock all the secrets of my very favorite opening moves and of the most important tips to excel when playing chess openings.

And now, if you are sitting in front of your chessboard thinking, “What am I supposed to do now? Where should I go from here?” read the next pages and do not worry. With these entries, you will make an excellent first impression, and your confidence will leave your opponent lost for words.

So, first of all, there are four words that you always have to keep in mind: CONTROL OF THE CENTRE. Why? Because the four center squares are also the *power squares*, mostly because this is where the board’s center is and where you can get to control all the action.



To make an example, if your knight is sitting on the center square, it controls up to eight additional squares. In short, this is a pretty solid position.

But if your knight stays on the center side square, it controls just four squares. Likewise, other pieces also have firm control only in the center of the board.

So, as you begin your game, the first move you should make is moving your pawns to the board's central squares. It is extremely important to try and get your pawns into the center to better control the match.

The following two words that you should never forget are **PIECE DEVELOPMENT**. Your chess pieces are working for you, and you must give them a specific task. If you just let them sit in the last row, they won't be "satisfied" because they won't have any work to do. This is why you have to find a way to get the last row of your pieces out on the board and make them work for you.

Generally, the following pieces that the players move out are the knights, which sit beside the bishops. You could move a knight to f3, and the other knight to c3, getting them closer to the center of the board. You won't move your knight to h5, because this would give it the possibility to control only four squares instead of eight. So, focus on the center of the board. Always.

The next step would be moving the two bishops out, once again keeping your eyes on the center of the board and aiming to control the center squares. After this move, your next goal (and words to keep in mind) would be the SAFETY OF THE KING, the key mission of any chess player.

By now, you should know that your king must be protected at any cost. And the best way to do it in these first few moves is by castling. As we mentioned before, you can do so either on the "kingside" or on the "queenside," but kingside castling is generally preferable.

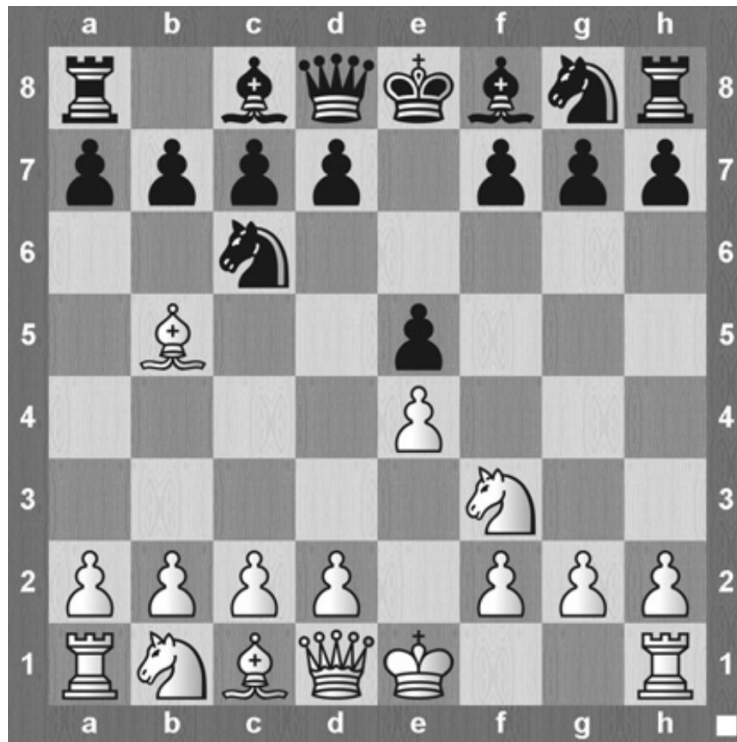
To make this move, you will have to move the king two spaces towards the side, and then you will have to move the rook to the other side of the king. By doing so, your king will end up guarded and protected by other pieces, like if it was in a fort.

And now, let's have a look at the basic principles of a few popular chess openings. First, we will talk about offensive strategies for the white player, and then we will mention defensive strategies for the black one.

White's Openings

Ruy Lopez

Moves: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5



The Ruy Lopez Opening is also known as the "Spanish opening in chess." It is a pretty simple and straightforward strategy, and it doesn't require much mental effort. This is why it is perfect for players that are just getting started at chess.

So, imagine that you are playing a match against your opponent. You play White, and your opponent plays Black. So you move the white pawn to e4, and your enemy moves the black pawn to e5. Then, you move your knight to f3, and the black knight responds by moving to c6. Later, as White, you pin down the black knight with your bishop, and this move puts the knight in danger of being captured and the pawn at e5 too.

In this situation, the most general response of the black player is to move his or her pawn to a6 in order to stop the bishop from attacking the knight. So you have two options at this point: to either attack the black knight or to retreat. If your choice is to attack the knight, your opponent will still be able to capture the bishop with their pawn.

Another possible move is to keep the bishop, considering that it has many distinct capabilities, and move it to c4 or a4. At this point, I would suggest you retreat with your bishop to a4 for two reasons.

- 1) It keeps the bishop safe from the black pawn's attack

2) It pins your bishop to the knight you were targeting at the beginning of the game.

After this move, the other player will have to think very well about what to do with the other pawns and the knight. He or she will move the black pawn to b5. So you will move your bishop back to b3. And this is a good position because it allows the bishop to target the f7 pawn of your opponent. And if he or she decides to move the pawn from a6 to capture your bishop, you can equally capture the black pawn with their pawn to a3.

So at this point, Black will try to move the bishop to f6, and after that, it will be able to capture your pawn on e5. My suggestion, at this point, is to go for kingside castling. Because if the knight captures the pawn, by castling your rook and queen, you will be able to move out to control the center and prepare to attack the Black.

After moving your king, you should move your knight and capture the black player's pawn on e5. With this move, your enemy's king will be in "check", and you should know by now that this is an excellent thing for you.

So, what we have just described is a pretty common way of playing the *Ruy Lopez* opening. From this point, Black will probably move their bishop to e7 and then castle. And you can then continue to attack the black pieces.

And as you have probably already noticed, with this opening, none of your pieces have been captured. A great start to the game, don't you think?

The Italian Game or Giuoco Piano

Moves: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Bc5



For more than 300 years now, The Italian Game opening has been analyzed and studied: it is one of the oldest ever-recorded game openings. Chess players like Polerio and Damiano developed their moves around the 16th century, and Greco, who gave this opening its main theme, further developed it in 1962. Chess players sometimes call it *Giuoco Piano*, even if this term mainly refers to the moves that take place after a player moves the bishop to c5.

It is considered a good and popular opening; however, it must be played carefully, and some chess grandmasters prefer not to use it because, if not played very well, it can lead to a draw.

So if you, as the white player, move your pawn from e2 to e4, then a possible move for your opponent, the black player, is to move his or her pawn from e7 to e5. According to the Italian game, if Black moves the knight from b8 to c6, you move your bishop to c4, as opposed to b5. Then, Black moves its bishop from f8 to c5. So, at this point, the best option for you is to move your white pawn from c2 to c3 in order to continue the game in the best possible conditions. The player can then move the knight to f6, making it easier to attack the enemy's e4 pawn. Then you move your pawn to d4, and the black player responds with kingside castling.

Queen's Gambit

Moves: 1. d4 d5 2. c4



The Queen's Gambit is considered one of the oldest openings in chess and also a pretty aggressive one. This opening can bring advantages to both the white and the black player. It provides you, as White, with enough ground to launch an offensive attack. Still, at the same time, it also offers the opportunity to the black player to respond to White's moves with an aggressive strategy.

With 2.c4, White threatens to exchange the c-pawn for Black's d-pawn with the aim of dominating the center using e2–e4.

This opening divides into two major categories based on Black's response: the Queen's Gambit Accepted and the Queen's Gambit Declined. In the first case, Black plays 2...dxc4, temporarily giving up the center in order to gain more unrestricted development. In the second one, Black generally plays to hold d5.

The King's Gambit

Moves: 1.e4 e5 2.f4



The King's Gambit is one of the oldest chess openings, and the possibilities that it offers have intrigued some of the greatest minds of this game: Fischer, Tal, and Spassky, among others.

In general, creative players that love bold sacrifices and wild combinations think that the King's Gambit is an ideal opening. On the other hand, if you consider yourself a faint-hearted player, then maybe this option is not the one that will better suit you.

So, in this strategy, you, as the white player, will challenge Black's center control in your second move and will attack the black kingside.

Your opponent has the option to decline or accept the gambit (Do you remember what a gambit is, right? Otherwise, go back just a few pages).

Generally, most black players decide to accept this gambit and counterattack their enemy's semi-exposed kingside. If this is the case, then you will have to focus all your attention on the f7 square, which is now your opponent's biggest weakness. After the move 2. exf4, you have two good options. The first one is to immediately begin to attack with 3. Bc4 and, by doing so, pressure the f7 square. Your second possibility is 3. Nf3. This will allow you to defend yourself against 3. Qh4+ and to start developing a kingside attack.

Those who love excitement will be happy to know that King's Gambit is a rather unpredictable opening and if Black doesn't really know how to defend itself, it will go down pretty quickly.

The Scotch Game

Moves: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4



This is a strategy that has regained a lot of popularity recently, as several top players have started using the Scotch Game as a way of shocking their opponents that are generally better prepared to face Ruy Lopez.

This strategy sees d4 opening lines for development and also offers the white player and early control of the center. In this opening, the black player has an opportunity to develop pretty easily; White instead must try to take advantage of its special control of the center.

Chess players who like playing 1.e4 should definitely learn the Scotch Game because it offers several subtle traps in which Black can fall into, giving White a devastating advantage.

So, most players would expect you, as the white player, to play 3.Bc4 or 3.Bb5. But suppose you incorporate the Scotch Game by making a different move, 3.d4. In that case, your enemy will much likely make some kind of beginner mistake, leading you to take control of the match.

So, also for Black it is imperative to know and be able to recognize the Scotch Game. In general, we could say that if you aren't prepared for this kind of opening, it can put you in deep trouble right at the beginning of the match... so watch out!

The Smith Morra Gambit

Moves: 1.e4 c5 2.d4 cxd4 3.c3



This strategy is an aggressive and sharp line against black's Sicilian Defense and, like most gambits, will better suit those players who like a fierce kind of game.

As the white player, if you make an e4 move for any length of time, then you will undoubtedly encounter the Sicilian Defense on several occasions.

White's goal is not only to take out the black player from the normal Sicilian lines but also to use its development advantage to stun the black king.

White typically tries to put its bishop on c4 to attack the weak f7 pawn, focusing on the castled kingside once its knight is on f3. Eventually, the white player aims to place its rooks on the semi-open d file and the open c file. By doing so, then White would have several potential attacking lines at its disposal.

Various Sicilian defenders end up playing the Smith-Morra Gambit.

The Vienna Game

Moves: 1.e4 e5 2.Nc3



The Vienna Game follows most central opening principles and enables significant creativity for players who prefer both a non-aggressive and an aggressive kind of game.

The black player has three options to respond to the Vienna Game strategy: 2.Nf6, 2.Bc5, and 2.Nc6.

Every black response opens the way for the white player to select how to go on with the game. White has the possibility of leading a quiet game by simply developing minor pieces towards the middle, choosing to stay ahead in space and time. If you are playing White, you can also move to f4, playing the gambit and transposing it into different King's Gambit lines.

The Vienna Game is an accessible opening to learn and offers several options to which the opponent isn't generally prepared.

Black's Openings or Defense

Now let's see some of the most critical defensive strategies if you are playing Black.

The Sicilian Defense

Moves: 1.e4 c5



First, we will take a look at the basics of the Sicilian Defense. This is one of the most significant and essential openings in chess, and there are more than ten variations of this strategy that can be played. So, no matter how many times you use it: you can always learn something new and improve your game!

According to this opening, the white player starts moving its pawn to e4 and taking control of the center. Instead of taking the black pawn to e5, the pawn on c7 moves to c5, which is the counter center.

Then White goes on with its knight on f3. At this point, there are so many variations that you could try. Still, the most common one is to move your pawn from d7 to d6 in order to increase a “small pawn chain” and open the way for the bishop’s advance.

The pawn of the white player then moves from d2 to d4: this is a must capture for the black pawn, but then White captures the black one. White has a greater advantage with this move because it may count with its knight out in the center and its pawn too. So, the main goal of Black is to try to stop White from removing its pawn from c2 to c4, which would lead to a *Maroczy Bind*.

What is this? The *Maroczy Bind* allows a player to take better control of the center and, by doing so, increasing his or her chances of winning the game. To prevent that from happening, Black moves the knight from g8 to f6: with this move it will be way easier to attack the pawn on e4, and White will not be able to play the Maroczy move. At this point, a common move for the white player is to move his or her knight from b1 to c3.

In order to stop an attack on the b5 square (an attack aimed directly at the black’s king!), Black needs to move its pawn from a7 to a6 to prevent the b5 square attack from happening and also avoid that the White’s knight might get to this same square. Also, it will stop the white player’s bishop on f1 from going to b5, and it will force it to move to c4 or somewhere else in the back of the chessboard.

From this point on, the game can move in any direction.

The French Defense

Moves: 1.e4 e6



The French Defense is a Black counterattack against the first white move – 1.e4, and it is ranked second in popularity to the Sicilian (always against White's 1.e4 move).

It's Black's turn to make the first move, and White expects it to move a2-g8, which is its biggest weakness and allows the white player to take control of the center squares after 2.d5. Some of the best players in the world find it challenging to play against the French Defense since it is a very peculiar and surprising defense.

The most significant problem you, as the black player, will face is the blocked bishop on the queenside, and generally, the entire game revolves around this main flaw. Remember, you will never win a game if you don't understand your own weaknesses.

One of the French Defense's main characteristics is that the black player generally counterattacks on the queen's side. At the same time, White typically focuses on the king's one.

The Pirc Defense

Moves: 1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3



The Pirc Defense is considered to be a hypermodern defense because it doesn't make an early attempt to control the game with pawns. As the black player, you attack the center from the sides with minor pieces, and once the foundation has been set, begin to undermine the white player's control of the center.

White only has two significant attacks to play against the Pirc Defense.

The first one is the *Austrian Attack*, one of the most aggressive moves in chess, which allows the white player to take its f pawn towards f4.

It is a risky move because it exposes White's king, but, at the same time, it also puts extra pressure on Black's kingside. Through the g6 move followed by Bg7, you, the black player, can aggressively attack your enemy's king.

The second attack of the white player is the *Classical System*, in which the second knight moves to f3 and positions itself to control the center better before the white player prepares to attack.

In both attacks, you have strong counter plays, but you must also be very careful about playing in a too passive way. If you aren't cautious, you could find yourself in a hazardous situation, way too cramped to move ahead.

So, your best option is to attack the center before White has any chance of doing it itself.

Caro Kann

Moves: 1.e4 c6



This is another very popular defensive opening in response to the King Pawn 1.e4 opening strategy.

So, if you are playing Black, you can respond with 1.c6 with a plan to thrust forward with d5 in your following move and attack the white central pawn on e4. With this strategy, Black finds itself in equal competition with White in the mainline. We could actually say that you find yourself (the black player) in a better position, especially at the end of the match. That's because you won't have to compromise your pawn structure through this move, and you will be able to play an easy endgame.

Even though several Caro Kann Defense variations exist, the mainline carries on with 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Nxe4 Bf5: a crucial setup that you must adequately understand if you want to use this strategy.

In various situations, to open the game following this tactic can gradually lead to the French Defense. In any case, when playing the mainline, Black generally has a pawn on c6. Then, the light-squared bishop is brought out by Black and makes a move to e6. So when your pawn, as the black player, is on c6, your following move would be to bring the knight to d7 and, at the same time, supporting the future knight on f6. Your queen can be placed on c7, while the dark-squared bishop has various lines and isn't blocked by any pawns.

This opening is not an aggressive or quick one. Actually, it is a relatively sound defense that leads the black player to have an advantage during the endgame. So this is the perfect defense for players who feel confident at endgame strategies and pawn structure.

The Dutch Defense

Moves: 1.d4 f5



The Dutch Defense is a pretty active one, especially against 1.d4. With this strategy, as the black player, you aim to control the e4 square while completely unbalancing the position.

Later, you will strengthen the attack on your opponent's kingside. From a strategic point of view, the most critical element is that Black's usual weak square f7 becomes an even easier target. So, the white player generally focuses their efforts on targeting this same weakness. As a response, you will have some active pieces that aren't cramped and will represent a very good tool to target your enemy.

The white player generally fianchettoes the king's bishop towards g2 to place some support on e4 square, which is under attack by you, the black player. You would probably fianchetto your bishop as well in order to add pressure towards the dark squares.

As you can see, both White and Black can count on different strategies with the Dutch Defense, and this is why the game gets to be really active and exciting, providing both players with plenty of interesting options.

The Benoni Defense

Moves: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5



The Benoni Defense is another very aggressive strategy that can be used to respond to White's popular d4 opening if you are playing Black. While the goal of many defensive strategies is to earn draws and close up against the pawn queen opening, the Benoni one offers the black player numerous possibilities to equalize the game and gain important supremacy to win the match.

The major focus of the modern Benoni Defense is White's center control of light squares, with the key pawns placed on d5, and the black player's center control of dark squares.

White wants to maintain permanent pressure on the d5 square and use it to set up outposts for minor pieces and to put additional pressure on his or her opponent.

As the black player, you want to prevent White from putting pressure on you and also gaining advantage on the c6 and e6 squares.

The Benoni Defense typically opens up pretty soon, leading bishops to have more power compared to the knights. So it is extremely important to act carefully when trading bishops. You might get many aggressive actions by the defending side and play a great match when things start to open up in the middle of the game.

The Alekhine Defense

Moves: 1.e4 Nf6



The Alekhine Defense is another hypermodern defense against the most used white e4 opening. If you are playing black, you will allow the white player to start chasing your knight on the chessboard and gain control of the center.

In the meantime, you will undermine White's overextended pawns.

The one thing you have to bear in mind as Black is that once your knight is being chased around the board, you cannot play passively. You must attack White's center control; otherwise, your enemy will crush you and win the game in a very clear way.

Generally, the white player has three main lines to choose from, but he or she will most likely begin with 1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5 3.d4 d6. And it is right here that things will start to change depending on the selected variant. The white player may pick an aggressive line of four pawn attacks to place the four central pawns near the center. And he or she may also play exchange variations that follow the pawn attack. Anyway, the last pawn White would opt to exchange would be the one on d6.

And you, as Black, can play a sharp line to capture with your king pawn, but also choose to follow an extremely exciting and very offensive strategy, capturing with your c pawn.

The Slav Defense

Moves: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6



This is a very popular strategy for opening defenses. Why? Basically, because of two key factors. First of all, this is the most robust line to play against the Queen's Gambit, the most popular opening at higher playing levels. Also, this strategy offers opportunities for multiple variations, something that the most creative players really appreciate.

As Black, in the second move you seek to defend your pawn on d5 with your c6 pawn. You do this because the pawn on the e file doesn't block the bishop on the light square.

In the Slav Defense's mainline, the white player seeks to control the center, while Black's goal is to control the b4 square, moving towards the e5 and c5 squares.

The King's Indian Defense

Moves: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6



The King's Indian Defense is one of the most powerful defensive chess strategies. As Black, you aim to create a strong defense around your king and to counter-attack, taking into account the weakest spots of the white player.

This defense offers control of the center to the white player without attempting to control the match early on with pawns. Instead, the black player's goal is to develop the minor pieces early on and later move the pawns to the center of the chessboard.

Please take into account that this strategy is pretty passive in its initial stages. So if you enjoy (or should enjoy in the future, once you have become a more experienced player) an active and aggressive kind of game, you probably won't find much amusement in playing it.

In any case, don't forget that, just like other opening chess strategies, this defense provides several opportunities for counterplay in the middle of the game.

The Grunfeld Defense

Moves: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 d5



The Grunfeld Defense is yet another hypermodern strategy: this means that if you are playing Black, you won't try to control the center with your pawns right from the start. Instead, you will focus on attacking the center from the sides, using your minor pieces, and then you will do your best to undermine the white player's control of the center.

This is a defense that can become quite deadly when properly used and can successfully stop even an experienced d4 player.

The Grunfeld Defense has three major lines. The main one is exchange variations, and it is what the majority of players aim for when they start using this defense. If you are playing Black, you will allow White to entirely dominate the center with its pawns, focusing your attention on the d4 square. So, instead of using its advantage in the center, White has to react to this threat and defend its d4 pawn. And with all the white player's pieces and pawns in the center, and no other possible strategy, things might get really nasty for White if he or she loses the focus.

For those white players who don't like to defend and always want to attack, the *Russian variation* allows them to give up their strong pawn center and get the queen involved, and by doing so pressure the black player.

The Benko Gambit

Moves: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 b5



The Benko Gambit is another popular and very well considered gambit, and it is the mainline stemming from Benoni Defense.

White can either decline or accept this gambit by using Nf3. In general, anyway, you will almost always witness White accepting with cxb5.

If you are playing Black, your primary goal is to give up a pawn early to gain a better advantage on the queenside, and then try to give up one more pawn with a6. Giving up their pawn is usually not a problem for Black because of the ideal attacking lines that result from the queenside of the attack.

If the white player wants to avoid getting into the mainline, defending their queenside throughout the game, then he or she will most likely give up a pawn and start focusing on the control of the center.

Remember, this opening isn't for faint-hearted players. It is a highly aggressive one and must be played accordingly.

Middlegame Strategies

So, what happens after an opening? According to Reuben Fine, a famous American chess player that was granted the title of International Grandmaster in 1950, there are three main factors to consider when reaching the so-called middlegame: king safety, force material, and mobility.

King safety is obviously our top priority, while the material is another essential thing to consider since, at this point of the game, any material advantage can be used to gain more and more material and may end up being decisive in the endgame. The aim of achieving mobility, on the other hand, is to make sure that your pieces count with a wide range of action and several targets to attack.

These factors require a very good strategy and a strategic way of thinking. Your aim must be to cultivate more and more small advantages that will eventually lead you to your main goal.

So let's have a look at the best options you have to get there.

Target Development

As we have just said, the best way for you to be crowned winner of the game is by building up a series of small advantages that will allow you to reveal your enemy's weaknesses. And there are essentially two ways to do this: either through weak pawns or through weak squares.

Weak pawns

The weak pawns are those that are open for attack and are unprotected either by being isolated or at the base of a vulnerable pawn chain. These types of vulnerabilities may be the result of your opponent's mistake or of your own action.



And if you want to become a good chess player, your aim should obviously be to force this type of situation instead of sitting there waiting for your enemy to make a bad move.

What is the best way to do it? Identifying the weak pawns among your enemy's camp and attack them. A good strategy to get to this point is the one known as *minority attack*: use your pawns to attack a pawn majority with the aim of leaving your opponent with weak squares and opening up lines.

Another good option is to always try to dominate the square directly in front of an isolated pawn of your opponent. This replaces any type of control your enemy may try to exert with that pawn (and other pieces too) to use its protection.

And it also allows you to virtually occupy critical square territory over your opponent and into his or her defense.

Weak Squares

Weak squares aren't as easy to identify as weak pawns, but don't worry: you will just have to learn how to detect them and understand how they can be used in your favor.



So, weak squares are those that pawns cannot defend. Generally, they are the perfect positions for minor pieces, especially if the weak square is placed in the middle of the board. Finding and taking control of weak squares can be as important as gaining a material advantage.

To give a practical example, we can see that in the image above, d5 is a weak square. Black cannot protect it with his or her pawns, while White controls it with the pawn e4.

White should then use this weak square to his or her advantage with 1.Bxf6! And White should also exchange pieces that are able to protect the d5 square. 1... Bxf6 2.Bd5! Bxd5 3.Nxd5. The last piece that could fight for d5 is gone, and now White has a dominant knight on d5 against a black bad bishop that is blocked by its own pawn structure. White has thus gained a strategically winning position.

In general, they are called weak squares because they bring to light the weaknesses of your opponent's strategy and territory while giving you power and control.

Watch out! You are not the only one looking for the weak squares of your enemy: your opponent will surely be doing the same, so always keep an eye on your own squares and make sure that you have them well covered.

Territorial Domination

After the opening game, the more space you control, the greater superiority you have over the direction of the game. So you should be working on your midgame strategy following this principle.

And how should you do that? By pushing your pawns forward. Anyway, don't forget: if you only focus on gaining space without protecting your front and back lines, you will end up being the perfect victim of your enemy's attack.

Making Your Advantages Significant

In order to make the best out of strategic advantages, it is essential to know when they really become relevant and how you can use them, also taking into account your enemy's advantages.

So always consider both your plans and possessions over your opponent's, and decide whose advantage is greater. If the answer is you, then confidently go ahead with your plan.

Taking this into account, also be always ready to change your strategy. Chess is a very dynamic game, and you need to be good at quickly finding alternatives if you can't go on with your plan A.

Essential tips for this stage of the game

Never bring out the queen too early

This is a pretty common mistake, especially among beginners. Bringing out the queen too early might make her vulnerable and even make you lose her. So, bring her out only when you have enough pieces of backing it up.

Bring the bishop and knight out instead!

Instead of your queen (or king and rooks), bring your bishops and knights to the center of the chessboard in order to start attacking. Since your knights can jump over the pawns, you don't need to remove them to move your knights. And when it comes to the bishops, in order to move them forward, you just have to move the pawns that are diagonal to them.

Attack and... defend as well

To attack your enemy's pieces is the only way you have to win the game. But at the same time, you also need to remember to double-check your moves before you make them in order not to expose any of your pieces, leaving them unprotected. A good defense is as important as a strong attack!

Time is gold

You need to remember that you don't need to move all your pawns to win the game. The contrary is actually true: the fewer moves, the better. So, if you notice your opponent wasting time moving all his or her pawns, then you know this is the perfect moment to develop your high-value pieces and take out as many of your enemy's pieces as possible.

Attack after the opening

So, when exactly does an opening end? Once you manage to move all your bishops and knights into the game. This is why during the middlegame, you should focus on trying to capture as many unprotected pieces of your opponent as possible. At the same time, as I suggested before, also think about your own pieces and don't leave them unprotected while trying to capture the ones of your enemy.

In general, always remember to position your army's pieces in such a way that allows you to attack and capture the king of your opponent.

Owning Your Last Stand

Please be aware of the fact that sometimes things will not be going the way you wanted to, especially toward the transition from the middlegame to the endgame. For example, you might be down by a few pieces or find yourself with a weakened defense. Do not panic; you still have options.

Actually, in certain situations, if you allow your opponent to stay busy mercilessly capturing your pieces, you can spot some secret pieces behind the enemy lines and conquer a win in a few well-planned moves.

What I am trying to say is that if you are able to find any kind of advantage within your remaining formation, you may still hope for a chance to win or at least to draw. So keep a cool head and NEVER stop attacking.

Endgame Strategies

So, here we are. This is the last part of the game. And if you have come this far, there are some things you should keep in mind in order to win the match you have battled so hard for.

Actually, one of the most common problems of chess players is that they know and understand effective opening strategies but lack knowledge about the endgame.

So, let's have a look at what you should do to avoid this kind of situation:

What to do with the king

To win a game in this last stage of the game, you should have an active and centralized king: if you don't have many other pieces left, the king may be the best piece to attack your enemy's pawns and defend your own.

But if you still have a good number of active pieces, then you should use them to attack your opponent and don't move the king at all, maintaining it safe and sound in its position.

Think twice about your next move

At this moment of the game, you should think about your next move very carefully. And you should never underestimate the importance of any of your pieces: in an endgame scenario, each one of them is just as important as the other. And talking about this, also remember to never isolate your pawns because you don't want to waste your time reaching out to their rescue...and of course, you don't want to lose them!

Pawns Exchange and Sacrifice

If you can count on a material advantage or if you get to gain a material advantage from this process, then you should exchange your pieces. But bear in mind: be very careful when exchanging your pawns if they are important for your endgame strategy.

Also, remember not to sacrifice your pawns without a good reason. But if you can do that for a greater purpose, such as allowing another pawn to develop into a queen, then go ahead and do it.

Take the King to the center

At the end of the game, your king becomes an offensive piece, and moving it to the center of the board becomes very important because it can help your other pieces. So do what you can to move your king to the center of the board and then fight to maintain this position. By doing so, you will also reduce the movement of the enemy's king, so don't let it go there first!

The importance of the rook

As you should know by now, the rook is a very important piece of your army, and in this stage of the game, you should move it into an attack pose in order to limit the movements of your opponent. If you have misplaced a rook, then, in this case, it could make sense to lose any pawn to make it gain an active position.

Avoid separating your pieces

We have already said that your pieces are like an army, and this is why you should keep them together and avoid separating them.

So remember to plan your strategy thinking of the best way to avoid your opponent attacking you and about how to keep your pieces together. Don't let your enemy pick your stranded pieces off: you will surely lose the game if you do so.

Are you winning? Then defend your army

You know by now that attacking your enemy is extremely important, but if you find yourself in the (excellent) situation in which your material outnumbers your opponents, then don't be silly: take a defensive approach and don't make crazy moves... you are already winning, and it would be stupid to take unnecessary risks.

Dos and Don'ts of the three stages of the game

So, we have talked about the most important moments of the match, and you probably feel a bit overwhelmed now. I know, it is a lot of information. This is why I would like to leave you a short recap of the basics of the Opening, Middlegame, and Endgame stages. I hope this will help you better memorize those essential tips that will surely help you win the game.

So come back to these pages anytime you need a brief refresh of what is most important to keep in mind.

Opening Stage

This stage normally refers to the first 10-12 moves of the match.

Dos:

- A) Control the center and always focus your attention on this part of the board.
- B) Develop your pieces, moving them towards the action of the game.
- C) Make the castling move.

Don'ts:

- A) Don't bring out the queen too soon.
- B) Develop your pieces but do not make too many pawn moves.
- C) Do not move your pawns in front of your castled king.

Middlegame Stage

This stage is considered to begin once the pieces are developed, the rooks are well connected, and the king has castled.

Dos:

- A) Anytime you have the possibility: make useful threats.
- B) Chase the enemy's pieces from your territory, or exchange them.
- C) Move your less active pieces to more active squares.

Don'ts:

- A) Never exchange your active pieces for your enemy's passive ones.
- B) Leave your pawns where they are unless you have a specific reason to move them.
- C) Never make meaningless moves.

Endgame Stage

The Middlegame turns into the Endgame once only a few pieces are left on the chessboard, and the kings can finally join the action.

Dos:

- A) Always try to cut your enemy's king from the action
- B) Try to create a protected passed pawn.
- C) Make your king join the fun and take it to the center of the board.

Don'ts:

- A) Think very well about your next move: the Endgame is a very dangerous phase of the game.
- B) Keep your pieces together and do not allow your enemy to separate them
- C) Don't sacrifice your pieces unless you have a very good reason to do so.

Extra suggestions and conclusion

So, we have reached the final part of this book, and I would like to leave you with a few additional general suggestions.

One thing you always have to keep in mind when playing chess is the importance of a good balance between offensive and defensive strategies. Why? Most chess beginners rush to take the offensive way in order to crush their opponent as fast as possible. Although this kind of game can be pretty spectacular, it is very complicated to win the match, especially when playing against an experienced opponent that can easily detect the flaws and holes in your defense. This is why, very often, the best players just wait for their enemies to make a mistake. And this is also why you have to see your chessboard as a battlefield, where you must defend your king, and at the same time, try to take your enemy's capitol. And an army that runs to the battlefield with no defensive protection whatsoever, sooner than later, will experience a humiliating defeat.

So follow my advice: always start your game in a balanced way. If you really want to win the game, both your offensive and defensive strategies must be very well planned. Actually, a moment will come in which the best offensive move will just be to wait for your enemy to start an offensive attack and recognize the flaws in his or her moves. This way, you will detect the holes in your opponent's defense, instead of giving them the possibility to discover your own weaknesses.

Another important suggestion I would like to leave you with is to know very well at least one opening. There are thousands of chess openings, and to try to master them all, especially at the beginning of your chess journey, is not only impossible but also something that will leave you extremely confused.

Will your opponent eventually be able to predict your next steps in an easier way if you often use the same opening? Maybe, but only if you always play against the same person. And, in any case, it is always better to play a game you are comfortable and confident with.

Also, start playing safe and sensible moves instead of trying at all costs to find some highly impressive and sophisticated shot to end the game in just a few moves. You won't even have the time to come up with such an impossible strategy, and you will end up being flagged and lose the match, especially if you are playing in a blitz game. So, watch the clock and play reasonable moves.

What else? Well, this might sound pretty obvious, but I will never get tired of stressing it. You are playing chess, so you must keep the focus on the game. This means you shouldn't get up and do other things or try to relax in between moves. You might end up making some terrible mistake once you are back in front of the chessboard!

And then, carefully plan every move. Sometimes actually, certain tactics don't work because you've just calculated them in the wrong move order. So get used to always plan, even during a blitz game. It will be complicated, and there will be so many things you will have to think about, but this kind of training will help you think the right way. And eventually, it will become second nature to you, and you won't even have to consciously plan at all.

Also, keep in mind that you cannot win if you cannot checkmate. A king and queen may checkmate a lonely king only when the king helps out.

A rook and a king can checkmate an alone warrior by pushing it to the border of the board and creating a waiting movement at the perfect moment to pressure the enemy's king to walk to a one-move checkmate. It is extremely important to understand the appropriate method in these kinds of moves. Most winning positions might be obtained by queening a pawn and then performing the key king and queen checkmate. So study and exercise accordingly!

And maybe the most important suggestion of all: don't give up! It will be challenging at the beginning, but if you abandon the game, you have already lost. So keep studying and practicing and when you are playing, just fight until the end.

I hope you have enjoyed this book and that you feel confident enough to start playing chess. Can you consider yourself an expert now? Of course not (that will surely take some time!), but you undoubtedly have the grounds to understand the game and begin to practice with a certain degree of confidence.

Remember: every Grandmaster has been a beginner at some point. And only by reading, studying and, above all, exercising you will be able to comprehend and make the different strategies yours.

So play, and play against any kind of opponent: it is okay to start exercising in front of a computer, but only by challenging real people (they can be beginners like you or more advanced players, it doesn't really matter at this point), you will improve yourself and enjoy this beautiful game.

PART 2

chess openings for beginners

The Ultimate And Definitive Guide To Learn Chess Board
Rules And Start Playing With The Best Tactics and
Efficient Strategies.

Introduction

Welcome to this book "Chess Openings for Beginners."

Chess is a game for two players that was invented in India and spread to Europe. It became an important part of the courtly culture of Europe. In the western world, chess has been prominent on college campuses and in intellectual circles years before the general public took notice.

Chess is a game divided into two distinct parts: the opening is the first phase of the chess game, and the middlegame/endgame is the second.

Chess openings are basically the first few moves of a chess game that are made by both players. Some of the chess openings are recognized to be very strong and some not so much. If a player can find a "good" chess opening then that player will possibly dominate the game. Some chess openings are very well known such as: Ruy Lopez, King's Gambit, Sicilian Defense, and the English Opening. Many chess players find that a chess opening is a big part of the game and can be very useful.

Why are chess openings important? Because if you can get an advantage at the beginning of the game, then you will most likely end up winning.

And how do you know which chess opening is “Good?” There are three main things that you should look at when analyzing a chess opening. These three things are: The popularity of the opening, the percentage of wins with that opening, and what books say about it.

You want to find an opening that is popular with many people but also has the highest percentage of wins for the player that uses it. Look at what books have to say about it, as Grandmasters probably know how to use that opening well. Then after finding an appropriate chess opening for yourself, try experimenting with it as much as you can so that you know how to do everything in it like: Castling, attacking pawns, defending pieces, etc.

This book “Chess Openings for Beginners,” talks about the chess openings: The Sicilian Defense, Ruy Lopez, King’s Gambit, English Opening, and the Slav Defense, and many more.

This book is written in a manner that a beginner would most probably understand and find useful. It also has many pages of diagrams, pictures, examples of moves, and endgames. Also, in it you will discover some of the most fascinating histories behind chess openings.

With this book you will get familiar with chess notation too: you may have heard scare stories that make chess notation extremely difficult. This complexity of chess notation is a fallacy spread by people who are too lazy to learn how simple and logical it is.

When playing chess, you must remember that the ultimate goal is to checkmate your opponent’s king. However, you must get past your opponent’s defenses before attempting this very difficult task. Therefore, it is imperative to understand the “good” chess openings and how to use them to your advantage!

So, shall we begin?

Basics on Chess

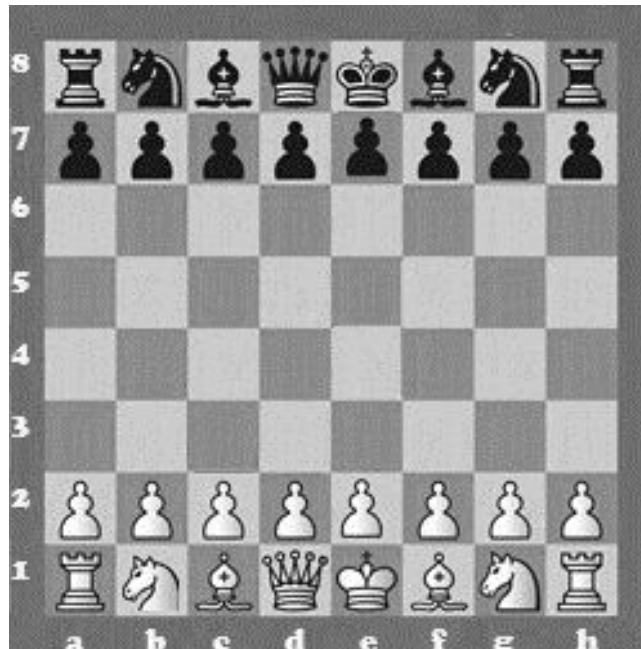
Chess is a fascinating board game that has challenged the imagination, creativity, and analytical prowess of people for thousands of years. Once reserved for the nobility, chess is now enjoyed by millions of people all over the world. It is a classic game between two players who have one ultimate goal in mind: to threaten the opponent's king with a move that leads to an eventual capture. The road to victory, however, is usually paved with traps, decoys, and tricks. A player with adequate preparation, strategic skills, and mindset will have significant advantages over one who lacks a sound game plan and plays the game randomly.

Winning chess games consistently requires time, focus, and serious preparation. This book is designed for beginners (and advanced chess players too) who want to improve their game and take their skills to the next level.

The Chessboard

Chess is played by two people using a chessboard with 64 squares of alternating colors – eight rows and 8 columns. Each player starts with sixteen chess pieces: 8 pawns, 2 knights, 2 bishops, 2 rooks, 1 queen, and 1 king.

Here are how the chess pieces are arranged at startup:



The rows are called ranks while the columns are called files.

The Chess Pieces

- The pawn

The pawns are usually the first ones to go to battle. From its starting position, the pawn can move up to two squares forward. Away from its original square, it can only move one square ahead and can never go backward. It captures opposing pieces one square diagonally forward on its left or right side. The pawn may also capture the enemy's pawn using the "En Passant" (in passing) rule.

While it has many weaknesses, a pawn is the only chessman that can be promoted. A pawn that has reached the back rank of the opponent can be exchanged for a knight, bishop, rook, or queen. There is no limit to how many pawns may be promoted.

- The knights

The knight is the only piece that can jump over other pieces. This capability allows it to be the only other piece besides a pawn that can make the initial move in a chess game. The knight moves or jumps in an L-shaped pattern - one square to its left or right and two squares forward/backward or two squares forward/backward and one square to the left or right.

- The bishops

The bishops move diagonally in any number of squares as long as it is not restricted by other pieces. Each side has two bishops at the start. One controls the light-shaded squares while the other moves along with the dark-shaded ones. The bishops cannot jump over other pieces like the knight.

- The rooks

A rook moves on a straight line from left to right or forward and backward. It can go from one end of the board to the other in one move if there are no intervening pieces. It cannot jump over other pieces the way a knight does, however. Along with the king, the rook takes part in a special chess move called “castling.”

- The queen

The queen has the most powerful attacking capabilities on the chessboard. Except for its inability to jump over other pieces, the queen combines the attack moves of other chess pieces. It can move diagonally like the bishops and horizontally or vertically like the rooks.

- The king

Although it lacks the attacking prowess of the queen, the king is the most important piece on the board. The player whose king is captured immediately loses the game. A capture happens when the king is attacked and could not make a legal move or could not be defended by other chess pieces.

A king has very limited movements. Unless it is castling, a king can only move one step away from its current position. It can capture pawns and other stray pieces and can be used in the end game to strategically restrict the actions of the opposing king

Basic Chess Terms

Attack	Moving a piece to a square where it can capture an opponent
Double attack	An attack moves against two or more enemy pieces at the same time
Fianchetto	To develop a bishop on the square in front of the adjacent knight

Minor pieces	bishops and knights
Major pieces	Queens and rooks
Capture	To remove an opponent's chessman through a legal move
Check	To attack or threaten the king
Chessman	All movable figures on the chessboard
Promotion	Converting a pawn to a queen, bishop, knight, or rook after advancing to the eighth rank
Queenside	The a-d files
Kingside	The e-h files
Zugzwang	A situation where a player is forced to make a move that is detrimental to his position
Back rank	A player's first rank

How to Identify a Chess Opening

What Is an Opening?

If you begin in the wrong direction, you can easily get lost forever – and lose everything you have in the process. That is for ordinary travel; and so it is for the game of chess. That is why you need to know the best chess opening moves. And the best ones are those that ensure you do not make your chess arrangement weak; you do not make yourself vulnerable to your opponent. They are also those moves that make you a threat to your opponent's pieces.

Whereas any beginning of a chess game is generally referred to as *opening*, formal use is usually in reference to the set of moves that you make in a certain sequence at the start of the game, which is normally referred to as openings by White; or defenses by Black. Do you know what will amaze you? It is said that you have at your disposal well over a thousand chess openings! Of course, that is quite a long sequence pushing up to the middle game.

Importance

In chess, you can form millions of combinations with pieces on the board. Some have said there are more chess piece combinations than grains of sand on every beach on planet earth. When you start the game with an opening, you're ensuring you're playing a game you're familiar with. If your friend isn't familiar with your opening (and if they're not a trained chess player, they won't be) then you will win the opening.

Let me give you an example: I used to be an avid Super Smash Bros player. The version for N64. I was very good and I always used to beat my friend Greg.

Well, Greg was trying to get me to play the newest version of Super Smash Bros on GameCube. He'd been playing it for like a year, but for some reason, we always played the N64 version.

Well, one day he says, "Why don't we change things up and play Smash for GameCube?" And I'm thinking, it doesn't matter to me. I always win at Super Smash. It's the same game, right?

Wrong.

Greg stomped on me. Why? Same rules. Same buttons. Mostly the same characters. I should've won. But I didn't because Greg knew the nuances of the GameCube Smash better than me. Greg had an advantage because he knew the slight changes in physics and items, and levels better than me. He had the home-court advantage.

This is like an opening. When you use an opening, you have a home-court advantage. You're playing a game you know and your friend doesn't.

Knowing an opening has other benefits too. If you know what piece to move at the beginning of the game, you'll be confident you know exactly what to do. Therefore, reducing decision fatigue and giving you more brain energy for the Middle and Endgame.

Since I want to teach you the fastest and most effective way to learn openings, I've very carefully curated which openings I'm going to show you. They're all openings I've personally used and still use regularly.

Do you always have to use an opening? No. In fact, many times you won't be able to accomplish your whole opening. Other times you'll simply want to do things your own way.

Difference Between Move and Opening

An opening is identified by a sequence of initial moves made in a chess game. Most serious chess players devote a great part of their study and preparation to openings. Studying game openings and theory early on can give you a definite advantage whether you're playing against a beginner or a chess expert.

Opening play strategies generally feature the following factors:

- Control of the center
- Development
- King's safety
- Pawn structure

The type of play you choose in the opening makes a big difference in a game's turnout. There are no cheap tricks in chess. You have to take time to study and memorize the special moves of the openings that you want to play. Becoming a competitive chess player takes time, effort, and discipline. While there are many types of opening plays and variations, you can incorporate the following opening principles and guidelines in your game:

- Develop your pieces as rapidly as possible.

Developing pieces involves positioning your pieces on squares where they can be most useful. Knights and bishops can help establish control on the center and set up attacking opportunities. You would normally bring your knights and bishops out ahead of the major pieces. To open the diagonals for your bishop, you should move your center pawn strategically.

- Develop the knights before the bishops.

The knights should be the first pieces to be developed. Knights are most useful if positioned towards the center area where they can maximize their attacking range and help control the central squares. You'll have more opportunities to place your knights in optimal position within the first few moves of the game as both sides have few pieces out at this stage.

- Avoid moving a piece twice in the opening stage.

Your ability to develop your pieces to their optimal squares as rapidly as possible could make the difference between winning and losing a game. You should develop your pieces as early as possible and you should not waste time on uncertain moves that you'll have to retract soon after. Never move a piece more than once in the opening unless it is actually necessary. Moving a piece two or three times in the opening plays is not only a waste of your precious time. It is also counterproductive. Strive to develop all your pieces rather than launch attacks using one or two pieces.

- Don't take the queen out prematurely.

The queen indeed seems invincible with its attacking powers that many beginning players try to bring it out in the early opening moves in the hopes of gaining material and perhaps a positional advantage. The queen's special abilities, however, are the very reasons why you should not develop the queen in the first moves of the game. Doing so will just expose the queen to attacks and tricks of the opponent who, for his part, is in the process of developing his knight and bishops. Once your queen is threatened, you'll have no choice but to move it to a safe square, a real time-waster at a point where your goal is to develop your pieces rapidly and take control of the center. It is smarter to develop your minor pieces first before developing the queen.

- Try to make moves that threaten your opponent while developing your pieces.

Introducing threats while developing your pieces is a good strategy to force your opponent to be defensive and reactive, and disrupt his progress in the opening phase. Your opening attacks should be well-woven in your development moves so as not to waste your time and delay your own progress.

- Advance one or two pawns first.

Developing your pieces early is an important opening strategy but this doesn't include the pawns. Advancing most pawns early on can create holes behind the pawns and weaken your defense. You should focus instead on

advancing the pawns on the king and queen's file to control the center squares and allow your pieces to be developed optimally.

- Keep the king safe by castling early.

The king is a natural target for attacks at all phases of the game. Castling early is vital to protect your king from tricky moves and dangerous possibilities in the opening stage. You can prepare your king for castling without wasting valuable time by developing your pieces in such a way that you're clearing the squares between the king and the rook while placing your pieces in their best squares

- Avoid opening plays that create weaknesses in the pawn structure.

Pawn structure is a positional element that is likely to stick for a long time in the game. A weakened pawn structure can compromise a player's defensive and attacking strategies. You should avoid making moves that create weaknesses such as isolated pawns, backward pawns, and doubled pawns. If you can find an opportunity, you can try to lead your opponent to overextend his pawn structure or form weak pawn positions.

Tactics and Opening Plays

You should always look for tactical opportunities in every position right from the first few moves of the game. Here are opening game features that can help you create plans and incorporate tactics during the game:

The f-pawns are weak pawns that can only be defended by the king. You can score a checkmate simply by focusing your attacks on the f-pawn.

Use pawn sacrifices to gain positional advantage or enhance the development of your pieces. The Queen's Gambit, for instance, is a potentially powerful pawn sacrifice that may lead to advantages in position and material.

Avoid taking gambits that you haven't studied. Gambits, after all, are made to gain an advantage in succeeding plays.

Study and memorize different openings and use them in your plays until you have mastered them. Playing open and semi-open games presents challenges and opportunities to hone your tactical skills. Learn the tactical features of your chosen opening to set traps against your opponent and prevent being tricked into forming weak positions.

If you are playing with a weaker opponent, you can take advantage of his inferior tactical skills by introducing excellent tactics right from the beginning. Play and develop your pieces aggressively and push your e-pawn.

Opening Games

Openings can be grouped into three main categories:

1. White can start the game by playing e4. This is a popular option that has many advantages. This move allows white to instantly control the center and immediately frees the light-squared bishop and the queen.

Black may elect to respond by mirroring the move and moving his pawn to e5 to achieve the same results. This leads to openings such as the King's gambit, Giuoco Piano (Italian Game), and the Ruy Lopez. The 1.e4 e5 opening play is called an open game as the moves open the ranks, files, and diagonals on both sides.

Black may also respond with a move other than e5 and this can lead to openings such as the French Defense, Caro-Kann, Pirc Defense, and Sicilian Defense.

2. White can start the game by playing d4. The play has its own advantages. The queen's pawn is instantly protected by the queen. The move also opens the diagonal for the dark-squared bishop.

Black may choose to respond by mimicking d4 with d5 to make it a closed game. This can lead to openings such as the Queen's Gambit, Slav Defense, and Semi-Slav Defense.

Black may elect to respond with other moves which can lead to openings such as the King's Indian Defense, Queen's Indian Defense, Nimzo-Indian Defense, and the Catalan Opening.

3. White can open the game with a move other than d4 and e4. This category includes flank openings and irregular openings. This may lead to openings such as Réti Opening and the English opening.

Basic Opening Principles

Chess Opening



Strategies openings appear to be psychologically challenging games or chess strategies that have been implemented to improve control of the actual center of the exact chessboard in the main starting game. This starting performance begins along with this primary phase. It ends at any time 1 participant has apparent control over the very center surface, which is right after around ten movements each. Sometimes the middle of any board is composed of four pieces immediately in the center of all chess boards. Management involved with the actual centerboard will make it a lot more difficult for the challenger to attack and advance. As a consequence, treat involving your middle board would be a definite, remarkably valued advantage.

Since managing a specific centerboard, a well-finished, mentally stimulating starting game would certainly also allow your current main pieces to help you get out of this back row to be practiced for an approaching or even defensive reason. Also, the openings must protect concerning the king (like the castling king-side) as well as not holding a king in a very uncertain role.

There are a variety of tried and tested "principles" that should be kept to any time a good start is played actively. As follows:

Immediately advance your knights. Knights can approach many squares and are excellent for the defense of the middle board.

Don't develop chess pieces on one side only. This tends to encourage the competition to take advantage of the middle board. Sections of your board can be more of a profit.

Avoid attacks that are too serious. Keep in mind that there are opportunities in place to set up security placements.

Please start the backline. Let your essential pieces have room to breathe.

The bishop or the knight (3 points) is worth three pawns (3 points). When you give up the knight and get three pawns in return, you can make it more or less an even trade. When you lose a knight (3 points) for only a pawn (1 point), you have suffered material, and you should lose the game if you play against an expert.

When you win a rook (5 points) for a bishop or a knight, you get 3 points, and you are said to have "won the Exchange." If you then lose a rook (5 points) for a bishop or a knight (3 points), you have "lost the Exchange."

As a chess player, you tend to lose games from time to time — like other chess players, —, but managing well a good amount of openings will reduce significantly the losses.

Types of Openings

Openings can be divided into four types, depending on the pieces involved in your first few moves. These opening types are the following:

- King or Queen Pawn Openings – being the pieces at the front of each side during the start of the game, pawns are usually moved first. However, the most common would be moving the pawns directly in front of the queen and/or the king. For White, their d and e pawns will be moving to the fourth row. Aside from providing an open space so that bishops can be developed early on, the king or queen opening enables the player to gain control of the center area.

- Gambit opening – a “gambit” in chess refers to a strategy wherein the player is offering “bait” (which is often an undefended pawn) to the opponent. This bait aims to entice the opponent into moving differently to gain a lead in developing the player’s pieces. A gambit opening can be queen’s or king’s, depending on which side the bait originated. For example, if the opponent (who’s playing Black) matched your pawn to e4 move with a pawn to e5, you can move your King’s side pawn to f4, allowing Black to capture the pawn. If Black accepts the gambit, it will bring a development advantage to your side because you can now do a queen pawn opening to square d4 and further control the center. A gambit opening can also be used in combination with the other openings.

- Flank Openings – if, suppose you’re playing White and your opening move doesn’t involve moving the king and queen pawns first, you are doing a flank opening. Pieces included in flank openings include moving any pawn from the queen and kingside (squares a through c and f through h, respectively) or moving either knight.

- Irregular openings – opening moves that are rare and are not always observed in a game can be considered as irregular openings. Mostly irregular openings involve the movement of the pawn that does not take advantage of the “two square moves” from their starting position.

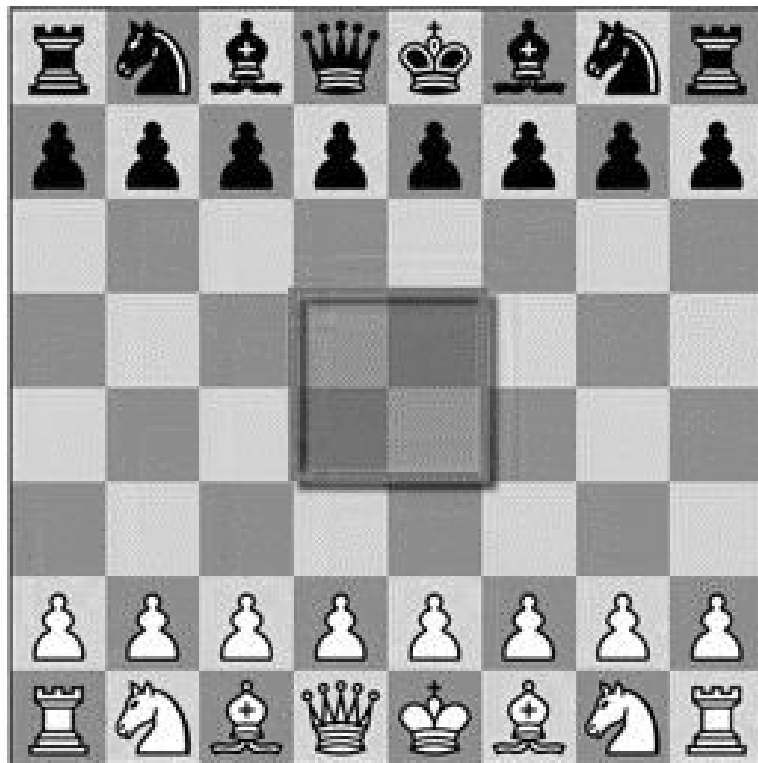
By knowing the first moves of your opponent, you will have an idea as to the game plan that they are trying to accomplish to win the game.

Chess Openings Top Rules for Beginners

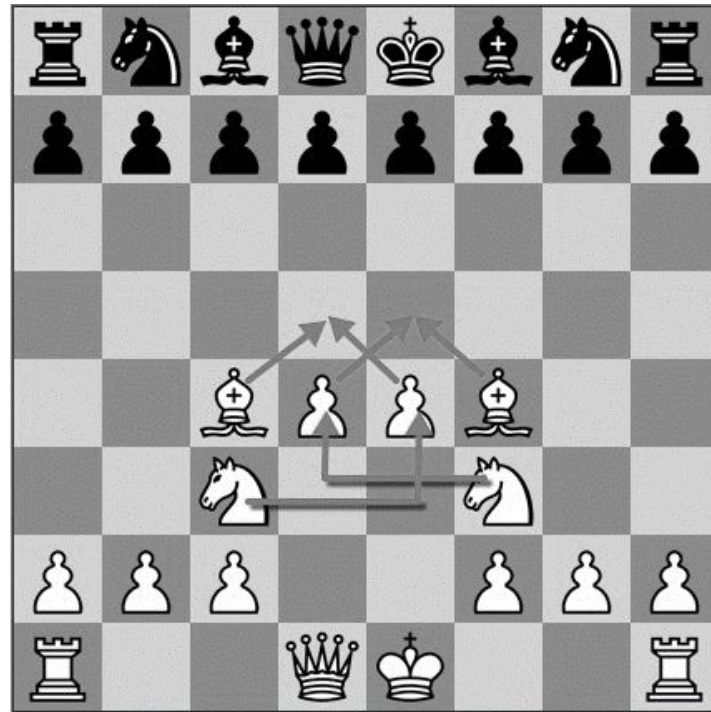
Control the Center

In the first five moves of the game, you're unlikely to take any of your opponent's pieces without losing one of your own. So, you want to fight for the next best thing: The Center. Whoever controls the center controls the game.

Just to refresh. What do I mean by the center? *In the picture below*, I've highlighted the four squares that make up the center.



At the beginning of the game, every move you make should fight to control those four squares. Most likely your first move will be one of those center pawns followed by your knights and your bishops. In the picture below, I show what your pieces would look like if they were developed to target those four squares.



Why is it so important to control the center?

Let's use an analogy to another sport. In Soccer, have you ever seen a team fight to protect the sidelines? Have you ever seen a goalie stand in the corner of the goal while an opponent drives up the middle? I hope for the sake of your sporting enjoyment, you did not.

Here's another analogy. In Football, your pawns are like your Offensive line. If your Offensive line fails to control the center of the line of scrimmage, an opposing player is likely to run through and sack your Quarterback.

Center control is closely related to development. They're two sides of one coin. If you control the center, it makes it hard for your opponent to develop his pieces past the center or move his good pieces toward your king. The center is the fastest and easiest place to damage your opponent from. So, the person who controls it has far more opportunities to attack.

The *image below* shows a real beginner game where Black has firm control of the center while White has not even tried. Notice that the four squares in the middle are either taken or protected by Black.



Now I'm going to show the effects Black's control of the center has over White.

In the *image above*, Black is dominating the center of the board. See the corresponding letters in the *image above* to get a visual of what I'm talking about:

Exhibit A: White's knight would love to move down and gobble up Black's pawn and Fork the queen and rook, but White would lose his knight. If he had another piece to protect his knight (like a bishop) he would fare much better. But since Black controls the center, White has no chance of bringing in a bishop or any other piece.

Exhibit B: White's two bishops (*Circled above*) are both stuck behind pawns. White's queenside bishop could move down and attack Black's bishop, but in the best-case scenario they would cancel each other out.

Exhibit C: White's knight is pinned to the king, so it can't move. Again, not helping White's cause.

Exhibit D: White moves the rook pawns, presumably to make room for his rook. But all it's really done is wasted precious opening moves. His rook is still stuck.

In summary, when you control the center, you have more moves available to you. YOU make the choices about how the game proceeds, which you can convert into winning unequal trades.

Develop Your Pieces

Developing your Pieces is moving your attacking pieces toward your enemy. In the opening, the main pieces you want to develop are your bishops and knights. We develop these pieces first because they help to control the center and put pressure on the enemy camp at the same time.

Why not the rook or the queen? You don't want to develop your rooks or your queen in the opening for two reasons: First, they're too valuable to develop first. If you move your queen out or somehow manage to move your rook out, you'll spend the opening trying to defend them instead of developing your other pieces and controlling the center.

In the case of your rooks, it simply takes too long to move the pieces out of the way to develop your rook. So, you might as well develop your bishops and knights first. Then you can castle and moving your rook is a lot easier.

Here are some sub-principles of *Developing your Pieces*.

1. Avoid moving the same piece twice.

Within the first 5 moves, you don't want to move the same piece twice. Every time you move a piece twice you lose an opportunity to develop your piece and your enemy has a chance to get closer.

The only time to move your piece twice is when you're going to lose the piece for no good reason. But the more you play, the less this happens.

2. Develop your pieces to protect your other pieces

In order to control the center, you'll want to protect the pieces that are in the Center. Remember the bullhead image I showed you in *Control the Center*? Those pieces are all protecting other pieces that are in the center and they are protected by other pieces. That's how you ensure your opponent can't take your centerpieces. It's like Jenga. If you leave too many pieces dangling unsupported, your whole structure is going to come down.

3. Stay on your half of the board

Later on I'm going to show you how you can break this rule. But for now, just know that you want to stay on your own half of the board (the half closest to you) in the first 5 moves because that's how you're going to maintain control of the center and keep your king safe.

4. Don't block your own pieces

It's important to know anyway. *Don't block your own pieces.*

For the same reason you need to control the center, you don't want to block your own pieces so you can develop as many pieces as possible. Of course, sometimes your opponent will force you to block your own pieces. But you certainly shouldn't do it without a fight.

5. Develop your knights before your bishops

This is a rule of thumb. This principle assumes knights are more valuable than bishops at the beginning of the game. Knights are great at the beginning of the game because they can jump over other pieces. Since there are more pieces to jump over in the beginning as opposed to the end, this makes them more valuable. Also, knights tend to protect bishops and it doesn't usually work the other way around.

Castle Early, Castle Often

You want to Castle as early as possible. This opens up your rook, protects your king, and frees up your queen. In general, you want to castle within the first 10 moves.

Don't Move Your Queen

It's important not to move your queen. Not even one space unless you absolutely must. Moving your queen sets you up for problems. Remember your queen protects your king and your other pieces.

Each of these principles is a guideline to keep you on track for taking control of the center and taking control of the game. There are always situations where following the guideline might not be the best thing for you. So, you must develop the experience to know when you should follow it and when you shouldn't. I highly recommend that if you're learning openings, start out by following the rules so you know what it looks and feels like. Later, you'll know when to sacrifice for the greater good.

Most Important Don'ts

Why do you think competing drivers take a route test a couple of days before the actual rally takes place? It's not, obviously, to find out the best places to have a stopover and take a cup of tea – there are designated areas for that. The main reason is to find out what shortcomings the route presents, so they can design ways of circumventing them.

When it comes to chess, you need to do the same thing if you want to win; or even be a formidable force – learn the main errors that players make and then find out how to avoid doing them yourself. Luckily, you've got this chess guide to help you.

Guard against the following chess mistakes:

Leaving Your King Exposed

What, in the name of competition, are you doing, if at any moment you are leaving your king unprotected? It is tempting, of course, to go for gambits; those opportunities you get to sacrifice a piece or two of your own to secure a strategic position, but if in chasing gambits you expose your king, then you are missing the basics. In some African cultures, they call it losing four as you make a dash for two. In chess, you are still in the game until you lose your king. What else could be as important as protecting him? Failure to carefully protect your king very often leads to an embarrassingly early checkmate.

Failure to Develop Your Chess Pieces

Have you watched some people as they begin a game of chess and one of them seems to mark time just around the starting rows – moving the queen here and the pawn there and then bringing the queen back and so on? Some novices try to apply some advanced tactics often shown on videos, and in their view, they are lying in waiting for an opportune moment to strike heavy on the opponent's particular piece, often one of the strong ones. But then what, as a novice, what you fail to understand is that your opponent has eyes and a tactical mind too. And so, very likely, they can read your plan as you joke around.

To be forewarned is to be forearmed. So, now that your opponent has seen right through your devious mind, do you expect them to leave any loophole; any piece unprotected? In short, your opponent continues to develop their pieces as they keep the others safe, and by the time you realize that the chance you are timing to capture your opponent's queen or bishop or whatever other big piece is not forthcoming, it will be an uphill task to begin developing your pieces. Your opponent will have occupied all the strategic locations and will be in full control of the middle part of the chessboard.

In short, stop allowing your opponent an early lead. If you cannot lead, at least, be at par with your opponent. What you logically need to ask yourself is: if you are out to fight, how would you expect your army to win if you have not allowed any soldiers into the battleground? You need to develop your chess pieces from the word, *go*.

That way, you will have great mobility for your pieces and you can easily enjoy the dynamic play. Besides, when you have developed your pieces well and thus dominated the center of the chessboard, you are able to attack your opponent's pieces more effectively and with less risk.

Experts advise that you just adopt this rule until you become a chess master: For your very first six moves, develop every piece that you touch. That means, get them from their home position in the 1st and 2nd ranks and advance them towards the center of the chessboard. And whenever you can, let your move be protective of another piece, in the meantime. Soon, you'll be controlling the center of the board. It will not be you on the receiving end but you calling the shots.

Copying Your Opponent's Every Move

I don't want you to be ahead of me so the minute you move your queen, I also go for mine; and when you move your bishop, I move mine. Surely, if I'm your opponent and I realize that you are aping my moves, am I not going to lead you to the gallows? In fact, often when you copycat, you end up hitting a dead end, and before you realize it, you'll be facing a rude checkmate. Of course, it doesn't mean that you are prohibited from making a particular move just because your opponent made a similar move ahead of you; all you need to do is to ensure that you have a good reason to make whatever move that you choose.

Using Your Queen Very Early

So, do you imagine you can play around with your queen and call checkmate in only five moves just because a video on YouTube said so? Think again – fundamentals cannot be ignored without repercussions. Develop your pieces systematically. These other shortcuts that you see online, including the Scholar's mate, cannot do your game any good if you haven't mastered the art of developing your pieces and how to use your domination of the middle area of the chessboard.

Bringing out your queen early risks an attack on her and also as you try to shield her by taking her back and forth, you waste so much time that you get late to develop your other pieces. The result...? As you have already read above, you end up lagging behind in taking charge of the middle area of the chessboard. And instead of attacking, you'll find yourself playing defense against your opponent.

Let's imagine a situation where a novice thought that the queen would threaten pieces on the opponent's side from the start of the game and so moved the queen straight to h5. Since the black player isn't dozing, he or she can move the black knight to f6 in quick protection.

Will you have made any progress? Let's say for now, no; because sooner or later you may find it necessary to retract that queen from h5 to a more productive place. And yet, you'll have wasted an opportunity to develop another piece with that initial move.

Wasting Tempos

Yes, tempos are not just in music – they are in chess too. Whenever it is your turn to make a move in chess, it is a tempo. So, if you make a move and after your opponent moves you follow with another move, those are two tempos for you right there. In a situation where you move your bishop, say twice consecutively, it beats logic because you had no limitation as to how far you could have moved your bishop in the first instance. So, effectively, the second tempo was a total waste. Taking a practical example, why move your white bishop in two moves when one is enough to get him on b5?

What's the big deal with many similar moves? Well, it is wastage. In chess, as you can see, pieces and tempos are resources. You need a strong piece or a strategically located piece to threaten your opponent, and you need an opportunity to make the move – the tempo. So, you need to think carefully before you utilize any of the two. You also need to remember that every move you make that does not add real value to your game, or which is so badly made that it amounts to a tempo waste, is also a lost opportunity to develop another piece.

Being Clumsy on The Chessboard

Look – the game of chess is one where you play with caution, not just because you want to be strategic, but also because you want to do what you mean. Someone may wonder, really, is there a chance of doing what you don't mean, anyway? Yes, there is. You may think long and hard on your next move, but then get careless at the last minute when trying to weigh two options.

Here are some careless mistakes that can be costly to you:

- Touching one of your pieces inadvertently

If you touch one of your chess pieces during your turn to play, you have no choice but to play it even if it isn't the one you had planned to move. Now, it may be that any move you make with that piece at that moment is dangerous and the piece is bound to be captured, but the rule holds – if you touch it and it's your turn, you've got to move it.

Exception:

However, if you don't like the way a particular piece of yours is sitting on the board and you'd like to adjust it, you can do it on one condition: that you declare audibly, *j'adoube!* Are you wondering what this means? It means I adjust. And yes, you guessed right – it's French.

- Touching your opponent's pieces inadvertently

Again, if you touch it, you've got to move it. If the piece you inadvertently touched happens to belong to your opponent, you must utilize any room there is to capture it, whether the move is going to advance your cause or not. The only time you can get away with it is if there is no opportunity to capture that piece. Otherwise, it doesn't matter if capturing it would jeopardize the piece you use; as the rule stands, if you touch it, you must act on your touch by capturing the piece.

- Hastening to make a move

Ha! Do you think expert chess players just happen to be time-wasters? No way! They know that once you make a move, that is, move your chess piece in play, you cannot change your mind. A chess moves once made is not reversible – you’ve got to live with the consequences. That’s why it’s advisable to take your time when it’s your turn to play, checking out all the possible moves that you could make, and evaluating the impact of each option.

Make Lessons Out of Your Mistakes

Do you think a good game of chess would ever end if no player made a wrong move? Simply put, mistakes are part and parcel of a game – and not just chess, but any game. The best you can do is to learn from those mistakes. If you castled late and your king’s position was, therefore, jeopardized, you can’t afford to repeat that same mistake in another game. And so, over time you become a better chess player.

Most Popular White's Openings

White has the advantage of making the first move and being able to set the pace of the game. Thus, the right preparation must be made if they want to improve their chance of winning the game.

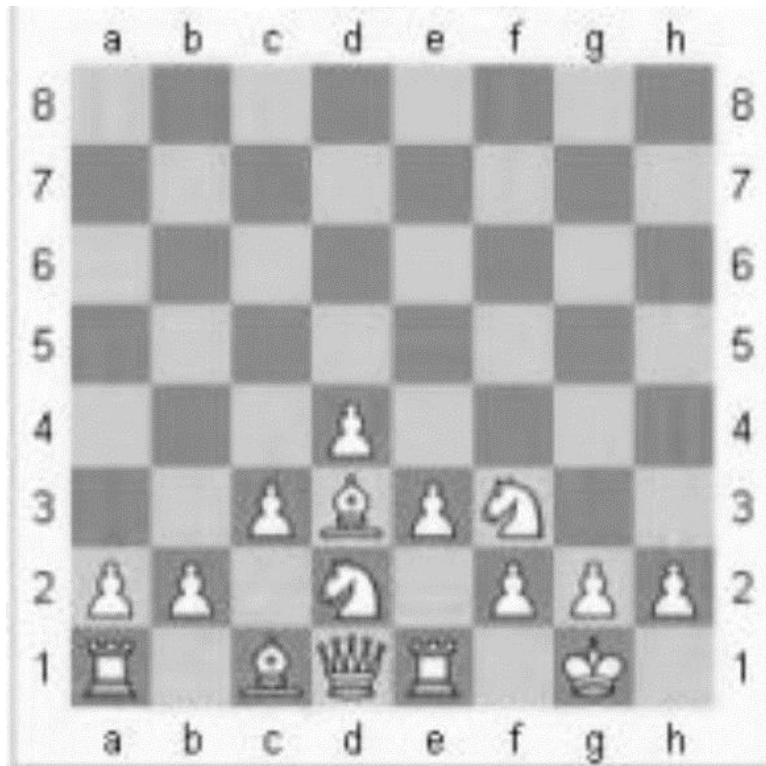
Colle System

This opening strategy, which can also be called the Colle-Koltanowski system, was formulated by Edgar Colle during the 1920s and was improved by George Koltanowski.

The Colle system stemmed from the queen pawn opening, and features the following moves (ignoring the moves of the opponent):

- Move Queen's pawn to d4
- Kingside knight moves to f3
- King's pawn to e3
- Bishop on b1 moves to d3
- Kingside castle
- Castled rook moves to e1
- C pawn moves to c3
- Queenside knight moves to d2
- A pawn in e3 moves to e4

This image will help you to visualize what the board should look like when using the Colle system (before the pawn in e3 is moved to e4):



The order of the movements can be interchanged, as long as all pieces should be in place within 9 moves. The Colle system allows for a good way to develop your minor pieces (the knight and the bishop), gain some control of the center with the d4 pawn and a threat from the f3 horse on any piece that will occupy e5, open paths for your non-pawn pieces (especially the queen), and move the king away from the center as early as possible.

Reti System

Another opening system that was developed earlier than the Colle system but is still an effective opening method is the Reti system. Developed during the late 1800s by chess player Richard Reti, this opening only involves two moves for White.

White moves g1 knight to f3 (Black will most likely move its queenside pawn to d5)

White's C pawn moves to square c4.

In the Reti system, the board must look like this:



In this opening system, it is easy to observe that Reti applies the flank opening and combines it with a gambit, making use of the “wings” rather than a direct approach to control the center area. The movement of White’s knight to f3 forces Black to avoid making the usual e5 pawn opening. If Black moves its queenside pawn, the c4 pawn will be offered as a sacrifice to the opponent. Even with the early lead of Black in material (if it chooses to accept the bait), White will be provided with different opportunities. Since Black’s center control is gone due to the shift in direction of its pawn, White can take control of the opponent’s half of the centerboard by simply advancing its pawns to d4 and e4 and no Black piece to immediately stop those moves. Another advantage would be that White can opt for an early check and a fork on the undefended pawn, forcing Black to make a move that does nothing to develop its other pieces.

Many other variations or defensive movements have stemmed from the Reti system, making it difficult for opponents to predict what you’ll be doing in your succeeding moves.

Stonewall Attack

To prevent your opponent from getting to your king, you will need to provide a good defense. If you are interested in a defense-based game plan, what you need is the Stonewall attack opening.

This system also utilizes the queen’s pawn opening and doesn’t utilize the Queen’s Gambit. But along with the Queen’s pawn, this system involves moving the other pawns in the center in such a way that they are protected, either by other pawns or the minor pieces. The pawn’s position in the center also allows for open lanes so that White can also guard any attacks from the flank.

To execute this opening, the following moves must be followed:

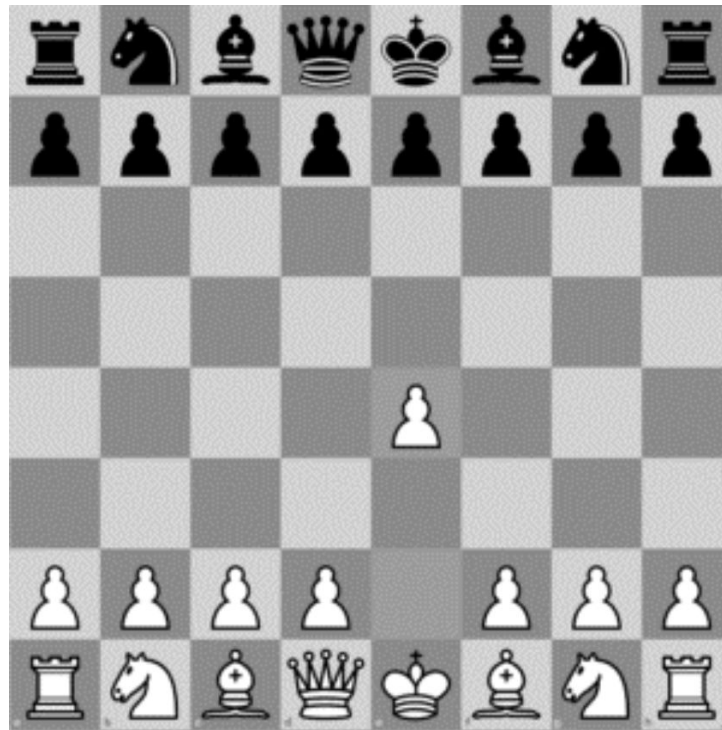
- Queen’s pawn to d4
- King’s pawn to e3
- Kingside bishop to d3
- C pawn to c3
- F pawn to f4

If the moves are followed properly, the board must look like this:



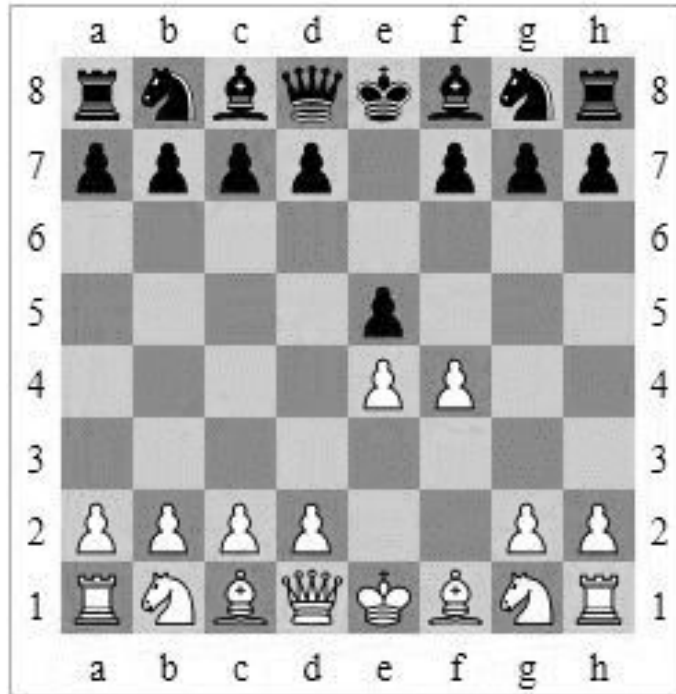
Using the Stonewall attack allows White to guard whatever it is that will come to the center square with its pawns, allowing it to capture opponent pieces that will attempt to occupy the said area and provide the pieces with enough protection. This makes it difficult for Black to penetrate White with a direct approach. Unfortunately, flank attacks are also checked by White's long-range pieces. And even if Black does manage to start an attack on the King's side, it can easily be shut close by the pawns in columns g and h.

King's pawn Opening/The Open Game



Known as the King's pawn Opening, this is by far white's most popular choice historically and empirically. *1. e4* has proven a favorite opening move by some of the biggest names in chess. It is easy to see why the move accomplishes all of the main goals we set out for our opening. It controls the key central squares *d5* and *f5* as well as allowing the development of two of our pieces, the bishop, and the knight. It is for this reason that it should come as no surprise that three of our example openings are King's pawn mainline variations. When black replies back with the move *1...e5* this is called the Open Game

King's Gambit (1. e4 e5 2. f4)



A historically very popular opening, especially around the 19th century when this opening saw a lot of play. It has since fallen out of favor somewhat but is still worth mentioning to beginners as it keeps to our core opening principles and has a lot of solid theory and evidence to support its success.

The main line starts off:

1. e4e5
2. f4

Immediately white contests the center with the sharp pawn advance *f4*. A little bit of lingo here for this opening: *a gambit is a sacrifice for some other advantage.*

In this position, black can simply capture the pawn on *f4* immediately if they so choose as white is not defending their *f4* pawn. There are two main variations to the King's Gambit depending on whether or not Blacks accept this sacrifice. They are therefore named the *King's Gambit Accepted* if black chooses to take the pawn on *f4*, or the *King's Gambit Declined*, should black instead choose to protect their now threatened *e5* pawn. Let's start off with the King's Gambit Accepted to try and learn why white would ever want to give a pawn away in the first place.

King's Gambit Accepted

With the moves:

1. e4e5
2. f4exf4

We have reached the first position in the King's Gambit Accepted. It is white's turn to play now. If you remember back to our discussion about controlling the center, white was very happy to have pawns on both *d4* and *e4* as this gave them very excellent control of the middle of the board, as well as options for all of their minor pieces to develop naturally. We will cover what *d4* brings to the table in a lot more detail in the Queen's Gambit Opening. This is the most usual continuation for white, but sometimes white will instead elect to play *Nf3* followed by *Bc4* next turn to both stop black from advancing their *f4* pawn, as well as to prepare to castle immediately.

King's Gambit Declined

After:

1. e4e5
2. f4bc5

This is the King's Gambit Declined – Classical Defense. Black has developed his bishop, as well as interfered with white's attempt to castle – as you cannot castle through check. You may be wondering why white wouldn't simply capture the black *e5* pawn after black neglects to protect it. Let's take a look at what happens if white takes the pawn.

1. fxe5?? Qh4+

Suddenly white is in some real trouble. They are either going to lose the rook after:

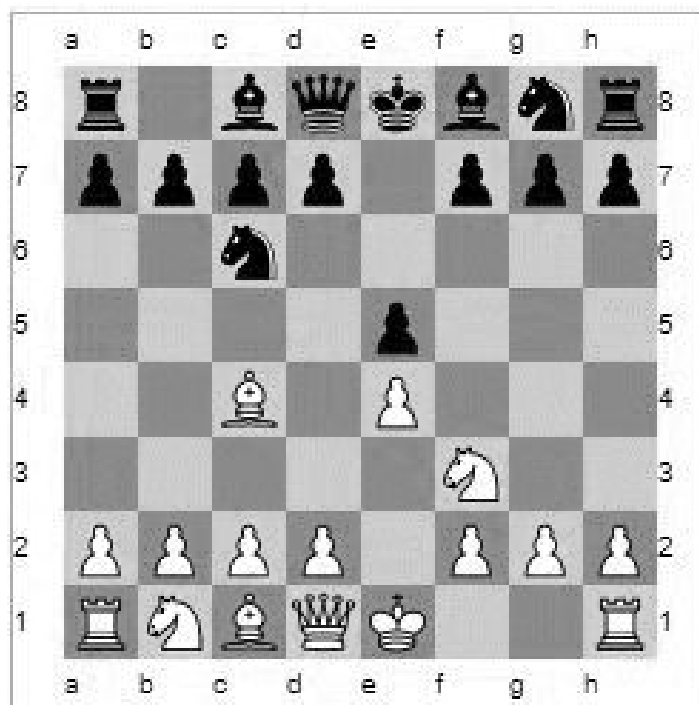
2. g3Qxe4+

Notice how both the king and the rook are being attacked? This is a tactic called *a fork*. Because black has forked white's king and rook, black is going to have to move his king and lose the rook.

If instead, white tries to run, the game ends swiftly:

Ke2 Qxe4#

Italian Game (1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4)



A historic opening, containing over 500 years of recorded games, it has been studied by many of the biggest names in chess history. The characteristic move of this opening is the move:

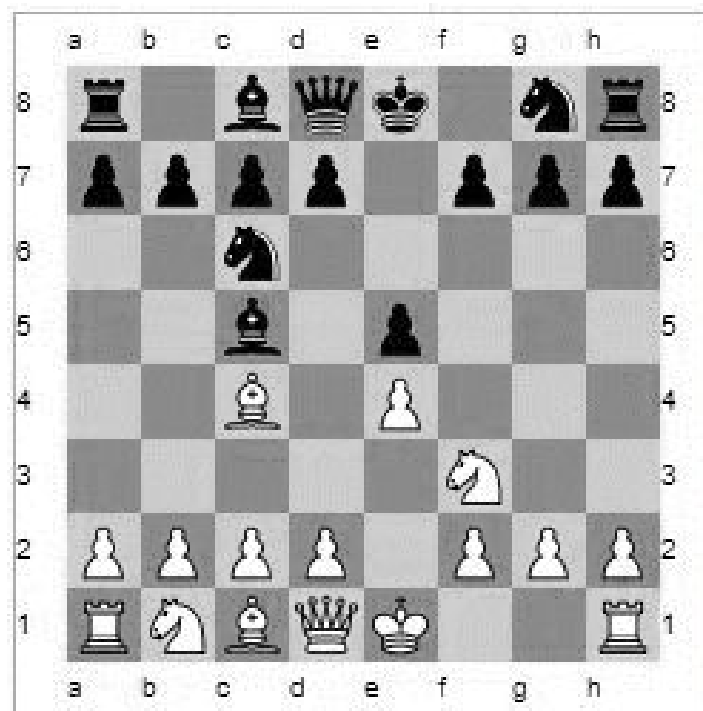
1. e4e5
2. Nf3Nc6
3. Bc4

Sometimes referred to as the Italian bishop. These games are very often sharp attacking games with white trying to focus on the poorly defended *f7* square (only the king defends it at the start of the game).

Also note how white has started developing an attack while, at the same time, preparing to defend with a castle king-side at any moment. A hallmark of high-level chess is accomplishing several goals with just one move.

Black, on the other hand, will usually try a strong counterattack in order to try and prove white was overzealous in their efforts. While more modern variations such as the Ruy Lopez have gained popularity, it is still worth examining this opening as there are great attacking chances for both sides. The two main variations branch depending on how black decides to respond after white moves their bishop. After 3...Bc5 we reach a position known as the *Giuoco Piano* and after 3...Nf6 we instead reach a position called the *Two Knights Defense*. We will be exploring each one separately.

Giuoco Piano

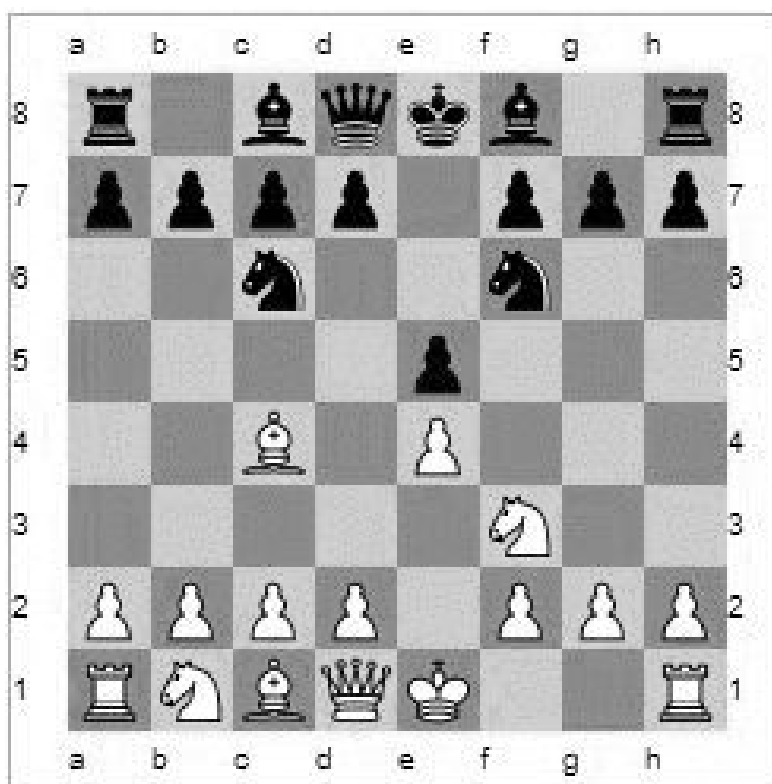


The Giuoco Piano main line continues as follows:

1. e4e5
2. Nf3Nc6
3. Bc4Bc5- Giuoco Piano with Bc5
4. c3

White is playing *c3* in order to prepare the move *d4*, grabbing vital central spaces away from black. Black will usually try to either counterattack with the aggressive move *4...Nf6*, or hold on to their central control with the move *4...Qe7*. Note that while this is a queen move in the early game, it doesn't violate our opening principles here, because the queen is being used far back on the 7th rank, as a support for her more forward pieces. This is a great and safe way to activate your queen without putting her in immediate danger.

Two Knights Defense



The Two Knights Defense starts out with:

1. e4e5
2. Nf3Nc6
3. Bc4Nf6

The most obvious attack continuation is to continue with move 4. *Ng5*. White is increasing the pressure on that *f7* square and threatening to win a pawn by force, as well as messing up black's hopes of castling. The usual reply from the black is:

4.4 *Ng5d5*

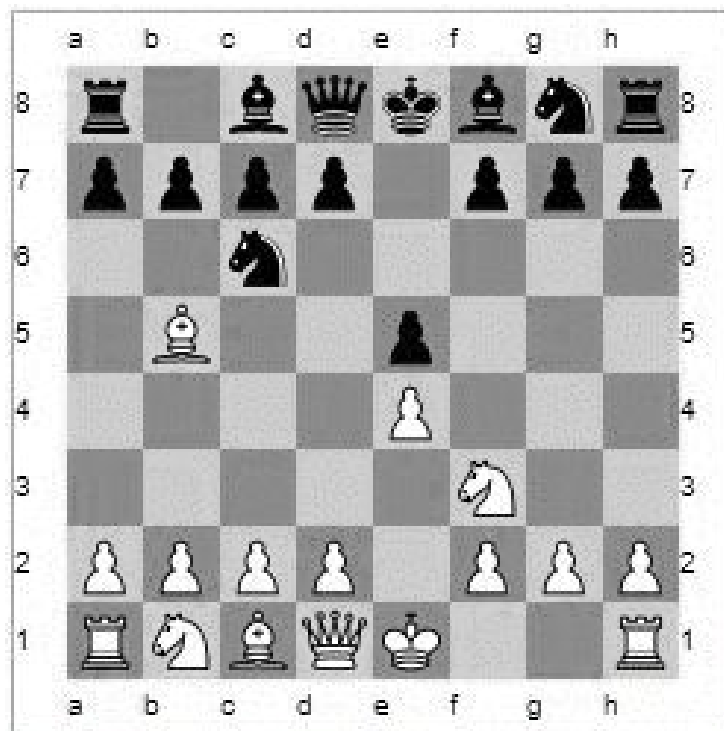
From this position, white has little option but to take on d5 as his bishop and e4 pawn are both under attack. After this, there are several different variations we will discuss later on.

However, black can instead try the exciting move:

4. *Ng5Bc5*

This is a dangerous counterattack from black. He is ignoring the mounting pressure upon the *f7* square in favor of developing a potential counterattack. White has three main variations: 5. *d4*, 5. *Bxf7+*, and 5. *Nxf7*.

Ruy Lopez (1. *e4 e5* 2. *Nf3 Nc6* 3. *Bb5*)



It can be said that the Ruy Lopez is the go-to option for many professional chess players when it comes to the Open Game (1 e4 e5). Unless black plays with perfection, it can be very tough for them to achieve equality. This is one of the key reasons why many black players choose to use the Sicilian Defense in response to 1. e4 instead.

After 3. Bb5, let's take a moment to analyze the relationship between white's bishop and black's knight. Imagine for a moment that the pawn on d7 didn't exist or had already moved to d6 or d5. If you notice, the white's bishop would attack black's knight and have the king lined up right behind it. This maneuver is called a *pin*. Pinned pieces can't move or they will expose a valuable piece of it (King, queen, or rook usually, but pawns can be pinned to other pieces too!) to danger. Blacks have hopes of making a break in the center with a move like d5, but with the white bishop attacking the black knight, that is an issue for black to think about. Let's see how black typically like to respond:

1. e4e5
2. Nf3Nc6
3. Bb5a6-

Morphy Defense

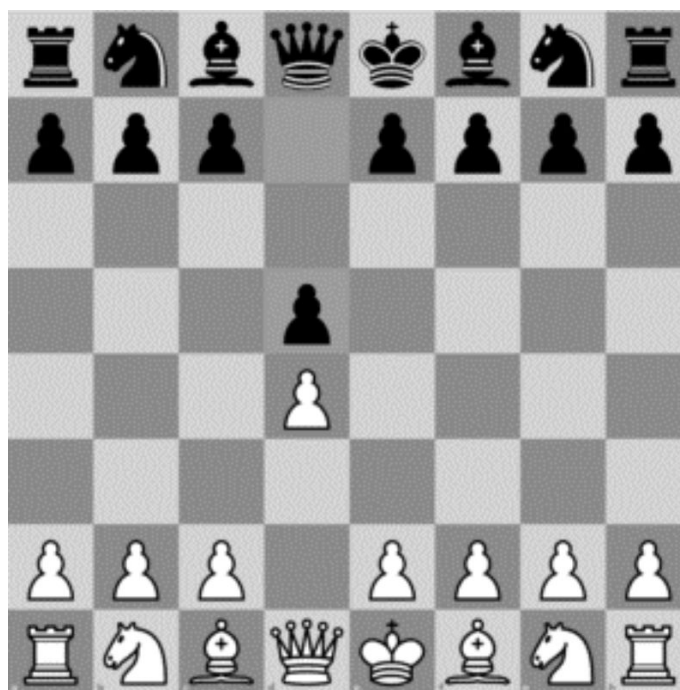
Named after the great chess player Paul Morphy during the 1800s, this is the most popular response for white. This move forces White to clarify their intent with the move b5. If he wishes to trade a bishop for a knight, black has taken no steps to prevent this exchange. If White retreats back to c4 Black has won a tempo back from white by forcing him to move his bishop twice.

The most common line is called the *Closed Defense* and goes as follows:

4. Ba4Nf6
5. O-OBc7

Ba4 from white to retreat away from the attacking pawn. Note that black can still, at any time, kick the bishop away with the move *b5*. In some variations, the white bishop may find itself trapped in the corner and care must be taken to allow room to escape a possible *b5* pawn thrust by black at any moment. *Nf6* increases black's central pressure by attacking the *e4* pawn, as well as supporting that *d5* move black has in the back of their mind. White castles away to safety and black develops his bishop and prepares for a king-side castle of his own.

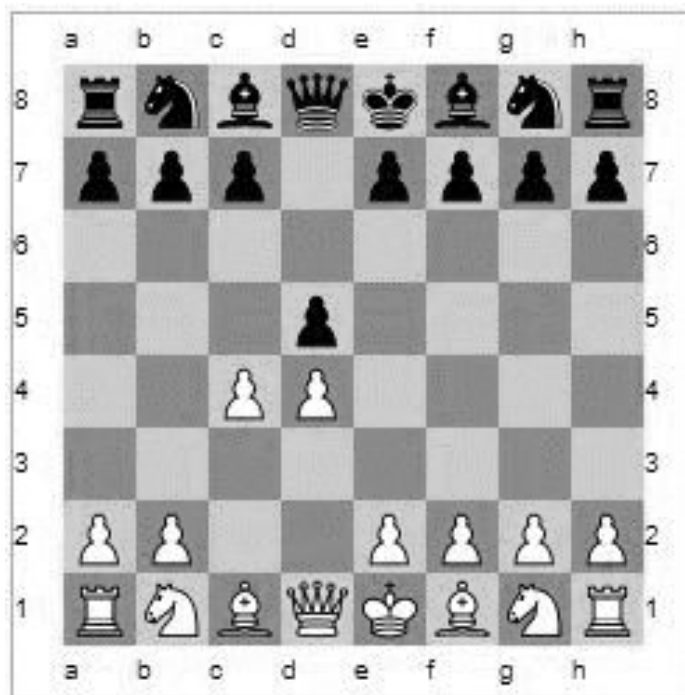
Queen's pawn Opening / Closed Game



White starts the game off with the great move *d4* and achieves several of our goals for the opening. White again occupies a central square with a pawn and attacks the two important central squares in *c5* and *e5*. Also, white can now look to develop their queen-side bishop as the pawn has moved to allow the bishop to move. It's a bit far away yet, but this move does also contribute to king safety in the sense that it is the first of several moves that white could use to facilitate a queen-side castle.

Although there are several good replies for black, very often black will choose to occupy his central space with a pawn on *d5*, and there the Close Game has been reached. All the same good things that applied for white, apply to black as well, so black feels very comfortable in staking a claim in the center in this way. Next, we will explore a mainline called the Queen's Gambit. One of the oldest and most exciting chess openings, as it features exciting chances for both sides.

Queen's Gambit (1. d4 d5 2. c4)



The Queen's Gambit is one of the oldest studied openings with well over 500 years of written history to support it. Another gambit opening which, if you remember from the King's Gambit, means some kind of sacrifice in material for a positional advantage.

Play starts out:

1. d4d5
2. c4

Right away, white is telling black that he intends to fight for the middle seriously. He is offering an undefended wing pawn on *c4* in exchange for that ever-tempting double pawn center of *d4* and *e4*. The difference is, unlike the King's Gambit that takes place on the relatively undefended king's side, this gambit takes place on the queen's side and that means the queen can get involved much more readily if the need arises. Because of this difference, it is not a true gambit, as black can't actually hold on to their pawn on *c4* after the exchange, which we will cover below. Just like the King's Gambit, the Queen's Gambit has two mainline variations depending on whether or not the offer on *c4* is accepted by black, and they are called *Queen's Gambit Accepted*, and *Queen's Gambit Declined*.

Black's Openings or Defense

Semi-Open Games

Semi-open games start with 1. *e4*. However, instead of answering with the symmetrical 1...*e5*, the Black player uses a different move to achieve early equality. This chapter will teach you three of the most popular semi-open chess openings. Study these openings carefully because they can be used to surprise your opponents who expect open games.

1. e4 – This move opens the d1-h5 diagonal for the queen and the f1-a6 diagonal for the king's bishop. Chess players consider this as the most aggressive first move. Aside from opening valuable diagonals, the pawn move attacks the d5 and f5 squares. Black has a wide range of options regarding his first move. In this chapter, you will learn about 1... c5 (also called Sicilian Defense), 1... e6 (also called French Defense), and 1... c6 (also called Caro-Kann Defense).

The Sicilian Defense (1... c5)



This is an aggressive reply to White's first move. Black pushes his pawn to the c5-square to prevent his opponent from establishing a pawn center (i.e. with pawns on d4 and e4). In this opening, Black allows White to attack the kingside. He hopes that he will be able to nullify White's assault and prepare his own assault on the queenside.

The c5-pawn move opens the a5-d8 diagonal for the Black queen. It also encourages White to exchange pawns on d4, after which Black will control the newly opened c-file. The game usually continues:

2. Nf3 – White develops his knight and fights for the d4-square.

2... d6 – Black supports his c5-pawn and opens the c8-h3 diagonal for his light-squared bishop. Also, he prevents White from transferring the f3-knight to the e5-square.

3. d4 – In order to start his attack, White opens the center and opens a diagonal for his c1-bishop. If Black takes the pawn, White will be able to place his pieces actively.

3... cxd4 – Black opens the c-file and removes one of White's central pawns. He hopes that the c-file and his pawn advantage in the center will give him a good game.

4. Nxd4 – Taking the pawn using the queen allows 4... Nc6, which attacks the queen and gives Black a free move to develop his pieces. The knight is excellently placed on the d4-square.

4... Nf6 – Black attacks the undefended e4-pawn and develops a knight. It is important to note that the d6-pawn prevents White from pushing his pawn forward with 5. e5.

5. Nc3 – This move develops the second knight and defends the e4-pawn.

5... a6 – This position is known as the Najdorf Variation. Black prevents White from placing a piece on the b5-square. Also, he prepares the move ... b5, which grabs more queenside space.

As the White player, your best option is to place your dark-squared bishop on e3, transfer your queen to d2, and castle on the queenside. This is known as the English Attack, the deadliest answer to Black's defensive set-up.

The French Defense (1... e6)



With this “silent” move, Black satisfies himself with a small center. He simply opens diagonals for his queen and dark-squared bishop. It is considered a quiet opening. The game usually continues:

2. d4 – White tries to establish a strong pawn center. The pawns on d4 and e4 control the c5, d5, e5, and f5, squares. In addition, the c1-bishop acquired an open diagonal.

2... d5 – Black cannot allow White to strengthen the pawn center. A well-supported pawn center can be converted into a decisive space advantage, so you have to attack it as soon as possible.

3. Nc3 – White defends the pawn and develops a knight.

3... Bb4 – Black pins the c3-knight against the king. Because the knight is not allowed to move, Black threatens to capture the pawn on e4.

4. e5 – White saves his pawn by pushing it forward. This pawn advance grabs more space in the center and the kingside.

4... c5 – Black assaults the center. If he can eliminate the d4-pawn, the pawn on e5 will be severely weakened.

5. a3 – It attacks the bishop on b4 and forces Black to decide the bishop.

5... Bxc3 – Black decides to ruin White's pawn structure. Even though bishops are considered to be stronger than knights, he hopes that he can exploit White's fragmented pawn set-up.

6. bxc3 – White needs to capture the bishop to restore material equality.

In this position, White tries to take advantage of his two bishops and kingside space. Black, on the other hand, plans to counterattack on the queenside and highlight the weakness of White's pawns.

The Caro-Kann Defense (1... c6)



Similar to the French Defense, this opening prevents immediate conflicts in the center. The Black player prepares the pawn move 2... d5. Its main drawback is that it occupies the c6-square, which is the most natural spot for the knight on b8. The game usually continues:

2. d4 – White tries to increase his control over the central squares.

2... d5 – Black attacks the pawn on e4 and opens a diagonal for the c8-bishop.

3. e5 – Taking the enemy pawn via 3. exd5 allows 3... cxd5 and 4... Nc6 for Black. Because of this, White simply pushes his pawn forward. This move gives White several advantages: more space in the kingside, control over the f6-square, and a long pawn chain.

3... Bf5 – Black wants to develop his pieces as soon as possible. The move allows ...e6, which will open a diagonal for the f8-bishop. Also, the knight on b8 can go to d7 now without hemming in the light-squared bishop.

4. Nf3 – White starts to develop his kingside forces. The knight move also supports the pawns on d4 and e5.

4... e5 – The a3-f8 diagonal is now available for the dark-squared bishop.

5. Be3 – it strengthens the d4-pawn and stops Black from pushing the c-pawn to c5.

5... Nd7 – It increases Black's control over the c5-square and develops the knight on b8. The a8-rook can be transferred to c8 later.

This opening often leads to positional battles. Because the piece configuration of both camps provides minimal attacking opportunities, it is extremely hard to initiate tactical attacks.

Closed Openings

Closed openings don't start with 1. e4. White spends his first move to either grab some queenside space or develop his kingside pieces quickly. These openings provide fewer attacking opportunities than open or semi-open ones. Because of this, chess players use closed openings to initiate strategic or positional battles. Positional battles are characterized by subtle moves and minimal calculations. Instead of attacking the enemy king directly, the players are trying to improve their respective positions. They do this by gaining more space, eliminating the opponent's strong pieces, establishing a pawn center, etc.

We will talk about two starting moves for White: 1. d4 and 1. c4.

1. d4

This move attacks the c5- and d5-squares. The c1-h6 diagonal is also opened for the queen's bishop. However, it doesn't contribute to the development of the kingside pieces. The White player is required to spend additional moves just to get his f1-bishop and g1-knight out. Black has a wide range of available replies here. This book will focus on the most popular defenses: King's Indian Defense, Queen's Indian Defense, Slav Defense, Queen's Gambit Declined, and the Semi-Slav Defense.

1.1 King's Indian Defense



This opening starts with 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6.

As you can see, Black castled immediately and placed his bishop on the a1-h8 diagonal. His main goal is to turn this bishop into an extremely strong piece. If he can open the center, the bishop on g7 will exert tremendous pressure on White's camp. White, on the other hand, has more space and great options for piece development. The pawns on c4, d4, and e4 control important squares in the center of the board. If he wants to neutralize the power of the g7-bishop, White should keep the center closed.

Black may try to open the center with ...c5 or ...f5. If he will choose the latter, he will gain some kingside space which can be converted into a violent attack. Here, White must develop his kingside quickly and support his excellent center. Two of his best options are 5. Bd3 (followed by 6. Ne2 and 7. 0-0) and 5. Be3 (followed by 6. Qd2 and 7. Bh6).

1.2 Queen's Indian Defense



This opening starts with 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 d6 3. Nf3 b6.

In the Queen's Indian Defense, Black develops his c8-bishop early. He intends to pressure White's pawn center and create some weaknesses in the enemy camp. Similar to the King's Indian Defense, this opening gives White extra space and excellent options for piece development. His control over the central squares gives him a good game. The play might continue:

4. e3 – It supports the d4-pawn and opens a diagonal for the f1-bishop.

4... Bb7 – The bishop is exerting great pressure on the a8-h1 diagonal.

5. Bd3 – It defends the e4-pawn and develops the bishop.

5... Be7 – Black finishes his kingside development.

6. 0-0 – White is ready to start his queenside operations.

6... Bg7 – Black has two bishops placed on valuable diagonals. If he can successfully open the center, the combined power of these bishops will rock White's world. Black may exert more pressure on the center by transferring his b8-knight to d7 and moving his f8-rook to e8.

1.3 The Queen's Gambit



You can reach this opening via 1. d4 d5 2. c4.

As indicated before, White wants to eliminate the pawn on d5 and open the c-file for his major pieces (i.e. the queen and rooks). It looks like he is sacrificing a pawn for nothing. However, Black cannot hope to keep the c4-pawn if ever he takes it. He may experience serious positional problems if he will try to defend his ill-gotten wealth. In addition, White can easily get material equality. For example: 2... dxc4 3. Qa4+ followed by 4. Qxb4. So, Black has three main options: the Slav, the Queen's Gambit Declined, and the Semi-Slav Defense.

1.3.1 The Slav Defense



It can be reached via 1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6.

Black protects his d5-pawn using a quiet move. Although the pawn on c6 occupies the most natural square for the b8-knight, Black's position looks great because the move ...b5 is now available. Play might continue:

3. Nc3 – White adds more pressure on the d5-pawn. If Black will take the pawn on c4, White will answer with 4. a4 (preventing ...b5) a6 5. e3 (attacking the enemy pawn) b5 (Black tries to hold on to his extra material) 6. axb5 cxb5 7. Nxb5 (and Black will still lose the pawn on c4). The knight cannot be taken with ...axb5 since White will laugh maniacally and capture the poor rook on a8.

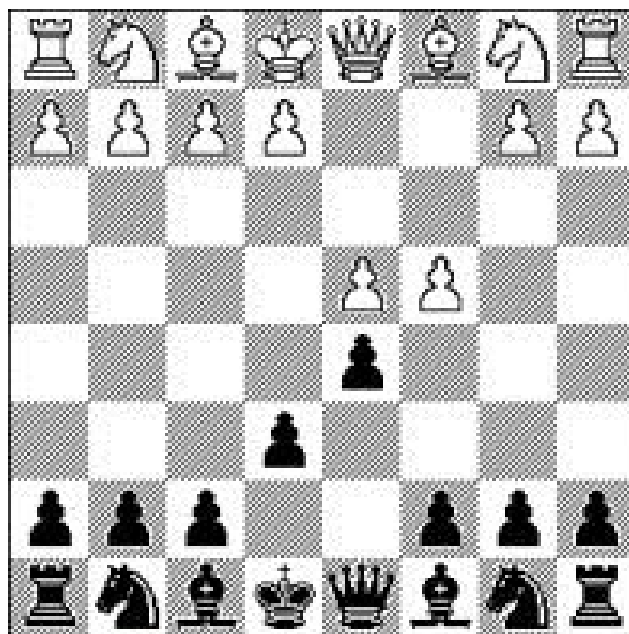
3... Nf6 – Black continues with his development. He calmly defends the pawn on d5.

4. e3 – White is now ready to recapture on c4.

4... Bf5 – Black exerts pressure on the e4-square.

In this position, White usually attacks the queenside via Qb3 (attacking the undefended pawn on b7 and increasing the pressure on d5). Black has to complete his kingside development as soon as possible and defend against White's attacks. He may play Qd7 followed by Na6, Nc7, Rb8, etc.

1.3.2 The Queen's Gambit Declined



You can get this position with the opening moves 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6. Black defends his pawn and opens a diagonal for his bishop on f8. However, the bishop on c8 becomes trapped. Some chess players consider this opening as too passive. Unlike other answers to 2. c4, this defense offers minimal opportunities for a counterattack. Play might continue: 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 Bb4+ 5. Nc3 0-0 6. a3 Be7 7. Qc2 b6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Bb7.

White has excellent control over the c-file. He can start a queenside attack via Bd2 and Rc1. Because he has more pawns in the center, he can grab more space in that area of the board.

Black, on the other hand, has completed his kingside development and placed a bishop on a long diagonal. He should attack White's center immediately. If the central pawns will be supported by White's pieces, they will be able to restrict Black's army and force him to defend for the rest of the game.

1.3.3 The Semi-Slav Defense



This opening can be reached with the moves 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c6 4. Nf3 Nf6.

As you can see, this opening combines e6 and c6. The Semi-Slav Defense is one of the most popular weapons against the Queen's Gambit. Black has more space in the queenside. Play might continue:

5. e3 – This move allows White to defend the c4-pawn using the bishop.

5... Be7 – Simple moves work for Black. He is now ready to hide his king and bring out one of his rooks.

6. Qc2 – The c-file is going to be opened so White places his strongest piece there. This move is also used to delay the development of the f1-bishop.

6... 0-0 – Black has completed his kingside development.

7. Bd2 – White vacates the c1-square for his rooks.

7... Re8 – The rook is placed on the e-file because White may try 8. cxd5. If that happens, Black will recapture with his e-pawn and give the e8-rook an open file.

8. Bd3 – White cannot delay this move any longer (8. Be2 gives the same results). He needs to complete his development or Black will get a decisive advantage.

8... dxc4 – Black wants White to waste a move.

9. Bxc4 – White needs to restore material equality.

9... b5 – This move attacks the bishop and grabs more space in the queenside.

10. Bd3 – White must retreat this bishop. The d3-square is the best option since it allows the bishop to attack h7, a weak point in Black's position.

10... a6 – Black supports his b5-pawn and prepares 11... Bb7.

White will castle and exert pressure on the c6-pawn. Black, on the other hand, will protect that pawn via ...Bb7, ...Nd7, and ...Rc8. His queen can go to b6, where it can help in preparing ...c5. If he can accomplish this move, he will be able to remove one of his weaknesses and eliminate White's d4-pawn.

2. The English Opening



As we will see later on in more details, this is considered one of the simplest openings currently available. White pushes his pawn to c4 to grab space in the center and the queenside. If Black plays d5, White will have the option to play d4 and convert the game into the Queen's Gambit.

Black has three main choices: 1... c5, 1... e5, and 1... Nf6.

2.1 The Symmetrical Variation (1... c5)

Black copies the first move of his opponent. Play might continue: 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. d3 d6 5. g3 g6 6. Bg2 Bg7 7. 0-0 0-0.

Black can achieve a solid position just by copying White's moves. However, he must break the symmetry at some point. White's right to move first can be converted into a decisive advantage if the symmetry will be kept for a long time.

2.2 The Reversed Sicilian (1... e5)

This move aims to prevent 2. d4 and grab some space in the kingside. In addition, the bishop on f8 acquired an open diagonal.

2. g3 – White wants to cement his control over the d5-square. He will place his bishop on g2 during his next move.

2... Nf6 – Black develops a knight and starts to fight for the d5-square.

3. Bg2 – The bishop is placed on the long diagonal. It can become extremely strong if Black will not close the center.

3... c6 – This move increases Black's control over the d5-square. It also restricts the power of the g2-bishop.

4. Nf3 – Since the a8-h1 diagonal has been blocked, White will just continue his development. 4. e3 followed by 5. Ne2 is also good.

4... Qc7 – The pawn on e5 must be defended.

5. 0-0 – White has castled his king. The rook on f1 can be transferred to e1.

5... Be7 – Black makes a natural bishop move.

Normally, White pushes his queenside pawns forward to acquire more space. Black, however, should focus on the center. He also needs to complete his development as soon as possible.

2.3 1... Nf6

Black develops his knight early. The position can be converted into the variations discussed previously if Black will play ...c5 or ...e5 later. Play might continue:

2. Nc3 – The knight fights for the d5-square.

2... e6 – Black opens the diagonal for his f8-bishop. Obviously, he wants to hide his king as soon as he can.

3. Nf3 – White makes another natural move. As a general rule, you should develop your knights before your bishops.

3... Bb4 – Black develops a piece and threatens to ruin White's pawn structure.

4. e3 – White ignores the threat. He continues to develop his pieces by vacating the e2-square for his bishop.

4... Bxc3 – Black disrupts the pawn configuration of the enemy camp.

5. bxc3 – Despite their ugly appearance, White's queenside pawns are doing an excellent job. The pawn on c4 controls b5 and fights for d5. The pawn on c3 claims the b4- and d4-squares. Meanwhile, the c1-bishop can be transferred to b2 or a3, depending on White's preferences.

5... 0-0 – Black completes his kingside development.

6. Ba3 – The bishop attacks the rook on f8. By doing so, White gets a free move to develop another piece.

6... Re8 – The rook is transferred to the e-file to support the advance of the e6-pawn.

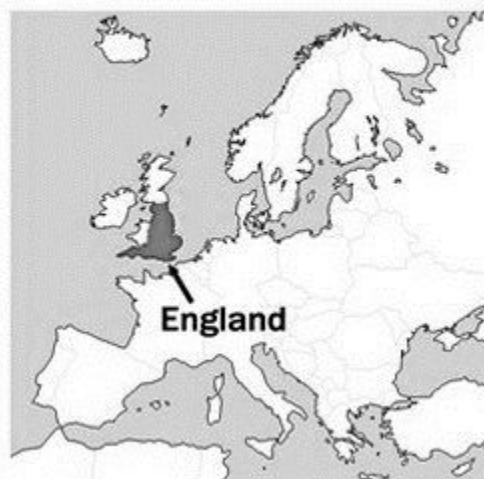
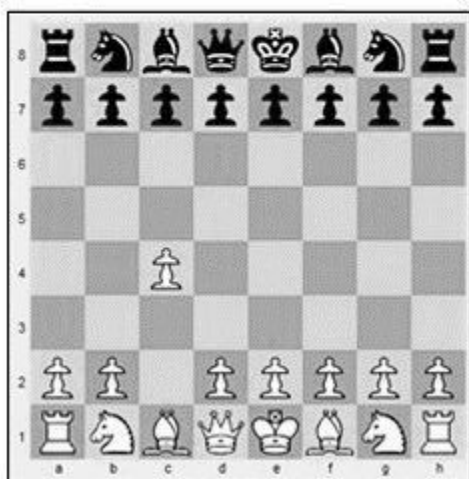
7. Bd3 – White develops his light-squared bishop and prepares to castle. The move 7. d4 is also good; it prevents Black from advancing the pawn on e6.

In this opening, White tries to take advantage of the open b-file. He pressures the queenside by placing both of his rooks there. Black, however, must defend against White's queenside assault and prepare his counter-attack in the center of the board.

The most fascinating histories behind Chess Openings

English Opening

1. c4



The English Opening is just ever so slightly off-beat, much like the English themselves. They foment a national image of stoicism, gentle self-deprecation, and keeping a stiff upper lip, yet beneath the surface are a people with a most idiosyncratic sense of humor.

1. c4 was pioneered by everybody's favorite mutton-chopped 19th century chess-playing Englishman, Howard Staunton. Staunton used the move six times when playing as White in his 1843 match against the Frenchman Saint-Amant at the Café de la Régence, although with mixed results. Staunton won the first two times he tried it, but Saint-Amant got better with experience, and Staunton could only draw two and lose two of the next four games where he started with *1. c4*.

Today, the English Opening is White's fourth most popular choice of the 20 possible first moves, but for many years it was given no respect at all. Ruy López noticed *1. c4* centuries ago and thought it so bad that no player of any skill would use it. Staunton's peers in the 1800s thought it was a bit strange too, and it didn't catch on with others, despite Staunton's influence.

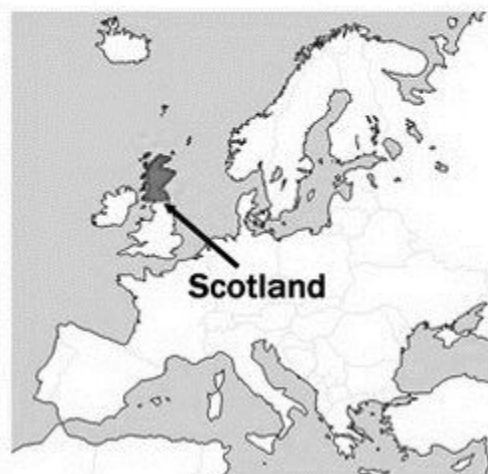
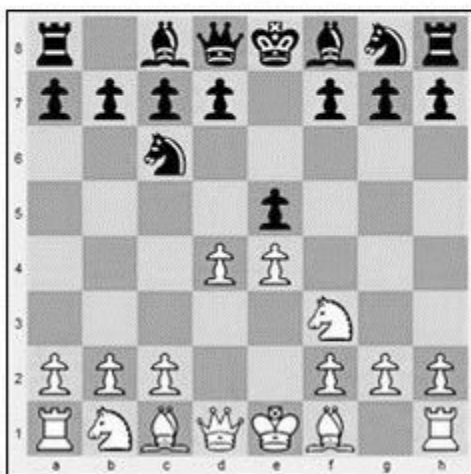
The hypermodern school of chess meant that interest in *1. c4* grew in the early 20th century. If flank attacks like the Sicilian Defense could work for Black, then why not for White? Another advantage of the English Opening lies in its flexibility – it has strong potential to transpose to other openings, depending on what Black does.

A chess game can last hours, and keeping one's concentration throughout this mental marathon has always been a key test of a player's mettle. However, some of Staunton's 19th-century compatriots took things to an extreme. In the days before chess clocks, each player could take as long as he liked to ponder their move before making it, leading to games of ten hours, twenty hours, or even more.

*The book *The Even More Complete Chess Addict* recounts the encounters between Elijah Williams and James Mucklow at the 1851 London tournament where both players were on the verge of falling asleep, such was the duration of their contemplation. It got so bad that one of the games needed to be adjourned for an evening so that everyone could go to bed.*

Scotch Opening

- | | | |
|----|-----|-----|
| 1. | e4 | e5 |
| 2. | Nf3 | Nc6 |
| 3. | d4 | |



Like the drink that bears its name, the Scotch is a rich, flavorsome way to play. It is an uncomplicated and direct opening, much like the stereotypical Scotsman.

The separate kingdoms of Scotland and England joined to form the United Kingdom in 1707. England has always been the dominant force within the union with the much larger population of the two. Still, the Scots maintain a distinct character of their own and there is nothing they love more than beating the English.

In 1824, Edinburgh, the capital of Scotland, challenged London to a chess match. London was a little taken aback by the temerity of Edinburgh, for the upstart Scottish club which had only been formed a couple of years prior. Yet here they were, throwing down the gauntlet to the most eminent players of Britain's largest city. Nevertheless, the challenge was accepted. The match took place by mail correspondence, a terribly slow business in those days, before inter-city rail transport and the invention of the telegraph. Each move needed to travel the hundreds of miles back and forth between London and Edinburgh by horse and carriage.

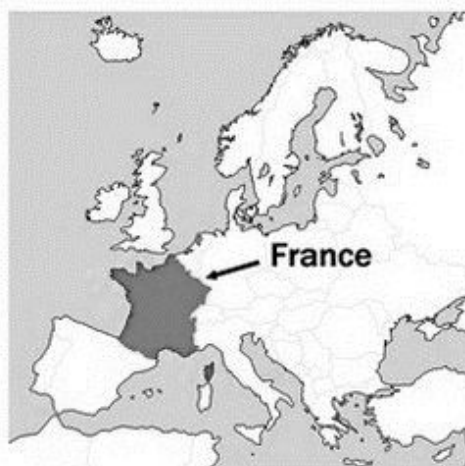
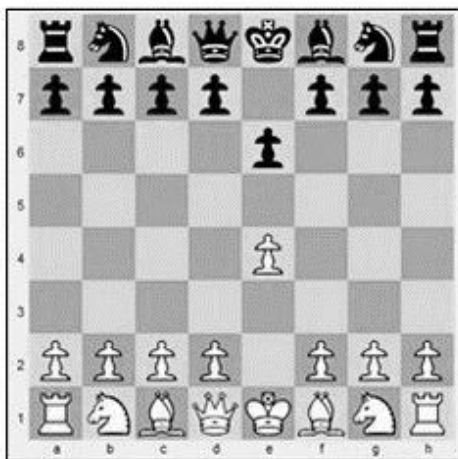
The clubs played five games between 1824 and 1828. The games were published in newspapers and keenly observed by the public like sports are today. Everybody expected a lopsided victory for London, but the Scots surprisingly prevailed. Three of the five games started with what we now call the Scotch Opening, including the decisive fifth game where Edinburgh played it as White and won. Their victory was sealed, two wins to one, and the opening came to be known as the Scotch.

During the second game, London controversially tried to retract a move after it had been mailed. The post office refused London's attempts to stop the letter's delivery. Then, Edinburgh refused to acquiesce when they received the original move and London's second letter pleading for an alteration. Edinburgh went on to win the game.

The Scotch Opening allows for easy piece development. The d4 pawn is pushed ahead boldly, and normally provokes 3. ...exd4 from Black. The center is cleared and both sides are left with a great degree of freedom. As anyone familiar with the blockbuster film *Braveheart* will know, “freedom” was the clarion call of William Wallace in the 13th-century Scottish war of independence against England. Fitting, then, that it was another battle – of the chess kind – between the two that gave the Scotch Opening its name.

French Defense

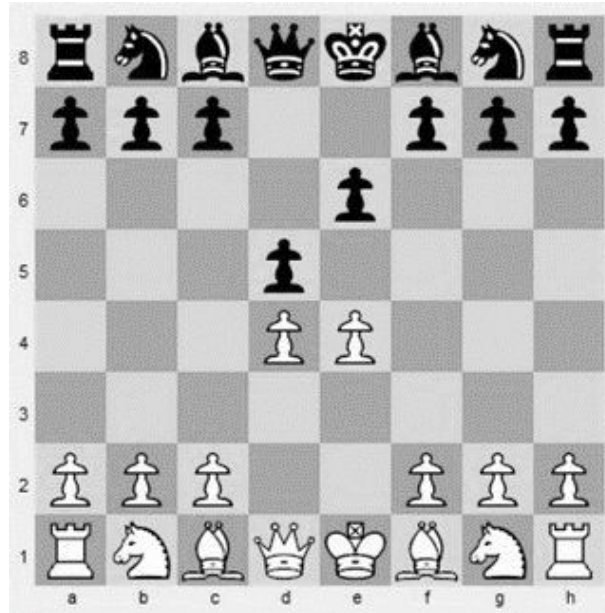
1. e4 e6



France occupies a central place in chess history, and the French Defense is one of chess’s most solid and resilient center pawn openings.

The French embraced the game like nowhere else in the 18th and early 19th centuries. Chess cafés were incredibly prolific there, and French players monopolized the mantle of world preeminence for generations: Legall de Kermeur, François-André Danican Philidor, Louis-Charles Mahé de La Bourdonnais, and Pierre Charles Fournier de Saint Amant all followed one another in succession until the 1840s. Today, the international chess federation is known as “FIDE,” which is a French acronym for *Fédération Internationale des Échecs*. French words turn up elsewhere in the game too, such as the *en passant* pawn capture rule and *j’adoube*, said when adjusting a piece’s position on a square without violating the touch-move rule.

In the French Defense may seem that Black is too timid to push the pawn all the way to meet its opposite, but the next moves reveal more aggression. White usually continues with 2. *d4*, which Black may meet with 2. ...*d5*.



Position after 2. ...*d5*.

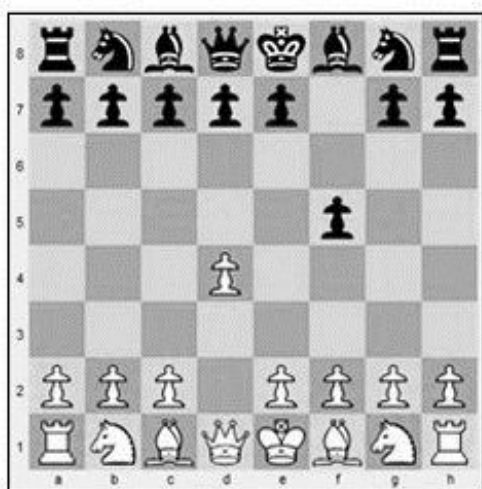
What White does next can vary, but often Black will target White's *d4* pawn by playing *c5* at some point – just the kind of flank attack that the French general Napoleon Bonaparte was famous for in his early conquests through Europe.

Napoleon, the Emperor of the French from 1804 to 1814, had a deep love for chess. It is, after all, a game of war, and over the years, many battle commanders have turned to chess for inspiration. On the real battlefield, Napoleon had an uncanny knack for sensing the intentions of the enemy and controlling the course of the battle, but on the chessboard, he was mediocre at best. Perhaps the fact a military commander's prowess does not transfer to ability at chess is unsurprising – a game with fixed rules played in silence by two equal forces on a square board is a long way removed from the chaos of actual combat.

The French Defense got its name from a correspondence match between the cities of London and Paris in 1834. Chamouillet, one of the players of the Parisian team, persuaded his team to play the (at the time) quite novel *1. ... e6*, which proved to be the Londoner's undoing. For the Paris club, winning must have been particularly sweet given that France's defeat in the Napoleonic Wars was still fresh in the memory. At last, a French victory!

Dutch Defense

1. d4 f5



The Netherlands is a small northern European country known for its tulips, windmills, bicycles, canals, and wooden shoes. Strangely, the words for the country and for the people who come from there do not match up. We have Norwegians from Norway, Australians from Australia, and Japanese from Japan, but when it comes to “the Netherlands,” we call them “Dutch.” To confuse matters further, the word “Holland” is often bandied around. “Holland” (when properly used) refers to just two of the 12 provinces of the Netherlands: Noord-Holland and Zuid-Holland.

The Dutch Defense was originally named for Elias Stein, who wrote a 1789 book that recommended *1. ...f5* as the best response to *1. d4*. Stein was actually born in France and published his book in French, but because he had settled in The Hague it was the “Dutch Defense” name that the chess world picked up.

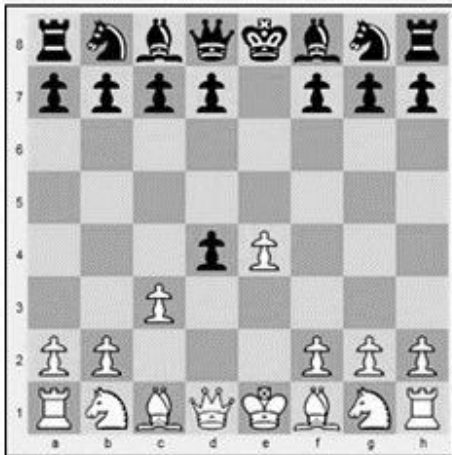
The only time that a Dutchman won the world chess title was when Max Euwe unexpectedly defeated Alexander Alekhine in 1935. The match took place in the Netherlands, and the best-remembered game (the 26th of the match, commonly referred to as “The Pearl of Zandvoort,” after the town the game took place in) was appropriately a Dutch Defense, won by Euwe, the Dutchman.

The true linkage the Dutch Defense has with the real-life Dutch lies in their shared uniqueness. Traditionally, Dutch people eat chocolate sprinkles for lunch, delight in wearing blackface around Christmas time, and hold a reputation for being highly conservative with money despite their seemingly contradictory relaxed attitude to sexuality and drug use.

The Dutch Defense is similarly esoteric. Throwing the f-pawn forward on move one is not for the faint of heart. Usually Black will castle kingside, which leaves the king with no pawn on f7, representing a significant hole in Black’s defensive dyke. The diagonal between c4 and g8 is often a weakness. But the Dutch have always been a nation of traders, and the compensation for Black is the opportunity to launch an immediate kingside assault. It is an exciting opening and can throw the White *1. d4* player off the balance if he were expecting a symmetrical center pawn game.

Danish Gambit

1. e4 e5
2. d4 exd4
3. c3



The Danish Gambit is named for the nation of Denmark, not the delicious sweet Danish pastries. Although given White is inviting Black to gobble up a couple of pawns, perhaps a double entendre is at play.

The opening is most strongly associated with a Danish chess master, Martin Severin From. He was active as a player in the mid-to-late 19th century but is better remembered as an analyst and administrator. From wrote an essay on the sequence of moves now known as the “Danish Gambit” while playing in a very strong 1867 tournament in Paris. Perhaps he penned it as a ruse to distract attention from his own play, as he came equal last out of the thirteen entrants. In a way, this makes From’s achievement in immortalizing the Danish Gambit even more remarkable – it’s one thing to popularize an opening thanks to winning a tournament with it, but it is surely even more challenging if the player has performed poorly.

An interesting quirk of this 1867 tournament was that it used a different scoring system to the one today's players are most familiar with. Almost universally, present-day chess tournaments award 1 point for a win, both players get $\frac{1}{2}$ a point for a draw and 0 points for a loss. Chess has been scored this way for such a long time that it's hard to imagine an alternative, but other scoring systems do exist. In Paris 1867, it was 1 point for a win, 0 points for a draw, and 0 for a loss. Drawing a game was as bad as losing. This system may hint at a solution to the scourge of modern chess; at the top level especially, there are far too many draws. When playing with the Black pieces, emerging with a draw is considered a fine result in contests between elite grandmasters, so they often try to lead the position towards a draw end rather than play sharp lines and risk a loss. There's also the so-called "grandmaster draw" – a draw by agreement where, early in the game, both players simply agree to shake hands and share the point before things even get interesting. Such a safety-first approach is not great for the game's followers who want to see danger, excitement, and decisive results.

Dragon Variation

- | | | |
|----|-------|-------|
| 1. | e4 | c5 |
| 2. | Nf3 | d6 |
| 3. | d4 | cx d4 |
| 4. | Nx d4 | Nf6 |
| 5. | Nc3 | g6 |



Dragons are mythical flame-snorting, flying beasts. They are frequently found in works of fantasy such as J.R.R. Tolkien's *The Hobbit* and George R.R. Martin's *A Song of Ice and Fire* series. The only tenuous connection between dragons and chess is the knight: dragons are slain by them, and chess has four of them on the board. Apart from that, dragons really have nothing whatsoever to do with chess.

The story of how the Dragon Variation got its name is tied to a Russian chess-playing astronomer: Fyodor Duz-Khotimirsky. He wrote: "I first uttered this name in Kiev, in 1901... While looking at the sky I noticed how the Dragon constellation resembled the [Black] pawn structure ...d6 ...e7... f7... g6... h7 seen in the Sicilian Defense. So, I decided to call the opening the Dragon Variation."

The Dragon Constellation (also known as *Draco*, which is the Latin word for “dragon”) can be seen all year round in the Northern Hemisphere. According to Greco-Roman legend, Draco was a dragon at war with the gods. When the goddess of wisdom Minerva killed Draco, she threw it into the night sky where it remains.

This configuration of stars does indeed bear a resemblance to Black’s pawn setup. But, dear reader, to say that the stars (or the pawns) look anything like a dragon is a stretch. But then, the same can be said about most star constellations. It takes a heck of imagination to argue the tiny dots of light in the sky look like lions, bulls, fish – or dragons.

With Black’s bishop coming to g7 to threaten White’s center, the Dragon Variation is one of the game’s most exciting, action-packed openings. After all, it would hardly do to give the name “dragon” to a timid opening. Duz-Khotimirsky was evidently quite pleased with the clever name he had invented, writing: “Of course the star system was itself named after a mythical dragon, so the association of the opening with the fire-breathing beast is fully appropriate.”

Giuoco Piano

- | | | |
|----|-----|-----|
| 1. | e4 | e5 |
| 2. | Nf3 | Nc6 |
| 3. | Bc4 | Bc5 |



If you want to learn a new discipline, you must be prepared to experience failure. You fall off your first horse, you forget your first foreign language lesson, and you bang your fingers when you hammer your first nail. So too it is in chess. As soon as a new player has learned the moves, they will be taught humility very soon thereafter as others mercilessly exploit their frequent missteps.

But even if losing is what we expect when new to chess, we will feel a lot better if we can at least give a respectable account of ourselves. There is dignity to be found even in defeat if the struggle is well-fought. However, if we can't even last past the opening, there is only humiliation. Losing inside the first ten moves is the chess equivalent of a first-round knockout. You can't help but detect that subtle superior smirk from your opponent and you can't help but feel you didn't deserve to share the same board with them.

Such defeats for novices are most common in the sharper openings. There, they must navigate a veritable minefield and make one correct move after another, lest their position explode out from under them. To avoid this, the new chess players will try to stick to openings where not too much can go too wrong, too quickly.

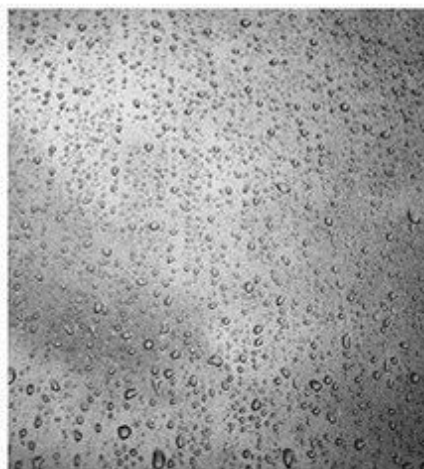
After 3. *Bc4* (known as the "Italian Game"), if Black responds with 3. ... *Bc5*, the opening is given an Italian name: *Giuoco Piano*, which literally means "quiet game." It is an opening that beginners gravitate towards because it reduces the possibility of rapid capitulation. Both sides follow the well-known opening maxims: develop pieces, occupy the center, and prepare to castle early. Neither player invites any immediate cut-and-thrust. If White's next move should be 4. *d3*, a related opening name is bestowed, *Giuoco Pianissimo*, or "very quiet game."

The piano and the game of chess have much in common. Both require deep and serious study, both tend to attract introverts, and both have links with mathematics. Some rare fellows have even had the distinction of excelling at both disciplines. Mark Taimanov was among the world's top 20 chess players in the mid-20th century and was also a world-class concert pianist. Sergei Prokofiev, the Russian pianist, composer, and conductor, managed to beat future world chess champion José Raúl Capablanca in a 1914 simul game.

Another thing shared by both chess and the piano is the linkage to the past. When sitting down to chess or to a piano, the same tools are in use as all the great masters who have come before you. New music is composed and the new chess opening theory is advanced, but the 88 keys on a piano remain as they always have, as do the 32 pieces on a chessboard.

Benoni Defense

1. d4 Nf6
2. c4 c5
3. d5



Ben-oni is a Hebrew term for “son of my sorrow” from the *Book of Genesis* 35:18. The Bible tells of a mother dying in childbirth and naming her baby “Benoni” before passing away. Slowly letting a winning position slip, touching a piece and then being obliged to move it, or badly messing up the opening can be enough to bring on the urge to cry out in despair. Nobody plays chess for any length of time without experiencing that sinking feeling, and for some of us, it happens on a depressingly regular basis.

There are two versions of the origins of the Benoni Defense name. The definitive truth over which story is correct has unfortunately been lost to the annals of time, so below are both stories. Readers can decide for themselves which they prefer.

The more colorful version begins with a Jewish man named Aaron Reinganum. He was suffering from depression and the only thing that would cheer him up was chess.

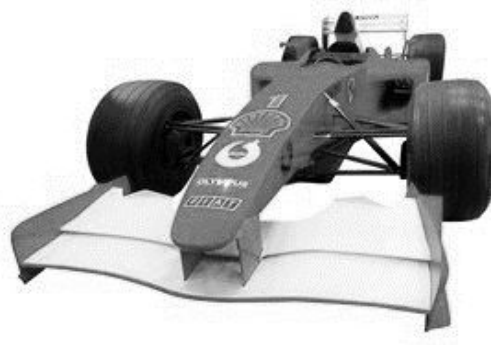
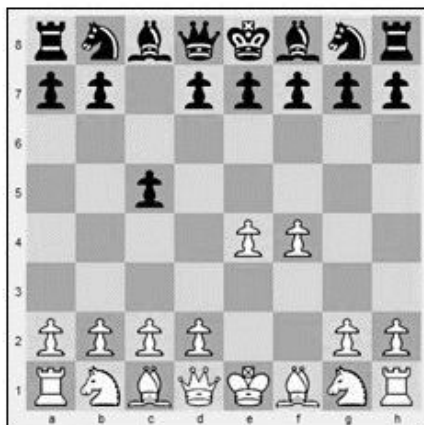
Reinganum then went into a brooding period where he wrote a book about gambit defenses – an interesting way to try to recover from depression, to say the least. His book, *Ben-Oni oder die Vertheidigungen gegen die Gambitzüge im Schache* (English: Benoni, or Defenses Against the Gambits in Chess), started its title with “Ben-Oni” in tribute to his writing it during a time of deep sadness.

The other story is of a player (or players) named Benoni. This was the version Howard Staunton believed. A Spanish player named Ramón Rey Ardid supports this version of events, calling the opening “An old, audacious defense which comes from the English player Benoni.” A Belgian grandmaster named Albéric O'Kelly de Galway wrote of two brothers named Benoni who lived in the 1830s.

The Benoni Defense splinters quickly into several variations, each of which requires precise play. There is the Old Benoni, the Czech Benoni, the Modern Benoni, and the Benko Gambit. Pawn breaks need to be monitored especially carefully, lest the opening infests you with the same sorrowful connotations of its name.

Grand Prix Attack

1. e4 c5
2. f4



What do supercharged cars capable of speeds of over 200 miles per hour have in common with a board game where players can take half an hour (or even more) to contemplate a single move? In terms of the activities themselves: nothing. The Grand Prix Attack got its name from the scoring system that chess has occasionally borrowed from Formula 1 for season-long competitions.

To the average man on the street, motor racing is mostly interesting for just two reasons: when drivers overtake, and when they crash. There is not a lot of enjoyment for the audience when cars lead from pole position and defend their initial advantage throughout the whole race. Viewers want to see excitement, drama, and swings in momentum.

Formula 1 racing tallies points from individual Grand Prix races to determine the overall season champion. The points are awarded to encourage the kind of racing the public wants to see. As of the time of writing, each event on the Formula 1 calendar gave points.

This schedule incentivizes the drivers to take risks. Far more points are awarded for higher placings than minor placings, so a driver with ambitions of capturing the Formula 1 title must chase first and second places, even if it means flaming out completely on occasion in their pursuit.

White's move 2. *f4* (or playing *f4* early, on the third or fourth move) in response to the Sicilian Defense became known as the Grand Prix Attack due to its popularity in British weekend chess tournaments which used a scoring format with a similar philosophy.

An *f4* pawn move in the Sicilian Defense likely avoids a lot of Black's opening preparation, but it's like a dangerous overtaking maneuver – the Grand Prix Attack will increase the likelihood of a win or a loss at the expense of a draw. But for the players trying to secure tournament wins rather than mid-table finishes, a better chance at capturing the full point is exactly what the Grand Prix Attack player is aiming for.

Things to Do After an Opening

What is Next? We looked at the various significant openings that you could use in a game of chess. Now, let's have a fast discussion about what to do after those first crucial moves.

Measure #1 Build Your Pieces

The very first guidance would be to build pieces quickly. This Concept involves memorizing your distinct opening tactics literally by hub and understanding which place is advantageous to every piece. You should be ready to use a game program if you would like to get a fantastic beginning to your game rather than going to it with no strategy.

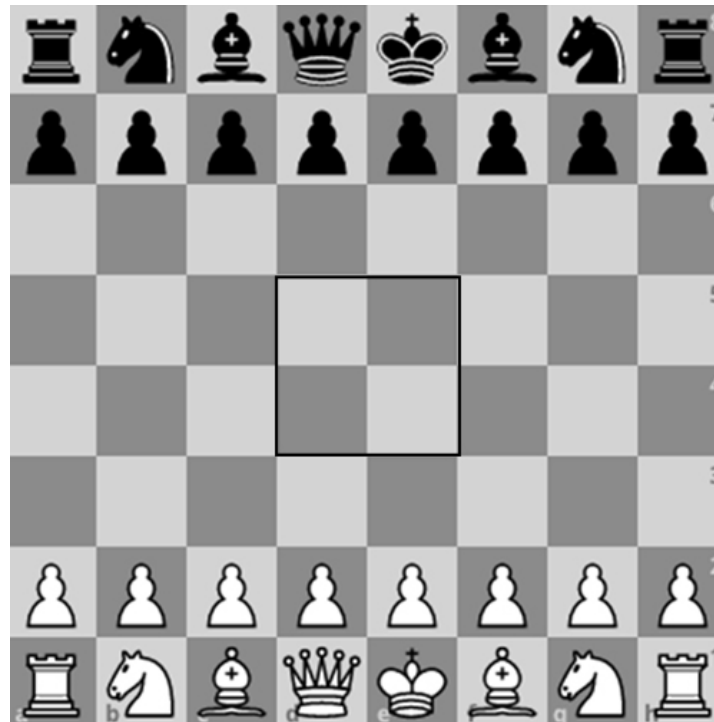
Measure #2 Control Your Center

The next thing to do would be, control the middle of the plank. As you understand, it's very important to balance the board at any time.

There are two types of scenarios that can arise if you want to garner control within the middle of your board. One is called the open center and the other one is an obstructed center. The open center is just one at which you and your opponent both have an equal chance in controlling the middle, which means you've got to swiftly progress all your significant portions into the epicenter; this is going to make certain you get fantastic control over the plank.

The obstructed center is one at which the competitor has put all of her or his significant pieces and it's hard for you to transfer any of your bits ahead. This isn't a good situation and you must do your very best to prevent it by producing a puzzling situation for your competitor. You have to make these scenarios for your competitor but if they do not come around, then you have to quickly re-strategize. Attempt to search for an opening and strategize ways to take charge of the center when possible.

Aside from these two, there's another situation called the lively center. The lively center is just one where the 2 players are not certain of that actually hold the middle of the plank. In this circumstance, it's crucial to find out who has the faster route to acquire control of the middle and you could do by visiting whose crucial pieces have a positional advantage.



Measure #3 Safe Guard Your Own King

The next thing to do would be to quickly transfer your king to security. As you understand, your king is the main part of the game. At no time should it be vulnerable or exposed. For this, you need to immediately move him into a secure location. But do not forget that the transfer ought to be significant. Do not only move him in this way that it threatens his place. If he's secure wherever he is, then let him stay there.

It pays to castle early in the game as you can normally place your king in a secure place. For this, you have to purposely move all of the bits which lie between the king and the rook and exchange their rankings, which is just another reason why Lopez's opening theory is really common. One other important concept is to ship an entourage with your king.

This means that you transfer a Couple of Security bits together with your own king in the event you would like to transfer him from the customary spot. Therefore, if you move the king ahead, your next move will be to put something in front of him. This way, you protect your troops and have the opportunity to help them stay secure. Even if your opponent kills the shield, your king could easily kill another piece.

However, make certain you understand what you're doing because it might be a snare. The competitor will purposely kill your shield to excite you to make a mistake so think it through once you put a defensive bit before your king. Another benefit of a historical castle is growing your bits. What this can do is allow you to move them around rather than getting them in their own place.

Many new players dread moving their large bits like bishop and knight believing they'll endanger those but if they aren't transferred, then they are going to endanger their troops and slow down their offensive assault. This way they recall they should transfer them onto the board when possible; this can also be called developing them.



Measure #4 Focus on Quality

The upcoming important issue is to focus on bit quality. It follows that you concentrate on the worth of this item before transferring it on the board. Each bit has distinct values, so as you probably already know, and you need to set them on the board in this way in which the values have been spread on the plank rather than being lumped all together.

Do not fall to the pawn-moving snare early on. That is where most novices fail. They begin moving the pawns and do not recognize it is very important to proceed with the other bits too. Bear in mind that a bit that isn't active on the board is just as good as not getting the item in any way. You have to steer clear of the error and begin moving your other bits early on. As was mentioned, you have to transfer your pawns into the middle of the plank.

Most General Tips for Chess Beginners

By now, you can tell that there is a lot to learn about chess. Depending on your motivation, it'll take at least 1 to 2 years to become a reasonably good player (when I mean good, I mean a club level player ELO 1600 – 1800). If you're thinking of becoming a master level player, which is ELO 2300 and beyond, you will need to take chess seriously and spend at least 3 hours studying & playing chess every day.

However, there are certain things that good players always keep in mind and this definitely helps you win more games, reduce your losses, and ultimately helps you improve faster.

(ELO – an international rating for chess. It indicates how strong of a player you are – the higher the number, the better you are theoretically.)

Here are some practical tips for playing chess:

Play the Moves Out on a Board

When you're just starting, you're probably not going to be able to remember many moves in your head. It's a good idea to have a chess set with you, whether it's a physical chess set that you can touch or with a [chess program](#) because this will help you see the moves more clearly and understand the ideas behind certain combinations or plans.

Know at Least 1 Opening Very Well, Preferably a Lesser-Known Opening

Your opponents may eventually be able to predict your moves easier and prepare against you, but it's better to play what you're comfortable with. Also, you're not likely to be playing against grandmasters so you can afford to play sidelines and also get away with minor inaccuracies.

Watch the Clock

Some players simply take too much time on the clock and end up losing because of being “flagged” (another term for losing on time). You should play safe, sensible moves, instead of always trying to find some highly sophisticated tactical shot that will end the game in 16 moves by force, simply because you won’t have the time in the end. This is especially true in blitz games.

Focus

If you’ve ever played in tournaments, you may see some players get out of their seats to watch other games. This is good for bodily circulation as well as just relaxing your mind from the mental challenges posed in your game. However, it is very easy to lose focus and make a huge mistake when you return to your board, so be mindful when you find yourself relaxing too much!

Keep A Lookout for Intermediate (In-Between) Moves

Being able to use intermediate moves won’t necessarily win you the game, but it is often quite surprising to an opponent, simply because it’s a move they won’t really expect. These kinds of moves are great for setting up tactics or getting out of trouble. Due to its surprise element, it can give you a psychological edge since it disrupts the rhythm of your opponent. Just don’t go checking your opponent to death because it might lead to a perpetual.

Think About Move Order

Sometimes, certain tactics don’t work because you’ve calculated them in the wrong move order.

Plan, Plan, Plan

One of the most best-renowned world chess champions, Mikhail Botvinnik, taught his students to always plan, even in blitz games. It might be daunting at first to always have to think of so many options, but it will train you to be thinking on the right path, and eventually, this will become second nature to you to the point where you won't even have to consciously plan at all.

Above all else, the greatest advice I can give you is to practice playing chess with all kinds of people. If you're just a beginner, play against someone who is also a beginner or slightly better than you. Chess is, after all, a contest between 2 players and simply reading books or even playing against the computer will only be so much. Humans play differently from computers and you'll also be able to try out different openings and strategies with human players, more so than computers. Also, it will be nice to be able to talk during a friendly game, as opposing to staring into a voiceless computer screen.

Game Development

Middlegame

The middlegame. This is what separates the good from the great. Anyone can memorize opening lines and opening traps, and endgame mastery is almost purely technical and can be learned over time. The middlegame, however, is where the artistry of chess lies and this is the chance for you to show others how good of a player you really are and how well you understand chess positions.

In my opinion, how you should approach the middlegame is based on general strategies, the type of opening you play, and the type of player you are.

General Strategies

Develop quickly, control the center (directly or indirectly), don't waste time (e.g., move the same piece more than once, don't move your queen out too early, pawn grabbing, etc.), get your king to safety, create mini-plans to achieve some major goal.

These are some of the strategies to keep in mind

For example, if you develop quickly in the opening, control the center and have a safe king, you'll have more chances or opportunities to make a break in the center to gain space, to gain space in the flanks, to attack a less developed and coordinated army, to attack a less well-defended enemy king and so on. You can choose to do either or all of these strategies where possible.

How you approach the middlegame also depends largely on the opening you choose. For example, if you prefer to play a sharp, tactical game, then opening with the Sicilian Dragon or Open Spanish is a good way to start. If you prefer a more solid game, then the QGD or the French Defense is your best bet. In general, king pawn openings (1. e4) are more tactical whereas queen pawn openings (1. d4) are more solid and positional.

You can get a rough idea as to who is better in a position by counting the number of points they've captured. This is actually more important than the amount of material you've captured by your side. As GM Alexei Shirov, once said, "pieces play chess." However, in reality, the player who has the advantage depends on the coordination and effectiveness of their pieces as well as the relative safety of their king.

You may also have heard about how important pawns are in chess. True, Francois Philidor, a very well-known chess player of the 18th century, once said “pawns are the soul of chess.” However, is *pawn structure* really that important? It turns out that the answer to this question really depends on what type of position you’re playing. Certain traditional weaknesses, like doubled-pawns and isolated pawns, can sometimes be useful to have either to bolster defense or to open up attack lines.

Although pawns are the weakest unit, they are excellent defenders, cost-effective attackers, and can promote to any piece. Their coordination and positioning often influence how well your pieces move and thus how much you can control the board.

If you would like to learn more about pawn structure, then you can have a read of GM Andy Soltis’ book [*pawn Structure Chess*](#) (2013).

Learning some opening traps will help you learn to avoid these, as well as be able to set them up against opponents. Although you shouldn't count on them since most decent players will not fall for them. Reserve these traps when you play blitz or very fast time limits; they often work better under these time conditions.

No one can read minds unless you are truly psychic, so it’s no surprise that you can't really predict what your opponent is going to do. However, you can *anticipate* what they can do and *be prepared* for these options. This is how you should really think when playing chess.

Forcing an opponents' moves in the middlegame is generally not a good idea. Beginners often make that mistake. Whilst many tactics have forceful combinations, the middlegame is not a purely tactical exercise. It is also strategic and positional, and you must learn how to understand these positions and have a 'feel' for them. It's not something that can be taught but after much practice, you can achieve it.

Planning an Attack

Before launching an attack, you must make sure that your king is safe, e.g. there are no back rank tricks in the air and that your pieces are well developed enough to attack as well as being able to retreat for defense if necessary.

When you have spotted a weakness in the enemy position, you have a target to attack.

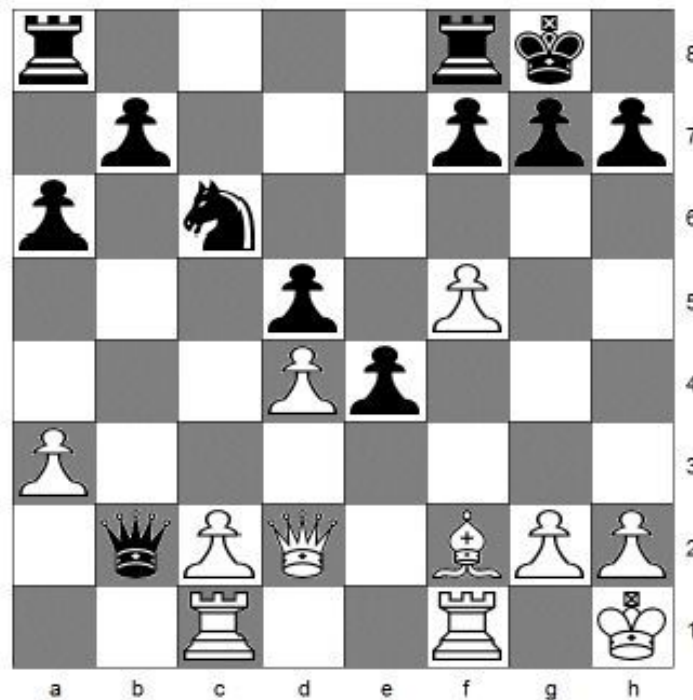
Think to yourself, “Is there a weak square that I can take over? Are there are weak pawns or badly positioned pieces that I can target? Can I directly assault the enemy king?”

If you can say ‘yes’ to at least 1 of these questions, then you can begin a plan of attack.

In the case of no obvious weaknesses, think about if there are any breakthroughs in the center, the kingside or queenside, or any piece sacrificed.

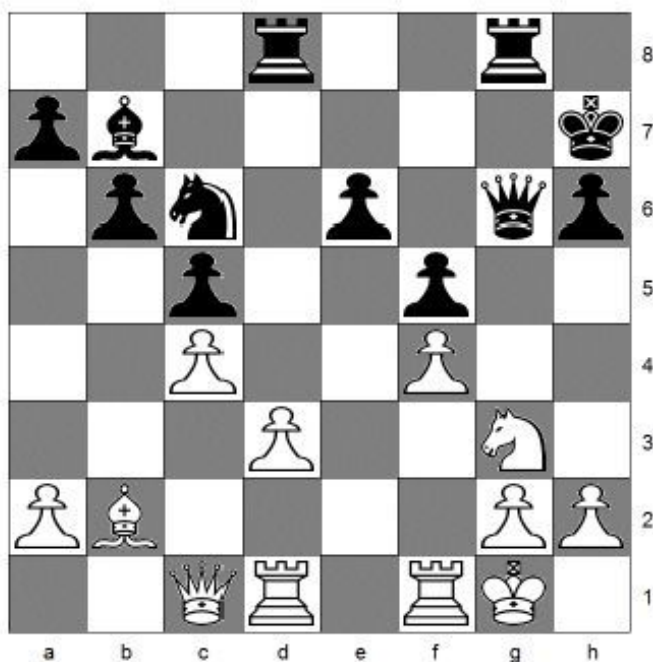
In chess, there is usually more than 1 plan that is acceptable to play so don’t be worried about getting a concrete or exact answer. It’s better to have a lousy plan than to have no plan at all.

Here are some puzzles to help you learn to plan:



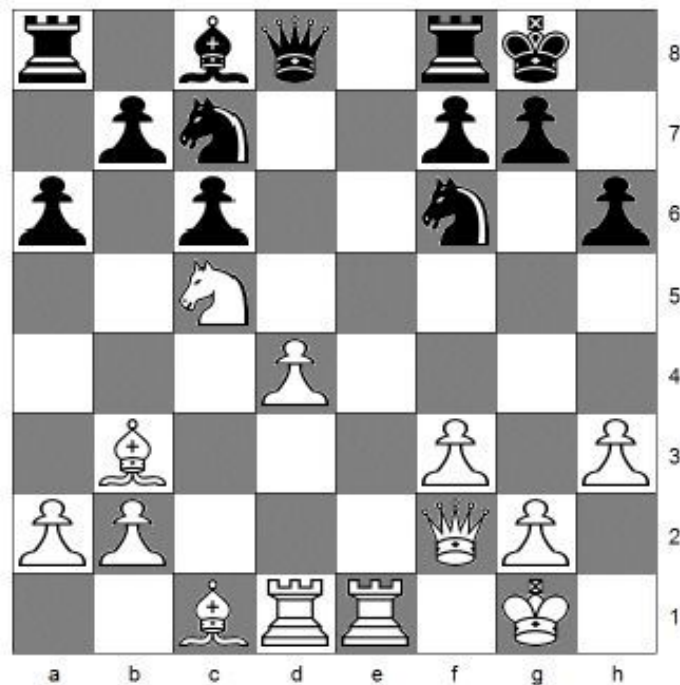
1. White to move

White's queenside has been breached by the black queen and it looks like a-pawn is about to fall as well, unless white decides to defend it with 1. Ra1. However, White's f-pawn is on the doorstep of Black's king and the white queen isn't too far away from being able to attack Black's king either. What could white play here?



2. Black to move

White's king looks deceptively safe but once the knight on g3 moves black can deliver checkmate on g2 with his queen. What can black play here?



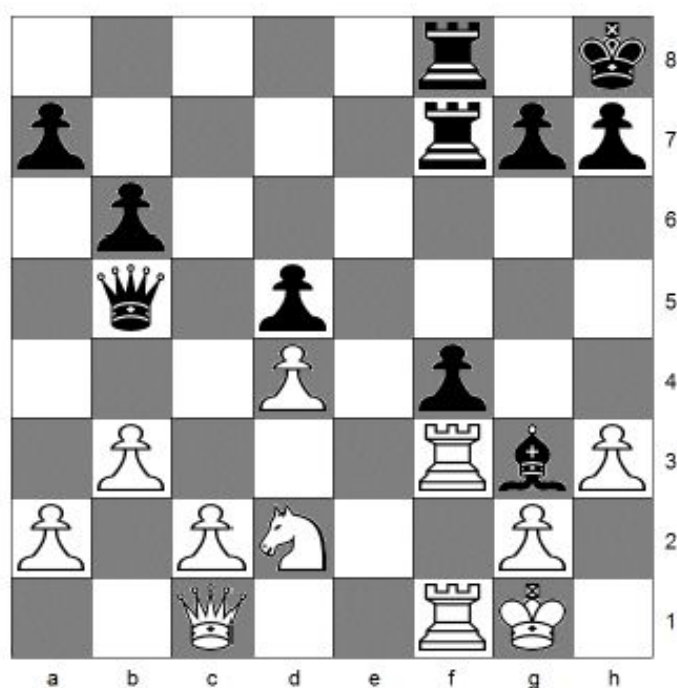
3. White to move

A good example of an isolated queen pawn position (also known as an IQP position).

In such positions, the player with the isolated pawn, in this case, white, is the attacker and black is the defender. This is because an isolated pawn is a weakness and white must attack in order to compensate for this weakness, otherwise black's slightly better pawn structure will allow him to easily take advantage. Also having an isolated pawn means more open or semi-open lines that the attacker can play on, so it makes more sense for white to attack rather than to defend.

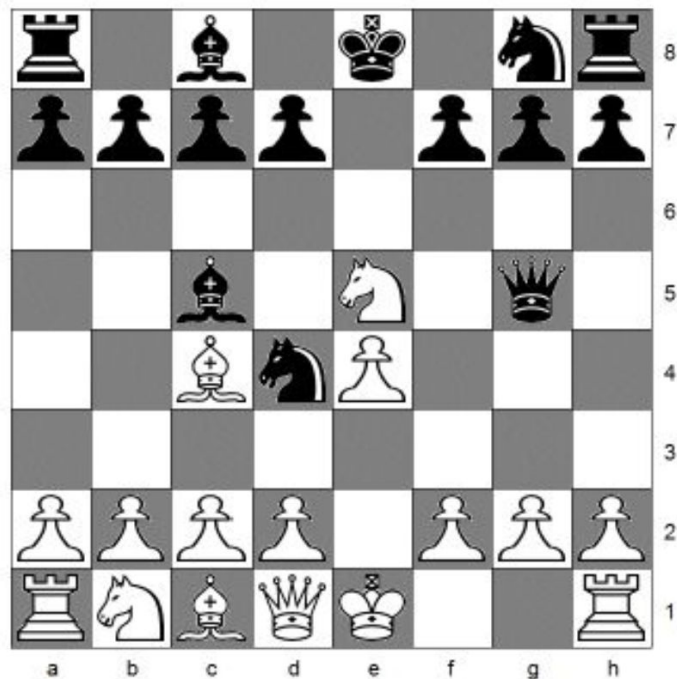
In any case, the position here looks like White is a little better here. White's pieces are well developed, the knight on c5 looks strong, the bishops are excellently positioned – pointing directly at black's kingside from a distance, the rooks occupy the central files and the king is safe. On the other hand, black is slightly under developed, the knight on c7 is awkwardly placed, and aside from having control of the d5 square, there isn't that much going on for black.

So, what can white do here?



4. White to move

Black has a powerful bishop wedged near white's king on g3 and is causing issues for white to coordinate his pieces. What can white do to get out of this slightly worse position?



5. White to move

It's only the 6th move of the game but white is already in some danger. The knight on e5 and the g2 pawn are under attack. If white decides to be a bit greedy, it might cost him the game. What are some variations here?

Tactics

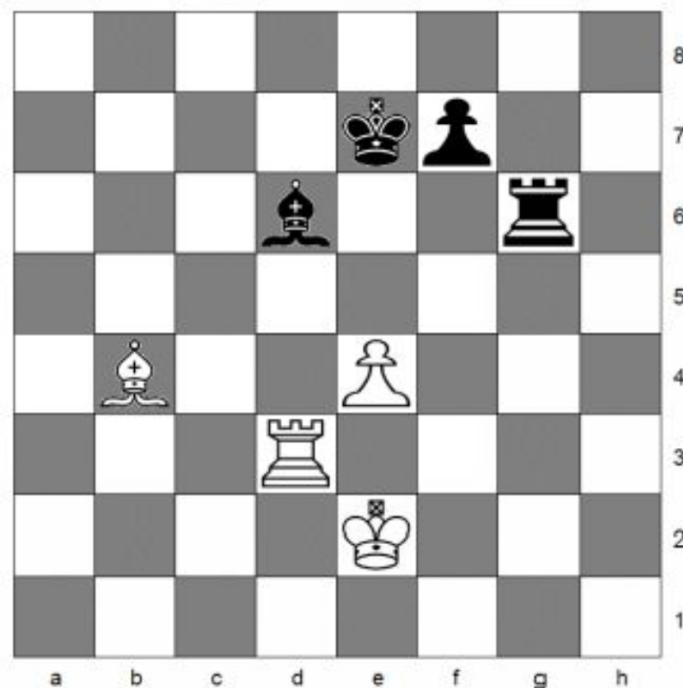
Teichmann, a German master in the early 19th century, once said that "chess is 99% tactics." Clearly an exaggeration, but in some ways, he is right – you need to be able to calculate tactical combinations carefully, no matter what style of player you are. Simply put, tactics are like the bread and butter of chess, is what I would say.

You might go through these puzzles and think, this looks very similar to the planning puzzles since it's just a random chess position and then I have to solve it right?

Well, not exactly. With planning, there isn't always a right or wrong answer, just that some answers may be better than others. However, with tactics, there is almost always a concrete answer.

I will give you some examples of what some tactical puzzles look like and their solutions:

Example 1:



1. White to move & win

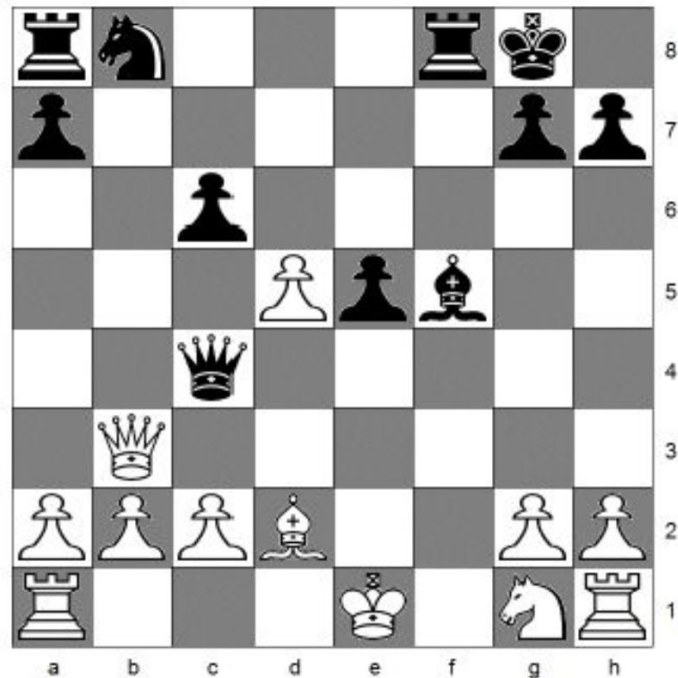
Black's bishop looks to be in serious danger but if the bishops are exchanged (1. Bxd6+, Rxd6), then the game will very likely end in a draw. However, white has a sneaky trick up his sleeve ...

1.Rxd6! (a good move that forces black to take back with the rook, otherwise he'll just be a bishop down for nothing) Rxd6 2.e5! (this move exploits the fact that black has pinned himself by taking back with the rook. Black can play any legal move here and white will simply take the rook with the pawn, leaving white a piece up and a winning endgame)

It's a good thing that the bishops weren't exchanged otherwise this trick wouldn't have been possible.

Here's another slightly harder example,

Example 2:



2. Black to move & win

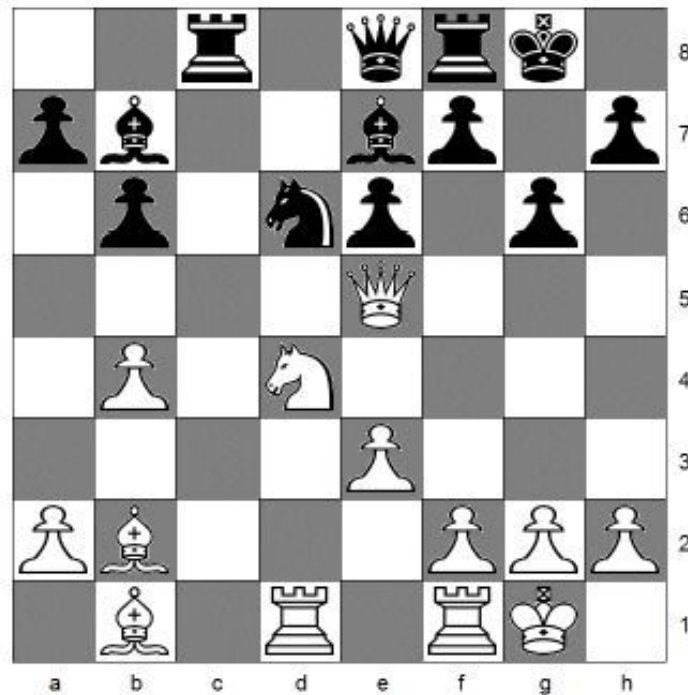
Although a pawn up, white has pretty much lost control of the center and is also behind in development with the king still stuck in the center. To make matters worse, Black also has to move. Black could just take the pawn on d5 with his c-pawn and gain complete control of the center with 2 connected passed pawns, but there is even a better move. In fact, it leads to checkmate in 3!

1... Qf1+!! (black sacrifices his queen in a forced combination)

2. Kxf1, Bd3++! (a discovered and double-check by the rook on f8 and the bishop on d3 – a very lethal move indeed)

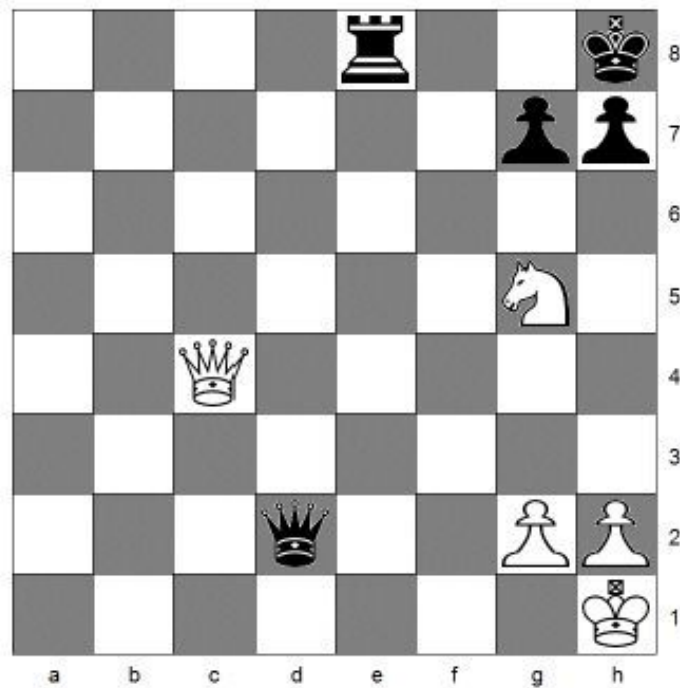
3. Ke1, Rf1# (and the white king has nowhere to run)

So here are some tactical problems to flex that chess brain of yours:



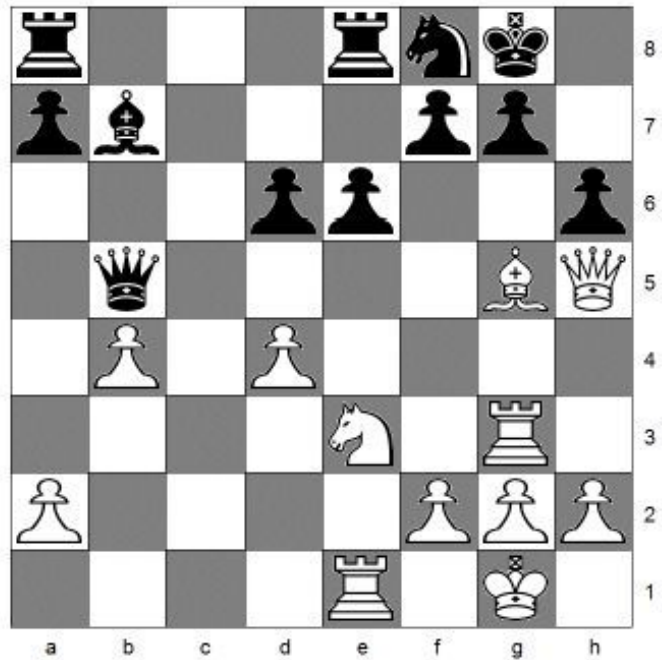
3. White to move & win

White's queen is strong in the center and the dark squares around black's king are weak. It's only a matter of time before white crashes through.



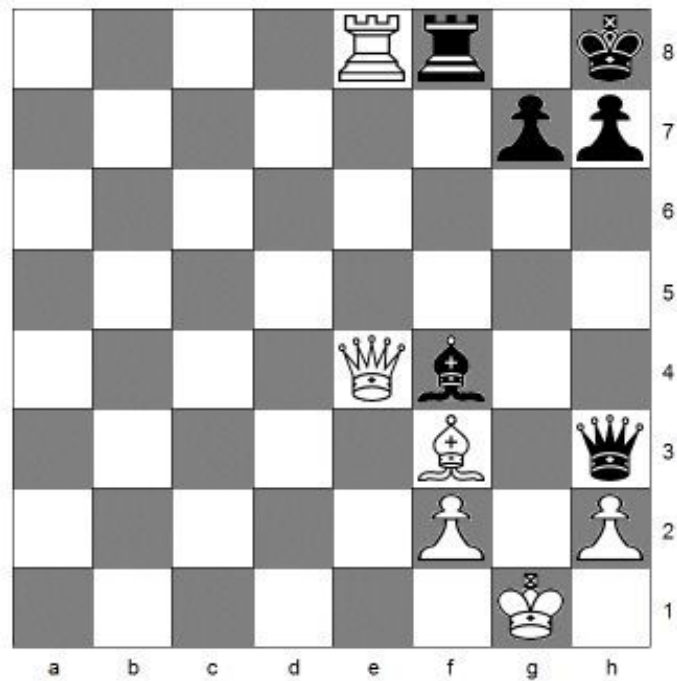
4. White to move and win

At first glance, it looks like black is winning since he is up an exchange, attacking white's knight, and is about to mate white on the back rank (aka back rank mate) with 1...Re1+. However, it is white who strikes first and turns the tables around!



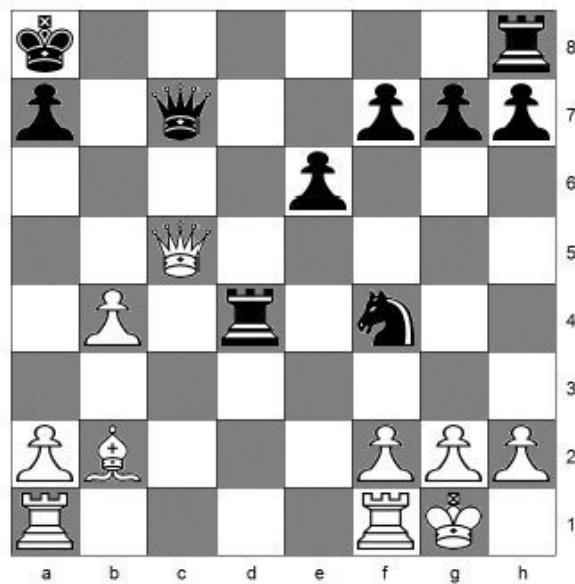
5. White to move and win

White looks like he's in trouble. His bishop is under attack and if it moves, then white's undefended queen will be ready to be taken by black's queen. So, this puts white in a real dilemma ... or does it?



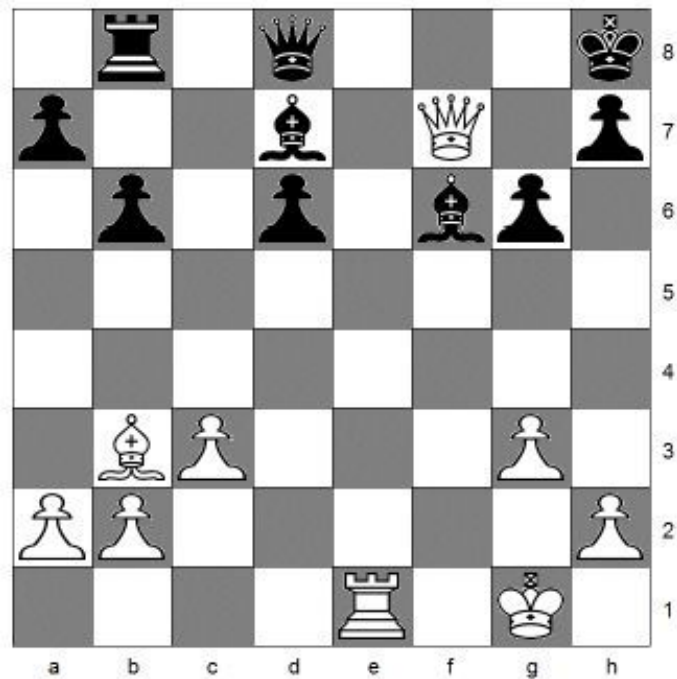
6. Black to move and win

Black looks like he is about to get mated on the back rank. On the other hand, the White's king is fairly exposed and if black can somehow find a way to exploit this, he might just save and even win the game.



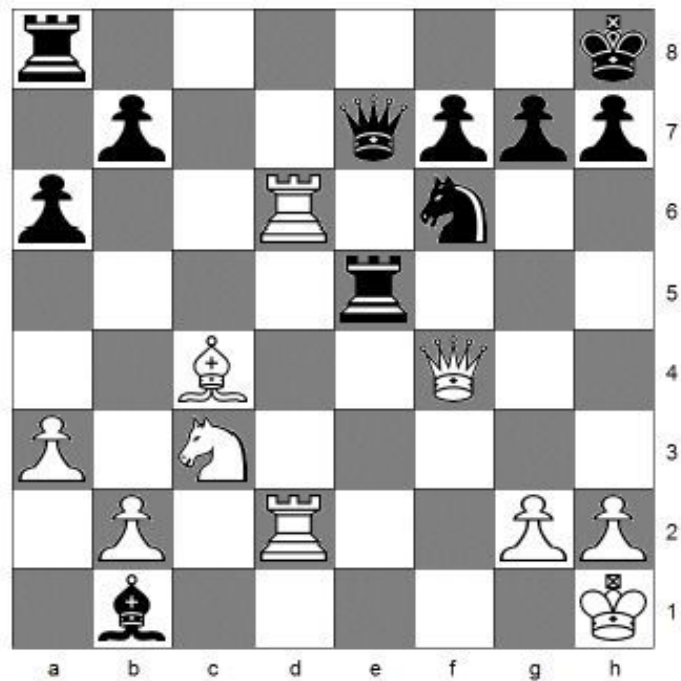
7. Black to move and win

Black's rook is under attack twice and white could win the pawn on g7 if the black rook on d4 decided to move out of the way. However, it is white who should aware of the danger ahead and not black.



8. White to move and win

White is down a full piece but his queen is dangerously close to black's king. If there was a need for white to do something in order to not lose the game, it should be now.



9. Black to move and win

A complex position with many things happening. Black is up 1 pawn but whites' pieces seem more coordinated. The only major concern for white would be his back rank as it looks a little vulnerable at the moment. Is there a way for black to exploit this?

Conclusion

I hope that you have enjoyed this book and that you are now ready to hone your chess skills. If you enjoyed this book, please share it with others so they can learn as well. To recap, chess is a game of strategy, so it's important to know the fundamentals of openings. The opening refers to the first few moves that are made before any chess game begins. The opening is a very important part of the game and it can be used to gain an advantage over your opponent. You can analyze the games of top players to learn exactly how they use the opening.

These chess tactics are generally played at all degrees of chess. Having the ability to spot these dangers is an excellent way to acquire the majority of your games and to refrain from making mistakes that may cost you the game. The further you resolve these chess approaches the greater your calculation abilities become. You'll also develop your creativity in chess and readily recognize breeding routines.

Bear in mind, good things just come out of hours of exercise. If you need to do at least 5 puzzles each day, you may greatly develop your attacking abilities in a few weeks.

Last but not least, here are the top 10 chess strategies for beginners or to every player that I would like to leave to you:

- Take your time.

Your competitor wants one to move fast. He or she also would like you to lose your queen. Take your time and discover a powerful movement.

- Do not resign!

I have never seen anyone win a game by departing. On another hand, I have seen countless stalemates when enormous armies could not finish off a lone king. Are you confident your opponent can acquire the place on the plank? Otherwise, then play!

- Practice playing with a clock.

Most scholastic chess players think they know how to play with using a clock. It's not unusual for both players to completely overlook the game at hand if a clock is set on the game. Frequently, the two players will create arbitrary appearing moves while both of them are fixated on the clock. A number of these games have been finished in just two minutes following a brief set of dreadful moves on either side. Practicing using a clock can help you to focus on the plank position over the moments remaining.

- Do not "think" together with your hand.

All big tournaments use the "touch move" rule. If you hit a bit, you need to move or catch that bit if at all possible. Players will often get a bit whilst still contemplating their movement. Frequently, they'll notice their competitor's danger after touching a bit. Oops! The Right procedure for making a move is straightforward:

- Consider and determine your move
- Create the move
- Never begin until you're completed with

- Develop your bits.

Among the additional key in Chess hints for newcomers is your "stage counts" for chess pieces are wrong. A knight is just worth 3 "points" if it's developed. The same holds for the other pieces. Attempt to maneuver each piece only 1 time at the start of the game. Try not to move pawns aside from your two center pawns unless you've got a fantastic reason. Falling behind in evolution can certainly cost the game.

- Watch out for your opponent's threats.

Your opponent's last move only jeopardized something. You can dismiss it, but your competitor just jeopardized something. I understand you're anxious to sabotage something yourself, however, he simply moved and threatened something. His hazard might be more significant than your own threat. Should you endanger mate in 1 move, you still lose if he simply threatened mate in 1 move and you did not fulfill this menace. Though a number of your competitor's threats might not be worthy of a reply, more games have been dropped by ignored one movement dangers than any other way.

- Never perform with a movement without thinking.

Your competitor just dropped his queen. If your competitor's a fantastic actor, he appears hesitant like he'd love to take the return. You've got the belief that he/she will resign whenever you choose her queen. Without thinking, you reach to your queen. Stop! The queen will still be present in a few moments. If that is a snare, you can lose the game by catching the queen. Attempt to ascertain if your competitor dropped his/her queen if he's setting a snare. Always be a little suspicious of a completely free queen.

- Make even transactions when beforehand.

As bits have exchanged, substance advantages tend to increase in importance. Just making even transactions must eventually result in a scenario where more substance could be obtained. At length, a lien may be queened and checkmate given. Do not make yourself win exactly the exact same game twice. A bit up endgame is far better than the usual attack.

- Learn basic checkmates.

You cannot win if you cannot checkmate. A king and queen could just checkmate a lone king when the king helps out. A rook together with a king can checkmate an alone warrior by forcing it to the border of the plank and creating a waiting movement at the ideal moment to pressure the opponent's king to walk to a 1 move checkmate. It's imperative to comprehend the appropriate method in these types of positions. Most winning positions could be obtained by queening a pawn and then performing the key king and queen checkmate.

- Do not get discouraged.

No matter how new you are at chess, everyone who got good at chess was in your title at the same time. You enhance more in the games that you shed than at the games you win. Maintain a wholesome mindset and ultimate mastery of the game of chess could be yours.

I hope you had enjoyed this book and you had learned a lot about chess openings. Good luck on your new journey!

2 BOOKS IN 1

CHES FOR BEGINNERS

Chess for beginners
+
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